

508 kg spurious paneer destroyed at Okhla Mandi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi government's Food Safety Department has stepped up inspections across the national capital ahead of the festive season, destroying around 508 kg of spurious paneer found at the Okhla sabzi mandi. Authorities took action as they intensify inspections across the capital ahead of the festive season, including Raksha Bandhan. Necessary legal action has been initiated under the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, and applicable rules following the seizure and destruction of the adulterated paneer.

Over the past two days, the department has lifted 22 enforcement samples of various food articles from different districts across Delhi. These samples have been sent to designated laboratories for detailed analysis, with further action to be taken based on the test reports in accordance



with food safety regulations. Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said food safety remained a priority for the Delhi government, particularly during the festive season when demand for milk products, paneer, sweets, edible oils and other food items rises significantly. "Festivals are a time of happiness and celebration, and every family has the right to enjoy festive food without worrying about its safety. The Delhi Government will take strict action against those who compromise food quality or put citizens' health

at risk. Our enforcement teams are working proactively across the city to prevent the sale of adulterated and substandard food items," Singh said. The minister said each district has been provided with dedicated teams for regular inspection, sampling and monitoring of food establishments, markets and supply points. These teams have been instructed to remain vigilant and take necessary enforcement action wherever violations are detected. With Raksha Bandhan and other upcoming festivals expected to drive up demand

for food products, particularly paneer, milk products and sweets, the department said it was maintaining heightened surveillance across the city. Similar enforcement and sampling drives are expected to continue in the coming days to ensure compliance with food safety standards.

Singh said the objective of the campaign extended beyond taking action against violations, aiming also to ensure preventive monitoring throughout the food supply chain to protect consumers and maintain public confidence in the quality and safety of food available in Delhi.

The Delhi government reiterated that strict action would be taken against individuals, manufacturers, suppliers or establishments found involved in the manufacture, storage, distribution or sale of unsafe, adulterated or substandard food items. The Food Safety Department said it would continue coordinated inspections and laboratory-

based testing across all districts in the interest of public health.

The enforcement drive at Okhla Sabzi Mandi represents one of the department's larger seizures this festive season, with officials indicating that similar operations are being carried out simultaneously across other markets and food supply points in the city.

Officials said the timing of the intensified drive was deliberate, aimed at curbing the circulation of adulterated food products during a period when consumption of dairy-based items and sweets typically peaks due to festival-related demand. The department's enforcement teams are expected to continue targeting wholesale markets, retail outlets and manufacturing units over the coming weeks as part of the broader festive season monitoring exercise, with test results from the 22 samples collected so far expected to guide further legal action against any establishments found in violation of food safety norms.

Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board launches cleanliness drive at Azadpur, Okhla Mandis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board has launched an intensive, round-the-clock cleanliness and anti-encroachment drive at Azadpur Mandi and Okhla Sub-Mandi. The drive is launched as part of the Chief Minister's "Delhi Ko Kude Se Azadi, Swachhata Abhiyan 2026" campaign running from August 17 to October 2, 2026.

To carry out the drive, the Board has deployed a special task force comprising Junior Engineers, Assistant Engineers and Executive Engineers to monitor cleanliness and garbage disposal work across morning, evening and night shifts. Deputy Secretary Deepak Sareen has been appointed Nodal Officer for the campaign, tasked with ensuring administrative control and accountability. Sareen has warned that immediate and severe disciplinary action will be taken under a relevant service rules against any officer or employee found negligent or disregarding orders.

The Board has taken a strict stance against infrastructure deficiencies within the mandi premises and against those found spreading filth. Executive Engineers and Assistant Engineers are conducting daily inspections to ensure potholes are repaired immediately and that no sewer or manhole cover remains broken or missing. Strict



instructions have also been issued for imposing immediate cash fines on anyone caught littering or spreading filth on the premises.

A mandatory special cleanliness and anti-encroachment drive was conducted across the entire mandi premises on Sunday, August 23, yielding what officials described as highly positive results in both mandi yards. Teams carried out intensive cleaning of main roads, internal lanes and auction platforms using machines and personnel across the Sabzi Mandi Azadpur, Fruit Mandi Azadpur and Okhla Mandi areas. Fruit and vegetable waste was removed immediately with the help of a fleet of tractors and tippers, while a special night shift was deployed to ensure the mandi remained clean before morning trade began.

As part of monsoon preparedness, desilting work was completed at sensitive locations across stormwater drains, gully traps and sewer lines to prevent waterlogging, with additional pumps and personnel deployed at these sites. The Board has also begun identifying and replacing damaged manhole covers

to prevent future accidents. Alongside the cleanliness drive, significant action was taken against illegal encroachment, leading to major improvements in mandi management.

The entire premises of Shed No. 13 were cleared of illegal street vendors and hawkers, following which 10 cleared auction sites were handed over to apple traders, with fencing installed at the remaining spots.

Enforcement and security teams also removed illegal vendors operating between Gate No. 1 of NSM and the A-Block police chowki, with encroached structures including illegal carts, rickshaws, tables and chairs demolished on the spot using a JCB machine. In a gesture of social responsibility, all fresh fruits and vegetables seized from illegal vendors during the campaign were donated to local orphanages, according to the Board.

The Delhi Agricultural Marketing Board has appealed to all traders, commission agents and visitors to extend full cooperation in keeping what it described as Asia's largest wholesale market clean, hygienic and well organised.

LG directs action on unused parking, security in Narela

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday directed officials to operationalise unused parking spaces in the city and enhance police presence in Narela. Chairing a coordination meeting with senior officers, Sandhu called for functioning as a "whole of government."

The meeting was attended by the Delhi government chief secretary

and principal secretary (home), Delhi Police commissioner, principal director of Delhi Fire Services, Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) additional commissioners, and Delhi Development Authority (DDA) vice chairman, according to a statement from the Lieutenant Governor's office.

Sandhu underlined the need for a "whole of government" approach, saying all agencies must work in close coordination rather than in silos,



particularly in matters requiring swift, joint action on the ground.

The meeting deliberated a range of issues, including parking-related challenges, encroach-

ments, fire preparedness and several other areas that require coordination between the MCD, DDA and Delhi Police.

Sandhu highlighted the need to increase out-

reach in schools and directed that the connect with teachers and students be strengthened as part of ongoing civic and safety initiatives like the enforcement of PCSCO guidelines.

Regarding parking, Sandhu instructed that unused parking sites across the city be made operational as soon as possible and stressed the development of multi-level parking facilities to alleviate the increasing pressure on available space.

He provided specific directions to the Delhi Police to enhance their presence and ensure security in the rapidly developing Narela area. Furthermore, he instructed the MCD to ensure proper civic amenities in that region. The meeting also addressed the demarcation and designation of vending areas, along with the timely completion of vendor surveys and the establishment of Town Vending Committees by the MCD.

SOUTHERN STAR CO-OP. (U) T/C SOCIETY LTD.

Corp. Off.: Star Tower, DDA Market, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi-60

Phone : 011-44424444, 011-28741800-01

e-mail : sstarsociety@yahoo.com, website : southernstar.org

GSTIN: 07AACAS4763M1Z1

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

The pledgors, in specific and the public, in general, are hereby notified that public auction of the gold ornaments pledged in the below accounts is proposed to be conducted at the Corporate office at New Rajendra Nagar on 30-08-2026, Sunday, from 12:00 noon onwards. The Gold ornaments being auctioned have been pledged by various borrowers who have failed to close the loan account and redeem the pledged gold ornaments despite being notified by letters send by the registered post/speed post. The list of pledges taken up for auction has also been displayed at the corporate office and the respective branches. Please note that the items remaining un-auctioned shall be auctioned on any other date without further notice. Changes, if any, in the venue and date of auction shall be displayed at the venue on the date of action mentioned above and no further notice regarding the change of date and venue shall be issued.

List of pledges:-

BH-6729 SURESH,CK. 6691,6773 EMILSON DOMINIC,6699 TINSO AC. MV-21461 MANU DAS PV-7239,7243,7244,7267,7268, HQ-15299 ABHILASH NAIR

Persons wishing to participate in the above auction shall do so. Terms& conditions apply.

Date.: 22 -08-2026

s/d

(P.N. VENIKIDESWARAN POTTY)

Hony. Secretary

VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD

Unit 203 & 204, 2nd Floor, "A" Wing, Navbharat Estate, Zakaria Bunder Road, Sewri (West), Mumbai 400015, Maharashtra.

CIN No.: U65922MH2005PLC272501

POSSESSION NOTICE

Whereas, The undersigned being the Authorised Officer of Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred in him under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued a Demand Notice calling upon the borrowers mentioned herein below to repay the amount mentioned in therespective notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers having failed to repay the amount, undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the date mentioned below.

The borrower and guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited Branch for an amount metioned as below and interest thereon, costs etc.

S N	Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower and LAN No.	Date & Amount of Demand Notice	Description of Property	Date & Type of Possession
1	Govinda . (Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Varsha Kumari (Co Borrower) HLO000000165324	16-May-26 Rs.306489/- as on 12-May-26	All That Part And Parcel Of The Immovable Property Situated At, Vacant Plot Of Land Area Measuring 41.85 Sq. Meter, Situated At Village Iradatnagar, Tehsil Kheragarh Agra Uttar Pradesh, 283112 Boundaries As Follows: North – Plot Of Manju Devi South – Khet Of Bhagwandas East – Rasta 12 Feet West – House Of Maniram	Symbolic Possession Taken on 19-Aug-26
2	Munesh . (Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Sujan Singh(Co Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Kusma (Co Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Sonvir Singh (Guarantor) MHL000000179885	16-May-26 Rs.664140/- as on 12-May-26	All that part and parcel of the Immoveable property situated at, Measuring area 108.96 sqm. Plot no. 12 Bihu Garden Colony Kharsa no. 36 44 Mauza Koyla Alipur Khadar Tehsil Dist. Mathura, East 37 feet 8 inches, West 34 feet, North 32 feet 9 inches, South 32 feet 9 inches, total area 130.33 square yards equal to 108.96 square meters, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, 281006 Boundaries as follows: North – Land of Tulsiram South – Plot no. 13 East – Plot no. 37 West – Road 18 feet wide	Symbolic Possession Taken on 21-Aug-26
3	Hemlata . (Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Arun Singh (Co Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Kanchan Singh (Co Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Bismbar Dayal (Guarantor) MHL000000166711	16-May-26 Rs.1279869/- as on 12-May-26	All that part and parcel of the Immoveable property situated at, Measuring area 197.88 sqm. Part of Plot no. 21 Apna Nagar Extension Kharsa no. 164 Mauza Palikheada Tehsil Dist. Mathura, measured East one side 15 feet and the other side 25 feet, West 40 feet, North one side 30 feet and the other side 42 feet, South 72 feet total area 83.33 sqare yards equal to 69.67 square meters,Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, 281004 Boundaries as follows: North – Plot no. 20 and part of plot no. 21 South – Plot no. 22 East – Road 6 mtr West – Land of others	Symbolic Possession Taken on 21-Aug-26
4	Ravi Kumar (Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Laxmi .(Co Borrower), Mr/Mrs. Lokesh (Guarantor) LP0000000185932	16-May-26 Rs.421365/- as on 12-May-26	All that part and parcel of the Immoveable property situated at, Part Of Plot No. 919, Area Measuring 83.61 Sq. Mtrs., Situated At Mauja Akbarpur, Tehsil Chhata Distt., Mathura, U.p., 281406 Boundaries as follows: North – Road 12 Ft. Wide South – Property Vinod East – Open Plot Others West – Property Sonu	Symbolic Possession Taken on 21-Aug-26
Date : 25.08.2026 Place : Agra, Mathura				Authorised officer Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd

CONTINENTAL CHEMICALS LIMITED

CIN : L24173UP1984PLC011111

Regd. Office: A-7, Sector - VII, NOIDA, Distt.: Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P., Pin - 201301

Website : www.continentalchemicalsltd.com; Email: info@continentalsoft.com; Ph. No: 91-120-2423316

NOTICE OF THE 41st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, BOOK CLOSURE & E-VOTING INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that the Forty-First (41st) Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of Continental Chemicals Limited ("Company") will be held on Friday, September 18, 2026 at 04.00 P.M. IST, through Video Conferencing ("VC")/Other Audio Video Means ("OAVM") facility, without the physical presence of the Members at the meeting, in compliance with all applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the Rules made thereunder and SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 read with Circular no. No. 14/2020 dated April 8, 2020, Circular No. 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, Circular No. 20/2020 dated May 5, 2020, Circular No. 02/2022 dated May 05, 2022, General Circular No. 9/2023 dated September 25, 2023, Circular No. 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024 and latest being General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") and SEBI circular no. SEBI/HO/CFD/CMD/1/CIR/P/2020/79 dated May 12, 2020, SEBI/HO/CFD/CMD/2/CIR/PP/2022/62 dated May 13, 2022, SEBI/HO/CFD/POD-2/P/CIR/2023/4 dated January 5, 2023, SEBI/HO/CFD/CFD-POD-2/P/CIR/2023/167 dated October 7, 2023 and SEBI/HO/CFD/CFD-POD-2/P/CIR/2024/133 dated October 03, 2024 (collectively referred to as "SEBI Circulars") and Master Circular SEBI/HO/CFD/POD/2/CIR/P/2023/120 dated July 11, 2023 (MCA Circulars and SEBI Circulars collectively referred as "Circulars"), to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice of the AGM dated 21st August, 2026.

The venue of the meeting shall be deemed to be the Registered Office of the Company. Members participating through VCOAVM shall be reckoned for the purpose of quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013. The facility for appointment of proxies by the Members will not be available since this AGM is being held through VC/OAVM.

In Compliance with the provisions of Regulation 44 of SEBI(Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with rule 20 of the companies (Management and Administration) Rules 2014, the Company is pleased to provide its shareholders the facility to cast their vote by electronic means in respect of the agenda items enlisted in the AGM notice through e-voting facility provided by CDSL. The date of completion of sending notices is 24th August, 2026 through electronic means to those whose email address is registered with the company/Depository Participant(s)/RTA in compliance with the above mentioned circulars. The copy of the notice is also available on the Company's website at www.continentalchemicalsltd.com, website of the Stock Exchange i.e. BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com. Additionally, as per Regulation 36(1) (b) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, Company is also sending a letter through Post providing the web-link of the Annual Report for financial year 2025-26 to those shareholder(s) who have not registered their email address with the Company/Depositories/RTA.

The e-voting period commences on Tuesday 15th September, 2026 (09:00 AM) and ends on Thursday 17th September, 2026 (5.00 PM). The e-voting module shall be disabled by CDSL for voting there after. During this period members of the Company, holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form, as on the cut-off date of 11th September 2026, may cast their vote electronically. Any person who acquires shares of the Company and become member of the Company after dispatch of the notice of AGM and holding shares as on cut-off date may cast their vote by following instructions and process of remote e-voting as provided in notice of AGM. Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, the member shall not be allowed to change it subsequently. The e-voting facility is available at the <https://www.evotingindia.com>.

Members are requested to refer to instruction for e-voting forming part of AGM Notice (available at company's website). Regarding process and manner for e-voting by electronic means, in case of any queries or issue regarding e-voting, members may also refer "frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)" and e-voting user manual for Shareholders to cast their vote" in help section at <https://www.evotingindia.com> or write an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com.

The Members who have already casted their vote by remote e-Voting prior to the AGM may also attend/ participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again through a-Voting at the AGM.

Notice is further given that the Register of members and Share Transfer Books of the Company shall remain closed from Saturday, 12.09.2026 to Friday, 18.09.2026 (both day inclusive) for the purpose of Annual General Meeting in pursuant to provisions of section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and clause 42 of the SEBI(Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

B.S. Goyal practicing Company secretary (FCS-4204, C.P. NO:2915), New Delhi is appointed as Scrutinizer for conducting e-voting process in fair and transparent manner. The result of voting on resolutions set out in the Notice of the AGM shall be declared within 2 working days of conclusion of the AGM. The results declared along with the report of the Scrutinizer shall be placed on the website of the Company www.continentalchemicalsltd.com and on the website CDSL immediately after the declaration of result by the chairman or a person authorized by him and result also be communicated to the Stock Exchange. The Result shall be displayed at the registered office of the Company A-7, Sector -7, Noida - 201301.

Member(s) are requested to keep their e-mail ID validated with their DPR&TA, so as to receive all communication electronically including annual report, notices, circulars etc sent by the Company from time to time. R&TA designated e-mail ID beetalra@gmail.com (BEETAL Financial & Computer Services Pvt Ltd. BEETAL HOUSE, 3rd Floor,99, Madangir, behind LSC, New Delhi - 110062) to facilitate the member(s) to register their request/complaints, if any.

Detailed process and manner of remote e-Voting, e-Voting at the AGM and instructions for attending the AGM through VC/OAVM is being provided in the Notice of the AGM.

If you have any queries or issues regarding attending AGM & e-Voting from the CDSL e-Voting System, you can write an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact at 1800 21 09911

For CONTINENTAL CHEMICALS LIMITED

Sd/-

Naresh Kumar Chhibba

Managing Director

DIN 00376963

Place: Noida

Date: August 24, 2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client, i.e. Yes Bank Ltd. that, Angel Education Society, Jaipur is the owner of Property measuring 7 Kanal 11 Bua comprised in Khawat No.12min Khatooni No.12min Rect. No.136 Killa No.281(1-15), 21(3-16) Situated at Village Baron Jhajar Tehsil & Distt. Jhajar Haryana; by virtue of Sale Deed dt.20.11.1996 (Doc No. 1972). Has lost/ misplaced Above Sale deed registration No. 1972, all persons are hereby informed that above mentioned owner wants to mortgage the said property & intends to obtain loan from our client against the said property if anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property, its sale/ mortgage/litigation & any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, 2nd Flr., 25, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-11
Legal@hnategal.com Ph: 011-41112627-28

NORTHERN RAILWAY

(E-Auction Notice)

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/G. Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for allotment of Misc contracts of NFR at following railway stations:

E-Catalogue No	Type of Asset	Station	Date & Time for e-auction
Advt-Sept-02-26	Unipole OOH	Cluster-B	Start: 07.09.2026 at 11:00 hrs
Advt-Sept-02-26	Vinyl Stickers/ Wrapping Exterior	Train No. 14041/42	Start: 07-09-2026 at 11:00 hrs

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen.

<https://ireps.gov.in/> (E-Auction-Leasing)

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Indro Devi, Mother of- No.10136869A Lnk Naveen, R/o- Vill- Kalai, PO- Mandholi Khurd, Teh- Siwani, Dist- Bhiwani, Haryana- 127046, have changed my name from Indro Devi to Indro, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Vitthal, Father of No.17030167X Sep Giri Somnath Vitthal, R/o- VPO- Pangri(MA), Teh- Shirur(Kasar), Dist- Beed, Maharashtra- 413229, have changed my name from Vitthal to Vitthal Shamgir Giri, vide affidavit dated 18/08/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

I, Manda, Mother of No.17030167X Sep Giri Somnath Vitthal, R/o- VPO- Pangri(MA), Teh- Shirur(Kasar), Dist- Beed, Maharashtra- 413229, have changed my name from Manda to Mandabai Vitthal Giri, vide affidavit dated 18/08/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

I, No.15426583L Hav G Srinivas, R/o- 2-200, Linegadda, Chennai, Dist- Adilabad, Andhra Pradesh- 504201, declare that in my service documents my father's name is wrongly written as Lingaiah, whereas his correct name is Chinnallalingaiah Gujja, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.15426583L Hav G Srinivas, R/o- 2-200, Linegadda, Chennai, Dist- Adilabad, Andhra Pradesh- 504201, declare that in my service documents my mother's name is wrongly written as G Posamma, whereas her correct name is Posakka Gujja, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Sar Kaur, Mother of- No.16015836X Hav Shailendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Ureeka, Dist- Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan- 333033, have changed my name from Ishar Devi to Sar Kaur, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Amar Singh, Father of JC-473668A Nb Sub Sanjay Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Govindpur, Shahjahanpur, Tilhar, U.P.- 242303, have changed my name from Amar Singh to Avdhendra Pratap Singh, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Bijendra Singh, Father of JC-474209N Nb Sub Manoj Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Saray Daud, Teh & Dist- Mathura, U.P.- 281308, have changed my name from Bijendra Singh to Vijendra Singh, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Anita Devi, Mother of JC-473668A Nb Sub Sanjay Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Govindpur, Shahjahanpur, Tilhar, U.P.- 242303, have changed my name from Anita Devi to Anita Singh, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Meena Devi, Mother of JC-474209N Nb Sub Manoj Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Saray Daud, Teh & Dist- Mathura, U.P.- 281308, have changed my name from Meena Devi to Meena Kumari, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Mamatesh Devi, W/o- No.16015836X Hav Shailendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Ureeka, Dist- Jhunjhunu, Rajasthan- 333033, have changed my name from Mamtesh to Mamatesh Devi, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Kiran Kumari Devi, W/o- No.15783004L Hav (GNR) Santosh Kumar, R/o- Vill- Kamlawari Dhaultol, PO- Kamlawari, P.S- Jaynagar, Dist- Madhubani, Bihar- 847226, have changed my name from Kiran Kumari Devi to Kiran Kumari, vide affidavit dated 24/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Baria Jibhasinh Shanabhai, Father of No.16027028M LNK Baria Rameshkumar Jibhasinh of 6 Raj Rif R/o- Vill- Talav Faliyur, Dhakaliya, TA- Shahera, Dist- Panchmahal, Gujarat- 389210 declare that in my Son's service record my name & DOB is wrongly recorded as Baria Jibhasinh 08.07.1971 whereas my correct name & DOB is Baria Jibhasinh Shanabhai 01.01.1971 which may be amended accordingly.

I, Baria Manjulaben Jibhasinh, Mother of No.16027028M LNK Baria Rameshkumar Jibhasinh of 6 Raj Rif R/o- Vill- Talav Faliyur, Dhakaliya, TA- Shahera, Dist- Panchmahal, Gujarat- 389210 declare that in my Son's service record my DOB is wrongly recorded as 01.01.1971 whereas my correct DOB is 01.01.1972 which may be amended accordingly.

I, Meraj Idrisi S/o Salamudin Idrisi R/o Deepak Vihar, Khora Colony, Gaziabad, U.P. hereby solemnly affirms and declare that my name Wrongly mentioned as Salim alam in my Aadhar card. both Salim Alam & Meraj Idrisi are same and one person. It will be known by this name in the future.

Seven held for fake CBI raids, extortion bid in *Special 26*-style con

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police said on Monday that they arrested seven people for pretending to be CBI officers and carrying out fake raids to extort money and valuables in Delhi and Mumbai. Among those arrested are a former bar singer, a former banker, and a woman who used to run a hotel.

It was straight out of the popular Bollywood movie *Special 26*. All those involved in the fake CBI raid at a businessman's residence in Prashant Vihar had copied the roles of various characters. They wore black clothes and showed what appeared to be CBI identity cards. They threatened a businessman and his mother with a raid, but left when neighbours stepped in and the family asked for proof of identity.



The people arrested are Asifa (29), from Jammu and Kashmir; Pooja Aggarwal, a former bar singer; Kuldeep Sharma (63), a former bank worker; Chander Prakash Sharma (38), a former electronics repairman; Shubham (also known as Golu) (25),

Rajveer Singh (21), and Nitin Sharma (30), who are all currently unemployed.

"The case was cracked through analysis of CCTV footage, electronic evidence, technical surveillance and a purported CBI notice sent to the complainant's father,"

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said.

The incident happened at 10 pm on August 11, when businessman Pratham Aggarwal and his mother were at home in Prashant Vihar. About eight people,

six men and two women, showed up and said they were CBI officials.

They showed identity cards and said they were there to conduct a raid. When asked for proper authorisation or a search warrant, the group tried to scare Aggarwal and

his mother, according to police.

Police said the suspects stayed outside the house for about 90 minutes. When neighbours got involved, the group said they had sent a notice to Aggarwal's father and left, saying they would get it from their car. The family then called the police helpline.

"A fake CBI notice was also sent to Aggarwal's father on his mobile phone. Though the original message was later deleted, the family had retained a screenshot, which became part of the investigation," the officer said.

Police said an FIR was registered at Prashant Vihar police station on August 19 under sections 308(2) (extortion), 351(2) (criminal intimidation) and 61(2) (criminal conspiracy) of the BNS.

Police reviewed CCTV

footage and digital evidence to find out who was involved. Asifa, who used to run a hotel in Rajendra Place before it closed for financial reasons, said she knew people in the police and Army.

About eight months ago, she met Kuldeep Sharma at a family wedding, where she and Pooja claimed to have connections with the CBI. Kuldeep, a former bank worker, had met the complainant through his job and gave Asifa and Pooja information about the complainant, his home, and the possible presence of cash or valuables, according to the DCP.

Police said Pooja organised the raid by telling her brother-in-law, Chander Prakash Sharma, to find others to impersonate CBI officers.

Chander arrived with Shubham, Rajveer, Nitin, and additional associates. Police

are verifying the identities of two Sikh men who were also present.

Police said they found CBI-looked clothing from Chander and images of fake identity cards on mobile phones. Chander had contacted others to join the fake raids, and he and Asifa paid them for each job. Police seized eight mobile phones, which had images of fake identity cards and photos and videos of the group dressed as Government officials.

The investigation found evidence that the group may have done similar fake raids elsewhere. Videos from phones suggest they carried out several raids in Delhi and Mumbai, posing as CBI officials and members of other Government agencies, such as the Enforcement Directorate.



Left to right commuters waded through the waterlogged Zakhira railway underpass following rainfall; People move on a waterlogged area following rainfall at Sangam Vihar and students play at Kartavya Path amid monsoon showers in New Delhi on Monday. The weather office issued a red alert for heavy rain and a yellow alert for moderate rain across several districts, with thunderstorms, lightning and winds of 30-40 kmph also expected in parts of the city.

Gurugram administration issues WFH advisory, online classes after heavy rain triggers waterlogging

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The Gurugram administration on Monday advised corporate offices to allow employees to work from home on Tuesday and ordered Government and private schools and educational institutions to conduct classes online in view of heavy rainfall and the possibility of waterlogging and traffic congestion.

The advisory was issued after around an hour of heavy rainfall inundated several parts of the city on Monday, slowing traffic on the Delhi-Gurugram Expressway and key roads and leaving school buses and ambulances stranded at several locations.

Uttam Singh, Deputy Commissioner and chairperson of the District Disaster Management Authority, said the work-from-home advisory for corporate and private offices would remain in effect on August 25.

The decision was aimed at reducing traffic congestion and facilitating repair and maintenance work on roads and drains by civic agencies,



Vehicles remain stuck in a traffic jam on a waterlogged road following heavy rainfall in Gurugram, Haryana on Monday

an official statement said.

The administration subsequently amended the advisory to direct all Government and private schools and educational institutions in the district to conduct classes online on Tuesday, citing the safety of students and staff and the likelihood of traffic congestion due to waterlogging.

The downpour caused waterlogging in Narsinghpur, Hero Honda Chowk, Rajiv Chowk, IFFCO Chowk and several areas of old Gurugram. Vehicles were stuck in water around Rajiv Chowk, while school buses and ambulances were also

caught in waterlogging on Sohna Road.

The district administration said Gurugram received 70 mm of rainfall by 1.30 pm. Rajiv Chowk, IFFCO Chowk, Railway Road, Sector 5, Old Delhi Road, Mehrauli Road and Basai Road were among the areas heavily affected. Naharpur underpass was also waterlogged.

School buses remained stranded for several hours at some locations, including near Rail Vihar in Sector 47 and Subash Chowk, prompting residents to raise concerns over the situation on social media.

On X, one resident said their child had been stuck in a bus for over four hours, while another criticised the authorities and called for an overhaul of the system. A third user said residents had been highlighting the city's waterlogging problem for years but "nothing has changed".

Traffic movement on several roads remained slow, with commuters seen wading through flooded streets. Waterlogging in parts of old Gurugram, including Sadar Bazar, Gurdwara Road and Old Delhi Road, led to traffic jams till afternoon.

A senior traffic police officer said vehicular movement was choked near the Sirhaul border, Rajiv Chowk, Narsinghpur and some other locations. Traffic police personnel were deployed to manage the situation.

Gurugram Traffic Police also used drones to monitor waterlogged areas and major roads during the rainfall, officials said. The aerial surveillance helped assess traffic conditions, identify sensitive locations and issue directions to personnel deployed on the ground.

71-year-old woman killed, husband injured as SUV hits multiple vehicles in South Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 71-year-old woman was killed and her husband injured after an electric SUV allegedly rammed into several vehicles before hitting the elderly couple near Kailash Colony Metro Station in south Delhi on Sunday, police said. The accused driver, identified as Tapan Ahir, 59, allegedly hit a Mahindra Thar, an autorickshaw and a cycle rickshaw before knocking down the couple, according to police.

Police said a PCR call about the accident was received at the Greater Kailash-1 police station, following which officers reached the spot and shifted the injured couple to Moolchand Hospital.

The woman, identified as Shashi, was declared brought dead at the hospital. Her husband, Kulbhushan, 65, who had also sustained injuries in the accident, was later declared fit to give a statement, police said.

According to the DCP, South District, Ahir has been working as a driver with the same vehicle owner since



1997. He was driving the SUV, a Mahindra XEV 9e, to pick up his brother from Kailash Colony Market at the time of the accident, police said.

Ahir's blood sample has been sent to the Forensic Science Laboratory to determine whether he was under the influence of alcohol when the accident occurred, according to police.

A case has been registered under Sections 281, 125(a) and 106 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, covering rash driving, acts endangering the life or safety

of others, and causing death by negligence. The accused driver has been arrested, and further investigation is underway, police said.

Police have not yet disclosed the exact sequence in which the SUV struck the other vehicles before hitting the couple, nor have they specified the extent of damage caused to the Thar, the autorickshaw and the cycle rickshaw involved in the accident.

The condition of Kulbhushan's injuries following the accident has also

not been detailed by police beyond confirming that he was later found fit to record his statement.

Results of the forensic examination on Ahir's blood sample are awaited, and police have not indicated when the report is expected.

The accident occurred in a busy stretch near the Kailash Colony Metro Station, an area that sees heavy vehicular and pedestrian movement through the day.

Police said the investigation would examine the circumstances leading to the SUV hitting multiple vehicles in succession before the fatal collision with the pedestrian couple.

Details on whether the vehicle owner, who has employed Ahir since 1997, faces any separate scrutiny in connection with the incident have not been made public by police.

The case remains under investigation, with police expected to record further statements and examine evidence, including footage from the area if available, to establish the exact cause of the accident.

Capital gets 1,914 new polling stations after rationalisation exercise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi's polling station count has risen from 13,033 to 14,947, an increase of 1,914 stations. The number of polling-station locations in the city, which has 70 Assembly constituencies, has also increased from 2,696 to 2,856. The new polling station was added following a rationalisation exercise carried out across all 70 assembly constituencies of the national capital.

The exercise was carried out as part of the Special Intensive Revision 2026. Rationalisation was undertaken in view of the Election Commission's (EC) decision to reduce the limit of 1,500 electors per polling station to 1,200 electors per polling station in view of voters' convenience.

As per data shared by the chief electoral office (CEO), South West district's polling stations rose from 1,187 to 1,351, and North West district's count went up from 1,248 to 1,403, according to the data. East district recorded an increase from 1,333 to 1,543, while South district rose from 1,124 to 1,367. Central North district saw its polling stations



increase from 768 to 863, and Outer North district's count rose from 904 to 975.

North district's polling stations went up from 873 to 971, while Central district increased from 633 to 682. Old Delhi district recorded a rise from 541 to 642 polling stations, the smallest increase in absolute terms among all districts. New Delhi district saw the least change, with polling stations rising marginally from 208 to 214. District-wise data released with the note showed North East district recording the highest number of polling stations after rationalisation, rising from 1,585 to 1,829. West district followed, with polling stations increasing from 1,390 to 1,543, while South East district saw an

increase from 1,239 to 1,564.

The rationalisation began with physical verification of existing polling station locations by senior officers appointed by District Election Officers, who assessed the feasibility of current sites for conducting future elections in Delhi.

New polling station locations were identified during the process, and new stations were created strictly in line with Election Commission guidelines. Electors were shifted to adjacent or newly created polling stations wherever the elector count at a station exceeded 1,200, to bring numbers within the revised limit.

Meetings were held with recognised political parties by Electoral Registration Officers

at the assembly constituency level and by District Election Officers at the district level, to seek their suggestions during the rationalisation process.

The number of polling station locations across Delhi also increased from 2,696 to 2,856 during the exercise, according to the data. North East district recorded the highest number of polling station locations after rationalisation, at 321, followed by West district at 316.

New Delhi, Central and Central North districts recorded no change in the number of polling station locations, at 87, 140 and 166 respectively, even as the number of polling stations within these districts increased. The Chief Electoral Officer's note stated that the objective of the exercise was to ensure no eligible citizen is left out while no ineligible person is included in the electoral roll.

Under the SIR exercise, more than 47 lakh voters out of 1.45 crore are going to be removed from the draft electoral rolls to be published on August 31. The enumeration forms of these voters were marked "unlocatable" during the door-to-door verification exercise that concluded on August 17.

NDMC unveils civic plan for BRICS Summit



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has drawn up an extensive civic preparedness plan for the upcoming BRICS Summit, with round-the-clock sanitation, tighter monitoring, road repairs and extensive beautification planned across the NDMC area.

Under the plan, 41 major roads have been divided into 14 circles, each headed by a nodal officer who will conduct daily inspections and ensure that civic issues are addressed promptly, NDMC Chairman Manoj Kumar Dwivedi said on Monday. The 18th BRICS Summit is an upcoming international summit of the BRICS nations comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa and addi-

tional nations, scheduled to be hosted by India on 12-13 September 2026 as part of its BRICS chairmanship.

The council has identified 15 locations for floral boards, nine for flower fountains and 17 roundabouts for special illumination and beautification. Several other prominent locations have also been earmarked for focused cleaning and upkeep, though their details have not been disclosed for security reasons.

According to a statement, special sanitation arrangements, including additional staff and night-duty teams, will be in place from September 9 to 14.

Mechanical sweepers, scrubbers, manual sweeping teams, temporary dustbins and mobile toilets will be deployed, while stray

animals will also be removed from key areas. The civic body will also work with hotels, resident welfare associations and market traders to maintain cleanliness and civic discipline in areas linked to the summit.

Horticulture teams will focus on seasonal flowers, landscaping, green corridors, brown patches, shrubs, floral boards and decorative planters to give prominent roads and public spaces a well-maintained appearance.

NDMC will also undertake repairs of potholes and footpaths, maintain railings and road signs, remove debris and ensure proper drainage. Public toilets in identified areas will be inspected regularly to keep them functional and clean. The council will display BRICS branding on 154 digital screens and around 83



public and common toilet facilities as part of its public-ty campaign.

Street lights and decorative illumination will be kept operational, with backup power and quick response teams to deal with electrical faults. Special enforcement drives will target encroachments, unauthorised hoardings, unregulated street vending, construction activity and illegal parking, particularly along important and VIP movement routes.

The civic body will also deploy ambulances and medical teams at identified locations, inspect food establishments and step up mosquito-control measures. Drainage arrangements will be strengthened to deal with possible rain and waterlogging during the summit period.

IN FOCUS



Children look on at a Pookalam, floral rangoli, at the Kerala State Council for Child Welfare as part of Onam celebrations ahead of Onam festival in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala on Monday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Widespread fear amongst autorickshaw and taxi drivers over rumoured steep fines linked to a state government Marathi proficiency drive erupted into street protests in parts of Mumbai on Monday, forcing Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis to step in and address the panic.

During protests, some drivers tried to prevent other members from transporting passengers, inconveniencing common people in the morning hours.

Some videos circulating on social media showed demonstrations being organised in suburban Kandivali,



Malad (West), Santacruz, Dahisar, Andheri and a few other locations.

A senior regional transport official at the Borivali RTO said they learnt that someone had spread misinformation among drivers that they would be fined ₹5,000 to ₹20,000 for not having working knowledge of Marathi.

Amit Shah sets new security agenda

It is expected that the officials attending the conference will have more closely coordinated protocols in place among the cyber units, the intelligence departments, and the local police.

Over the years, the NSSC has become one of the most important annual events for calibrating India's internal security policy. This year's conference is especially important because of the clear political direction from the Union home minister.

The conference is still going on, but its message is already clear: India will not just react to threats. Instead, it will use data and algorithms to anticipate them and keep a strict zero-tolerance policy.

The home minister said national security is no longer just about defence. It is now a continuous effort, backed by technology, to confront anyone trying to infiltrate, radicalise, or wage war in other ways.

Kashmiri Pandit employees in Valley...

The Prime Minister's Employment Package for displaced Kashmiri Pandits was launched in 2009. It aimed at facilitating the dignified return of the exiled community to the Kashmir Valley. In its initial phase, 3,000 appointments were made under the package, followed by another 3,000 in subsequent years, notably in 2014 and 2017.

The All PM Package Employees Forum Kashmir on Monday submitted an official representation to the Chief Secretary of Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) regarding their safety. They have also urged the UT administration to ascertain how such outfits have been receiving personal details of employees and expose this crucial data to terrorise them.

In its letter, the forum said, "The authenticity of the poster is yet to be verified by the Police and security agencies. However, the repeated circulation of such threat letters and posters, particularly those containing sensitive personal information, is a matter of grave concern."

"We have already witnessed the tragic loss of Kashmiri Pandit employees in targeted attacks. The repeated emergence of new threats every week has created a deep sense of fear and insecurity among employees and their families," the forum added.

Seeking immediate intervention from the administration, the forum has called for enhanced and adequate security cover for all PM Package Kashmiri Pandit employees posted in the Valley. It has specifically requested immediate protection and security guidance for employees whose names, addresses or vehicle details may have appeared in the alleged threat. The forum said preventive measures should be taken on the basis of the latest security assessment and intelligence inputs, stressing that the government should act swiftly to reassure employees and their families.

J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah had earlier warned against taking threats to Kashmiri Pandit employees lightly and called for action against those behind the threats while urging authorities to ensure their security.

"Targeted killings of minorities have taken

ED raids nine locations in ₹9.63 cr bogus ITC case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■
New Delhi/Lucknow

On Monday, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) carried out a series of synchronised searches at several locations in Uttar Pradesh and Haryana as part of an inquiry into a major Goods and Services Tax (GST) fraud involving the false claim of input tax credit. The officials stated that teams from the central agency seized nine premises in Muzaffarnagar and Ghaziabad in Uttar Pradesh, as well as further sites in Faridabad, Haryana.

The searches were conducted under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act and focused on alleged irregularities involving Jambudwip Exports and Imports. Investigators say the company is accused of creating and using fake input tax credits through forged invoices and e-way bills. These documents were reportedly generated without any actual movement of goods, allowing the company and its partners to claim tax benefits illegally.

GST authorities earlier estimated the fraudulent input tax credit at Rs 9.63 crore, which officials say is a direct loss to the Government. The Enforcement Directorate began its investigation after the tax department's findings, turning the GST offence into a money-laundering case. The company is accused of



engaging in circular transactions, moving funds through layers, and making repeated cash withdrawals through fake or non-existent companies. Investigators say these tactics are often used to hide the source of illegal money and bring it into the formal economy.

The searches aimed to track the flow of money, find more people involved in the alleged fraud, and collect both paper and digital evidence to understand the full extent of the fake input tax credit network. Officials said the operation could lead to more information about other companies or individuals who may have been part of or benefited from the scheme.

Despite several attempts, we were unable to get a reply from Jambudwip Exports and Import. The company did not respond to requests for comment

while this report was being filed, and it has not issued any public statement about the ED's actions. This case highlights ongoing efforts by tax and enforcement agencies to curb input tax credit fraud, a long-standing issue in the GST system. Fake invoices and trading companies have often been used to claim refunds or reduce tax bills without any real business activity.

The ED's action under the Prevention of Money Laundering (PMLA) Act aims to recover the quantified loss and investigate whether the proceeds were used for further layering or investment. The officials stressed that the raids are part of a wider strategy to dismantle organised networks that exploit flaws in the invoice-matching and e-way bill verification systems.

The digital records collected during the searches will be forensically analysed to trace the transactions and find the final beneficiaries. The investigation is ongoing. The ED is expected to review bank accounts, property records, and communications linked to the company and its associates.

Offences relating to the GST, especially in cases where there is a significant loss of revenue and where sophisticated methods of diverting funds are involved. The authorities say that these measures serve as a deterrent and safeguard the integrity of the tax system.

Adityanath slams Akhilesh over dynastic politics remark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raebareli (UP)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath criticised Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Monday over his recent remark that "dynastic politics" had helped keep the SP united. The chief minister said the SP believed that only its "family syndicate" should be respected. Addressing a gathering,

Adityanath said Akhilesh's remarks showed that the party considered other MPs worthless and believed that only members of one family could become its MPs.

"Congress believes that only Congress should be honoured, while the Samajwadi Party (SP) believes that only its 'family syndicate' should be respected," he said.



Adityanath said this 'family syndicate' is such that any goon in your town, area, district or state finds himself

ideologically close to the SP. "Their work is to occupy the land of the poor, extort money from traders and compromise the safety of daughters," he alleged.

Yadav, at a press conference in Lucknow on Saturday, said the SP does not break alliances and that its fight is against the BJP. Asked about defections by MPs from various parties, he referred to the presence of several

members of his family among SP MPs and said, "Have you ever wondered why the entire party did not split? Because there are five MPs from the same family. We also have several Muslim MPs, and some staunch socialists, so our numbers would not decrease."

"Sometimes dynastic politics has its benefits," Yadav, leader of the third largest party in the Lok Sabha, had

said in a lighter vein. Taking a dig at the remark, Adityanath on Monday said, "They believe that the remaining MPs are worthless and that only members of one family can be MPs."

The SP currently has 37 Lok Sabha MPs from Uttar Pradesh, while the BJP has 33. Congress has six, RLD has two, Apna Dal and Azad Samaj Party one each of all 80 UP seats.

FROM PAGE - 1

Bengal).

The West Singhbhum district of Jharkhand, which was earlier characterised as a District of Concern was recently upgraded as Legacy and Thrust category district.

For the complete solution of the LWEE terrorism, the Union home ministry has been implementing a national policy and plan since 2015, which includes strengthening security measures and undertaking development initiatives. The ministry has credited the effective implementation of the policy for elimination of the LWEE problem.

Over the last decade, India transformed its approach to Left-Wing Extremism, from reactive containment to proactive elimination.

Pakistan cleric killed in mosque

This edict criticised Aslam for leading funeral prayers for Asif Shah, a member of the Shia community in Shadiwal. Raza said this was un-Islamic, based on his understanding of religious law, and that it was not allowed to lead funeral prayers for a Shia. After that, he received repeated threats from people connected to the incident.

The suspects named are Qari Aslam, his son Rehan Aslam, Muhammad Usman, and Qasim Shah, who is the son of the late Asif Shah. Raza told police that Usman contacted him via WhatsApp from Dubai on August 20, warning of "dire consequences very soon".

A murder case has been filed under Section 302 of the Pakistan Penal Code against the four named suspects and several unidentified accomplices. According to available information, investigation teams have been formed, and on Saturday night, the District Police Officer of Gujrat, Faisal Shahzad, visited the hospital to review the case.

Govt to release onions at ₹35 per kilo as...

Onion will be sold at ₹35 per kg in the retail market through NCCF and Nafed. The Government has a buffer stock of 1.21 lakh tonnes of onion for the current year, sufficient to meet the demand.

Data maintained by the ministry shows the all-India average retail price of onion rose 59 per cent year-on-year to ₹43.53/kg on August 24, from ₹27.37/kg a year ago. The average wholesale price was up 68 per cent at ₹35.58/kg, against ₹21.23/kg in the year-ago period. Among major cities, retail onion prices on Monday stood at ₹60/kg in Chennai (₹33 a year ago), ₹55/kg in Delhi (₹35) and ₹53/kg in Kolkata.

Onion prices typically see a seasonal uptick from August-September, on account of festive demand, weather-related disruptions, supply-chain movements and shifting demand patterns. To counter this, the ministry undertakes calibrated release of buffer stocks "through bulk mandi releases and targeted retail sales in consumption centres", a strategy it said has been consistently followed in recent years.

The timing, quantity and destination of releases are decided based on continuous monitoring of prices and market conditions across States. In 2024-25, 14 railway rakes carrying nearly 12,000 tonnes of onion buffer stock were dispatched to five cities. In 2025-26,

this has expanded to 86 rakes carrying about 88,000 tonnes of onions to 16 major cities across the country.

"Mandi prices in Nasik are ruling higher than Delhi, which should be the case. It means cartelisation and speculation are at work," she noted Khare said initially, the onion will be supplied to Chennai, Madurai, Delhi, Ernakulam and Guwahati, with additional destinations to be included subsequently based on emerging market requirements. She said the Government is keeping a close watch on prices to take further steps.

Khare said onion availability remains comfortable to meet domestic demand over the coming months, supported by estimated 2025-26 production of 307.37 lakh tonnes, 'broadly on a par with 307.67 lakh tonnes in the previous year.

Meanwhile, amid rise of sugar prices, Indian Sugar and Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) has claimed that there is no shortage of sugar in the country and said the prices in the retail market are expected to decline in the coming days following the Government's decision to allow imports besides imposing stock holding limits on traders and bulk consumers. Addressing a press conference, Indian Sugar and Bio-Energy Manufacturers Association (ISMA) President Niraj Shirgaokar said the prices have risen due to various factors, including speculative buying by traders and bulk consumers as well as lower production than estimated.

On Monday, the average all-India retail prices of sugar stood at ₹63.05 per kg, 29 per cent higher than ₹48.73 per kg a month back. The maximum retail price on Monday stood at ₹75 per kg, while the model price was hovering at ₹65 per kg, according to the Government data.

Delhi drowns as rains lash north India

Vehicles were stuck in water around Rajiv Chowk, while school buses and ambulances were also caught in waterlogging on Sohna Road.

The Gurugram administration on Monday advised corporate offices to allow employees to work from home on Tuesday and ordered government and private schools and educational institutions to conduct classes online in view of heavy rainfall and the possibility of waterlogging and traffic congestion.

The district administration said Gurugram received 70 mm of rainfall by 1.30 pm.

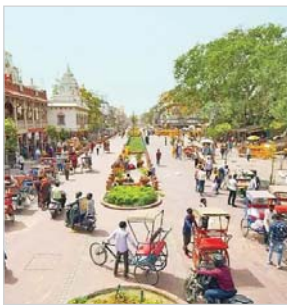
In Delhi too, several key stretches, including parts of Lutyens' Delhi, Mathura Road, Connaught Place, Bhairon Marg, ITO and the Zakhira underpass, were waterlogged, triggering traffic snarls. Waist-deep water, bumper-to-bumper traffic and life brought to a standstill marked the day's heavy downpour, as gusty winds and showers lashed the national Capital, with a few areas recording almost 67 mm of rain.

Many parts of UP witnessed light to moderate showers and isolated heavy downpours, disrupting normal life in urban pockets, the meteorological department said. Monsoon remained normal across UP over the past 24 hours, it said.

In Ghaziabad, heavy spells led to severe waterlogging across major roads and low-lying residential sectors, causing massive traffic congestion. In a mishap captured on cameras,

Delhi Govt plans ₹34 crore upkeep of historic Chandni Chowk stretch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Delhi Government plans to hire a private firm to beautify and maintain the historically significant 1.3-kilometre stretch of Chandni Chowk, starting from Red Fort Junction to Fatehpuri Mosque, and five other lanes interconnected to this stretch.

"To improve the situation at the revamped stretch of Chandni Chowk, we plan to hire a facility management company for housekeeping, cleanliness, repair work, horticulture work, etc. The work will be given initially for three years," an official said.

In the past few years, the stretch has fallen into neglect, facing problems of sanitation and cleanliness due to a tussle between the Public Works Department (PWD) and Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) over the maintenance of the revamped stretch.

"A tender has been issued to hire a company at the approximate cost of ₹34 crores; there will be penalties on the contractor if there are violations of the contract," the official said.

The identified areas

include the main Chandni Chowk corridor, Dewan Hall Road, Esplanade Road, HC Sen Marg, Rai Kedarnath Marg, Town Hall Chowk, Shanti Desai Marg and associated interconnected areas. Lal Jain Mandir and the Fatehpuri Mosque areas are also covered in the plan.

As per the scheme, security guards will be deployed, jet machines will be used for washing roads, toilet areas and public utility assets. Further, garbage disposal vehicles will transport collected waste to designated MCD disposal sites and horticulture work will also be undertaken.

"Security personnel will be deployed in three eight-hour shifts to provide continuous watch and ward at key locations," the plan states.

NIA raids 5 States over GOI websites cyber attacks

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Monday conducted searches at five locations across five states as part of its ongoing investigation into a major cyberterrorism case involving advanced DDoS attacks targeting key Indian Government websites.

The searches happened in Junnar (Pune district, Maharashtra), Nadiad (Kheda district, Gujarat), Ramagundam (Karimnagar district, Telangana), Gopalganj (Bihar), and Delhi. These actions are part of case RC-01/2025/NIA/AMD, known as the Cyber Terrorism Gujarat Case, which began on June 25, 2025.

According to the agency, the suspect tried to launch advanced DDoS attacks on 54 websites owned by various Indian Government entities.

These attacks targeted important computer systems and the Critical Information Infrastructure (CII) as part of Operation Sindoor. Investigators believe the attackers wanted to threaten national security and unity, and to create public fear. Two suspects have already been arrested in this case.

The Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) in Gujarat first registered the case before the NIA took over. NIA officials say that after a detailed technical analysis, they identified additional suspects believed to have supported the main accused. These individuals are thought to have helped plan the attacks and to have improved the skills needed for DDoS operations.

After getting search warrants from a court, NIA teams raided the homes and other locations of the suspects early Monday morning.



During the searches, investigators found several digital devices and documents related to hacking. They seized three laptops, five mobile phones, pen drives, and other digital storage devices. The suspects present at the sites were questioned to determine whether they were connected to the two people already arrested and whether they were involved in the cyberattacks.

Authorities emphasised that the operations followed all legal procedures. The seized items will undergo

forensic examination to uncover additional links in the conspiracy and identify others who may have helped plan or support the attacks on key Government digital systems. This case highlights growing worries about cyber threats to national security. DDoS attacks like these aim to flood online systems with traffic, making websites unavailable and possibly disrupting important public services.

During a sensitive operational phase, the accused allegedly aimed to cause extensive disruption and damage. At a critical stage, the accused allegedly tried to cause major disruption and harm public confidence by attacking 54 Government websites. NIA teams are still analysing the digital evidence collected from the five locations. More arrests or legal action may follow,

depending on what the forensic examination of the laptops, mobile phones, and other devices reveal.

Aspects of the conspiracy and to bring those liable to justice in accordance with the legal provisions concerned with cyber terrorism and threats to critical information infrastructure. The fact that the searches span multiple states shows that the alleged network had a nationwide presence.

The NIA's actions are part of a broader effort to protect India's digital assets from emerging cyber threats that could affect sovereignty and public order. As the investigation continues, authorities are expected to share more details about the technical methods used in the DDoS attacks and the level of support the accused received, whether from inside or outside the country.

MP High Court closes 8-year-old tree felling pleas, mandates planting



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jabalpur

The Madhya Pradesh High Court has disposed of two long-pending writ petitions seeking restrictions on tree felling across the state, noting that the 2015 notification challenged by the petitioners had already been struck down by a Full Bench of the court.

A division bench of Acting Chief Justice Vivek Rusia and Justice Pradeep Mittal was hearing Writ Petition No. 26802 of 2018, filed by Anand, and Writ Petition No. 13864 of 2019, filed by Vivek Kumar Sharma, against the State of Madhya Pradesh and others.

The petitions had sought directions to stop tree cutting, protect green cover, take action against illegal felling and quash the notification dated September 24, 2015, which the petitioners alleged was harmful to ecological balance.

The bench recorded that the principal challenge had already been settled. A Full Bench of the High Court, while considering the same petitions, had on March 1, 2025, struck down the 2015 notification.

What remained was an additional issue raised in Sharma's petition regarding the cutting of trees for road widening and construction of

new highways across Madhya Pradesh. The petitioner had alleged that trees were being felled for such projects without adequate compensatory plantation.

The court, however, found that there was no concrete data before it showing how many trees had been cut for road projects or how many had been planted in return.

Observing that the petition was filed in 2019 and that significant development had taken place since then, including construction and widening of several highways, the bench said the issue could not be examined effectively without updated figures.

The court therefore disposed of the petitions while giving the petitioners liberty to approach it again if they collect specific data on tree felling and compensatory plantation.

The bench also directed both petitioners to plant 25 fruit-bearing trees each in areas identified by the Municipal Corporation and submit a compliance report.

With these directions, the court closed the nearly eight-year-old litigation over the 2015 notification, while keeping open the possibility of fresh proceedings on the road-widening plantation issue if supported by detailed evidence.

Rahul Gandhi not champion of women's rights but Hindu baiter, says Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday slammed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, claiming that he is not a champion of women's rights but "simply a Hindu baiter".

During an interaction with girl students in Maharashtra on Saturday, Gandhi had criticised the "Manusmriti mindset", urged students to "smash patriarchy" and said women belonged to themselves, not to their fathers, husbands or sons.

Gandhi is simply using the cause of women's empowerment as a convenient smokescreen to target and discredit Hindu Dharma, Sarma alleged in a social media post.

"Consider this: how many times has he spoken with the same outrage against patriarchal and medieval practices that persist under Sharia? NEVER," Sarma said.

"While Sharia is foundational to Islamic jurisprudence, Manusmriti has no



comparable scriptural authority in Hindu Dharma. It is not even a universally binding code for Hindus," the chief minister said.

"How many times does Rahul Gandhi attack the Manusmriti, and how many times does he attack Sharia with the same fervour?" Sarma asked.

He claimed that the enduring strength of Hinduism lies in its unique ability to "evolve, reform and adapt



with time — as it has for millennia, and as it will for eternity".

"Every Hindu must therefore ask: what is Rahul Gandhi's real intent- championing women's rights, or using them as a pretext to malign Hindu Dharma?" Sarma said.

The chief minister alleged that Congress rhetoric on women's rights rings hollow when measured against its own record.

"They betrayed our mothers and sisters by reversing the effect of the Shah Bano judgment. It opposed the law against Triple Talaa," he said.

Shah Bano Begum's case led the Supreme Court to grant divorced Muslim women the right to maintenance in 1985. Following protests by Muslim organisations, the then-Rajiv Gandhi Government enacted a law in 1986 which nullified the apex court's decision in the Shah Bano case.

Sarma further alleged that just to cling to power in Karnataka, Rahul Gandhi's party ensured that not a single woman found a place in the State Cabinet.

"So here is a simple challenge to Rahul Gandhi: If women's equality truly comes before politics, will he unequivocally support a Uniform Civil Code that guarantees equal rights irrespective of religion? Or will his idea of 'women's rights' continue to begin and end with attacking Hinduism?"

Nation Focus



Govt to boost investments in chemical sector: Nadda

Union Minister JP Nadda on Monday emphasised the need to increase the size of the chemicals sector to \$1 trillion by 2040 and said the Government is focused on creating an ecosystem to boost investments for increasing domestic manufacturing capabilities. On Monday, Nadda chaired a CEO roundtable to deliberate on India's ambition of building a \$1 trillion Chemicals sector by 2040, an official statement said. The Department of Chemicals and Petrochemicals, Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilisers, in partnership with Invest India, organised the roundtable. Nadda "emphasised that the sector has to touch the \$1 trillion vision by 2040 in the country", the statement said. He said the Government is committed to establishing a continuous and institutionalised dialogue mechanism with the industry. (PNS)



Security forces unearth Naxal dump in Chhattisgarh forest

Hand grenades, gelatin sticks, AK-47 and INSAS rounds, alongside a huge cache of arms and explosives, were recovered from a Naxal dump in a forested area in Chhattisgarh's Sukma district on Monday, police said. The recovery was made during an anti-Naxal operation conducted by a joint team of the District Force, District Reserve Guard (DRG) and Bastar Fighters in the Bhandarpadar-Munurkonda area under Bhejji police station limits. Acting on intelligence inputs provided by surrendered Naxals, the joint team launched an area-domination and search operation in the forest and hill areas of Bhandarpadar and Munurkonda villages on Monday, police said. (PNS)

ISBT petrol pump row: NGT sets up panel to check site

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhopal

The National Green Tribunal has taken up an environmental plea challenging the alleged construction of a new petrol pump over or close to a drain and its buffer zone within the ISBT campus in Bhopal, and has constituted a joint committee to verify the ground situation.

The matter came up for hearing on Monday before a bench comprising judicial member Justice Sheo Kumar Singh and expert member Sudhir Kumar Chaturvedi. The application, filed by Prabhath Pandey, has alleged that the proposed petrol pump or retail outlet



is being developed either over a marked drain or natural drainage channel, or within the prescribed buffer zone around it.

The petitioner has relied on Central Pollution Control Board guidelines dated January 7, 2020, and referred to an earlier matter

dated August 16, 2021, while arguing that new fuel stations are required to maintain prescribed distances from water bodies, wetlands, canals and similar environmentally sensitive features.

The application has also alleged violation of provisions under the Madhya Pradesh Bhumi Vikas Rules, 2012, relating to the siting of fuel filling stations and protection of water bodies and drainage channels.

The tribunal, however, has not yet decided the merits of these allegations. At this stage, it has only recorded that the application raises a substantial environmental question requiring examination.

Following the preliminary hearing, the NGT directed issuance of notices to the respondents and asked them to file their replies within four weeks through the tribunal's e-filing portal.

To ascertain the factual position, the tribunal also constituted a joint committee comprising representatives of the Central Pollution Control Board, the district Collector and the Madhya Pradesh Pollution Control Board.

The committee has been directed to inspect the site, examine the alleged construction, assess compliance with applicable environmental norms and submit a report

within four weeks. The panel is also expected to place before the tribunal details of any action already taken by the authorities in connection with the project.

The case concerns the proposed petrol pump inside the ISBT campus and the larger question of whether its location is compatible with environmental safeguards governing natural drainage channels and nearby water-related features. The tribunal's directions are significant as they will bring an independent site assessment on record before further adjudication. The next hearing in the matter has been scheduled for October 13.

Mamata dismisses retirement rumours, vows to fight BJP

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Amid talks of the Trinamool Congress gradually fading into oblivion, with most of its leaders, including MPs and MLAs, leaving the party or forming separate rebel platforms, former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Monday reiterated that she was not going to quit politics anytime soon.

In a social media address, she ruled out "wild rumours" about her retirement, saying she would not take any political "sanyas" and would fight off the BJP instead. "I will not retire as some rumours are being spread ... instead I will fight the BJP out," she said.

Taking to Facebook Live, Banerjee said that the people of Bengal had read through the "true face" of the BJP, cautioning the people as well on the ongoing census process.

Referring to the recent protests at various places regarding the implementation of the Annapurna Bhandar scheme, presently being run by the Suwendu Adhikari Government, replac-



ing the previous Laxmir Bhandar programme of the Trinamool Congress Government, Banerjee said that the BJP was going back on its pre-election promises.

The BJP had promised to enhance the women-specific Laxmir Bhandar scheme from ₹1,500 to ₹3,000. However, women who have been left out of the scheme have been protesting at various parts of the State, accusing the BJP Government of playing "partisan politics".

Alleging once again that the national census being conducted by the BJP Government was another kind of National Register for Citizens (NRC), the former

Chief Minister cautioned the people against its prejudiced implementation. She asked the people to be cautious while sharing their details or signing the census forms, reminding how lakhs of names were deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision.

Incidentally, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari had already gone on record earlier, saying how rumours were being spread about implementation of Annapurna Bhandar.

"There is no point spreading rumours and staging protests before the media ... we are firm on our policy that no ineligible person will get the benefit of Annapurna Bhandar," Adhikari said, adding that already more than 1.45 crore women had started getting the benefit of the scheme. "If another 20 to 30 lakh women are found eligible, then they too will get it," he said.

The Annapurna Bhandar scheme is meant for women between 25 and 60 years of age and rules out families with an annual income of more than ₹12 lakh.

20% Government jobs for Agniveers in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The West Bengal Government has decided to provide 20 per cent reservation to the Agniveer cadets in Government services. The reservation would be provided in the Fire and Emergency Services, Forest Department, Police and Disaster Management Department.

Apart from this, a new disaster management force called Arjun Vahini would be created and modelled

after the National Disaster Management Force.

Incidentally, while some States are yet to formulate any policy on how to accommodate the Agniveers, some are providing 10 per cent reservation to them in the Government cadre. "It all depends on how these forces will be utilised and when and on whom... before that it is difficult to comment... besides, the legality of the project would also have to be seen," a senior CPI(M) leader said.



Ladakh administration mulls single permit for foreign tourists

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

The Ladakh administration is exploring a single protected area permit (PAP) for foreign tourists across the union territory, except for specifically restricted areas, to streamline procedures for such clearances while balancing tourism convenience with security requirements, officials said on Monday.

The decision was taken at a meeting chaired by Ladakh Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra, which reviewed the existing framework governing PAP and Restricted Area Permits (RAPs) for foreign visitors. "A key outcome of the meeting was the decision to explore the feasibility of introducing a single PAP for the entire union territory of Ladakh, except for specifically restricted areas, which would be explicitly mentioned in the permit," they said.

The meeting also explored establishing dedicated registration and verification desks for foreign nationals at the airport, including separate arrangements for visitors requiring additional scrutiny under



revised standard operating procedures (SOPs), they added. Kundra stressed the need to minimise unnecessary checkpoints that cause delays and inconvenience to tourists while strengthening verification and compliance mechanisms. The Leh deputy commissioner was asked to examine the feasibility of introducing facial recognition technology and self-registration facilities at designated checkpoints to modernise permit verification and make the process more seamless, they said.

Administrative Secretary (Tourism and Culture) Sanjit Rodrigues gave a presentation on the existing permit regime, including the geographical coverage of PAP and RAP, restricted areas, particularly in northern and

eastern Ladakh, and procedures for issuance and verification under the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025.

The meeting discussed permit verification at key entry points, particularly along the Changthang axis through Upshi and Kharu and at North Pullu in Nubra, they added. It was also decided to explore measures for verification of travel purpose, accommodation details and related documentation of foreign tourists at dedicated airport facilities. Kundra directed the tourism department to convene a meeting with taxi and bike unions involved in facilitating travel by foreign tourists to ensure proper maintenance of travel records, logbooks and visitor information.

States Focus



NAIDU DIRECTS OFFICIALS TO LEVERAGE AI, DATA INTEGRATION

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday directed officials to make online Government services more convenient by leveraging technologies including AI. During an RTGS review meeting at secretariat, the chief minister enquired with officials about the performance and progress of various departments and directed all departments to improve their efficiency and work towards providing quality services. "We should leverage technologies such as AI Assistant, Digi Verify, Data Lake to make online Government services more convenient and ensure that people can access services without having to visit Government offices," Naidu said. (PTI)



J&K CM OMAR REVIEWS PLAN TO UPGRADE 714 HIGH SCHOOLS

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Monday reviewed a comprehensive roadmap to strengthen access to senior secondary education and improve the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) at the higher secondary level in the Union Territory. Abdullah chaired a meeting of the School Education Department during which a phased plan to upgrade 714 high schools into K-12 composite schools was discussed, an official spokesperson said. The plan focuses on requirements of teaching and non-teaching staff, infrastructure, laboratories and other essential facilities, he said. Other senior officers of the School Education Department were also present. (PTI)

3 Bambiha gang fugitives deported from Malaysia

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

India has advanced in its efforts to combat organised crime and transnational gangs. On Monday, the Union Home Minister, Amit Shah, announced that three members of the Bambiha Gang had been deported from Malaysia. Jaspreet Singh, Ajay Singh and Pawandeep Singh were apprehended with the assistance of Indian agencies, returned to India and then handed over to the Punjab Police.

The *Pioneer* was the first to report the repatriation of three gangsters from the Bambiha Gang in its August 20th edition, titled "Punjab Police nets three key Bambiha gang operatives in major deportation from Malaysia".

The three men were wanted for serious crimes such as extortion, arms smuggling, drug trafficking, and a failed grenade attack in Ludhiana. Their arrest is another step in breaking up gang networks that organise crimes in India from other countries.

The Home Minister's office tweeted that "Indian authorities have caught three absconding Indian gangsters in Malaysia, deported them to India and handed them over to the police" and also stated that "under Modi ji's vision of a safe and secure India, our agencies have arranged for the deportation of 51 hardened criminals in 2026 alone".

This success comes from stronger diplomatic and intelligence cooperation with other countries, especially



in Southeast Asia. In recent years, many members of India's underworld have tried to escape justice. The Bambiha Gang has been connected to violent extortion, drug cartels, and arms trafficking routes that cross the India-Pakistan border and other regions.

Law enforcement agencies say these groups use other

countries as safe havens and run their operations through encrypted messages, staying out of reach of Indian police. Tracking and deporting Jaspreet Singh, Ajay Singh, and Pawandeep Singh show that real-time intelligence sharing and cross-border cooperation are now working more effectively.

People involved in the

operation said the three men still threaten public safety in Punjab and nearby areas. Their attempt at a grenade attack in Ludhiana has raised concerns about the gang's willingness to use more violence. Now that they are back, investigators can question them closely, which may uncover new details about other associates and financial networks still operating from abroad.

The Union Government's current efforts focus on bringing fugitives to justice, making it harder for gangsters and terrorists to avoid prosecution abroad. Deporting 51 people in 2026 alone shows these efforts have grown, thanks to diplomatic pressure, legal extradition, and coordinated deportations that follow local immigration laws. These measures

deter criminal activity and indicate that going abroad does not guarantee safety.

Since some areas in Punjab have been affected by gang violence and drug trafficking, the return of these three men is likely to bring some relief. While the accused go through the legal process, the public will keep an eye on the evidence already gathered as well as any new information the men may provide.

Home Minister Amit Shah's statement shows the Government's commitment to finding anyone who threatens India's security, wherever they are. The teamwork between Indian and Malaysian authorities demonstrates that international cooperation can yield tangible results in combating organised crime across borders.

Assam CM Himanta meets Amit Shah, discusses flood response, rehabilitation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday evening met Union Home Minister Amit Shah in the national Capital and briefed him on the flood situation in Assam and the damage caused by the recent floods, besides discussing several other important matters concerning the State.

During the meeting, the Chief Minister apprised the Union Home Minister of the scale of the damage and the steps being taken by the state government for relief, rehabilitation and restoration.

Shah acknowledged the scale of the flood damage and assured the Assam Government of the Government of India's unequivocal support for rehabilitation and restoration



efforts in the affected areas.

The Chief Minister said the Union Home Minister had remained in constant touch

with the state Government throughout the floods.

Taking to X after the meeting, Sarma said, "Today

in New Delhi, I had the privilege of meeting Hon'ble Union Home Minister Shri Amit Shah Ji and briefing him on the #AssamFloodResponse, along with several other important matters concerning Assam."

"Throughout the #AssamFloods, he remained in constant touch with us. In today's meeting too, he acknowledged the scale of damage caused by the floods. He assured the Government of India's unequivocal support for rehabilitation and restoration," the Chief Minister said.

Sarma further said he came away from every meeting with Shah "enriched by his meticulous attention to detail, and his unwavering commitment to a secure and stable Assam".

"Grateful, as always, for his guidance and steadfast support," the Chief Minister added.

CPI(M) slams BJP over Vande Mataram



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Monday issued a strong statement disapproving of the manner in which the BJP and Hindutva communal forces are misusing the question of prioritising Vande Mataram with all six stanzas as legislated by Parliament.

Highlighting its position, the CPI(M) pointed out the historical context in which the song was officially rendered as the National Song. The party noted that the six stanzas were added subsequently, after a lapse of decades, to dovetail with the novel Anandamath by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay. "It is on the basis of this historical fact and the implication that no one less than Rabindranath Tagore himself found this unacceptable as the National Anthem," the Polit Bureau stated.

Clarifying its stand, the Left party stated that there are no reservations about the recitation of the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram, as has traditionally been done during the freedom struggle and

within the Constituent Assembly.

However, the CPI(M) alleged that following the passage upgrading its status with the addition of all six stanzas, attempts are being made to turn the rendering of this version into a single-point marker for patriotism.

"It clearly betrays the Hindutva forces' communal and divisive objectives. The hypocritical style of wearing patriotism on its sleeve is exposed by the act of the Uttar Pradesh Assembly Speaker walking out midway during the rendering of the National Anthem," the press release read.

The Polit Bureau expressed concern that such moves are disruptive to national unity, adding that ironically, these actions are being initiated by those who did not show the inclination to raise the Vande Mataram slogan during the freedom struggle.

Reiterating its stance, the CPI(M) affirmed that all constitutionally accepted concepts must be honoured, as they represent vital additions to the idea of India by recognising pluralism and inclusiveness.

BJP hits back at Congress over space sector reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday hit back at the Congress for accusing the Modi Government of pursuing an "aggressive privatisation agenda" in the space sector, asserting that India's space programme has expanded from a predominantly Government-led initiative into a growing ecosystem comprising ISRO, private industry and hundreds of startups.

The remarks came after Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh accused the Government of "strangling and emasculating" the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and pursuing an aggres-

sive privatisation agenda for the space programme just as it has for nuclear energy.

Ramesh claimed recent reports about ISRO's future role in India's space programme raised "legitimate concerns", given the capabilities built by the organisation over six decades.

Responding to the Congress leader, BJP national spokesperson and national media co-in-charge Pradeep Bhandari said opening up the space sector has enabled private companies and startups to move from being suppliers to developers of rockets, satellites and complete space systems.

"From a largely government-driven programme to



BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari

an emerging national space ecosystem. That is not the weakening of ISRO's legacy. It is the expansion of India's space ambition," Bhandari said in a post on social media.

Citing data, he said that under Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the space sector has expanded signifi-

cantly, with the number of foreign satellites launched by ISRO rising from 35 before 2014 to 399 by January 2026.

The number of space startups, he added, has risen from one in 2014 to around 440 by August 2026, while private investment in the sector increased from \$100.5

million in 2021-22 to \$618.5 million by March 2026.

Bhandari also highlighted the increase in revenue of NewSpace India Limited (NSIL), from ₹321.77 crore in 2021-22 to around ₹3,000 crore in 2024-25.

He cited the Chandrayaan-3 mission's soft landing near the Moon's south polar region and the development of launch vehicles such as LVM3 and SSLV as other milestones in India's space programme.

He cited Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 reaching orbit in July 2026 as an example of the growing role of private players in the sector.

"Skyroot Aerospace's Vikram-1 reaching orbit in July

2026 as India's first privately developed orbital rocket to do so is a powerful example of this new era. ISRO gave India a formidable technological foundation over decades. The Modi Government's reforms have sought to build on that legacy by enabling ISRO, private industry, startups and investment to grow together," he added.

Bhandari said the expansion of the space sector is "not the weakening of ISRO's legacy" but an expansion of India's space ambitions.

"Jairam ji, I understand your frustration with India's remarkable journey in space. But the numbers tell a story that is difficult to ignore," he said.

US envoy visits Tata-Lockheed plant

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The production in India of critical structures for the C-130J military transport aircraft is a strong example of the growing defence cooperation between the US and India, and such efforts are set to advance the shared vision for a free and secure Indo-Pacific, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said on Monday. The envoy made the remarks after visiting the Tata-Lockheed Martin Aerostructures Ltd's manufacturing facility in Hyderabad.

Established in 2010, the joint venture focuses on complementing India's 'Make in India' objectives and has the distinction of being the single global source of C-130J empennage assemblies included on all new Super Hercules aircraft produced in the US.

The Tata Advanced Systems and Lockheed Martin joint venture is now eyeing to address India's requirement of around 80 Medium Transport Aircraft (MTA) under a multi-billion dollar procurement programme.

Lockheed Martin's C-130J, Embraer Defence and Security's C-390 Millennium and Airbus Defence and Space's A-400M aircraft have emerged as top contenders for the mega contract. The IAF is currently operating 12



C-130J aircraft.

During the visit, Ambassador Gor toured the production line that manufactures empennages for the C-130J Super Hercules. "The decades-long economic partnership between the United States and India continues to grow stronger through innovation, shared security interests and economic cooperation," Gor said.

"The production in India of critical structures for the C-130J, a platform operated by both our nations, is a strong example of the growing industrial and defence cooperation between the US and India. Partnerships like these support high-skilled jobs, strengthen resilient supply chains, and advance our shared vision for a free, open and secure Indo-Pacific," he said.

Gor's reference to the Indo-Pacific comes amid rising global concerns over China's increasing military muscle-flexing in the region.

Sukaran Singh, Chief

Executive Officer and Managing Director of Tata Advanced Systems Limited, said: "Tata Advanced Systems' partnership with Lockheed Martin has proven over time to supply world-class aerostructures for their key programmes including the C-130J."

"This partnership has now extended to MRO, which will be operational soon. Additionally, both parties are expanding cooperation on full platforms for Make in India, should we get the opportunity."

The Tata Advanced Systems' MRO opening is planned for December this year, with aircraft arrival slated for Spring 2027. Trish Pagan, vice president of Air Mobility and Maritime Missions at Lockheed Martin, said: "Through our collaboration with Indian industry, we have established world-class aerospace manufacturing capabilities that directly support the global network of C-130J operators."

Opposition, Adhikari lock horns on JU face-off in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Bengal Opposition parties have strongly criticised Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari for "taking sides" and not taking action against the ABVP students for vandalism and assault on the students during a midnight raid inside the elite Jadavpur University campus last week.

Trinamool Congress leader Kunal Ghosh said that "if the Chief Minister thinks that the JU students and not those belonging to the ABVP were guilty, he should immediately take steps without... but if the story is different then also he should act neutrally."

Srijan Bhattacharya, a national-level leader of SFI, the students' arm of the

CPI(M), too on Monday attacked Adhikari for "taking sides" of the ABVP goons, asking whether he would use the "anti-goonda" laws that his Government had recently enacted. The law, which was passed in the State Assembly, was, however, awaiting the presidential assent.

Bhattacharya also objected to the composition of the enquiry committee, saying the Chairman of the committee had a controversial past.

Clashes took place between two groups both inside and outside the campus on last Wednesday and Thursday, leaving several persons injured. Despite CCTV footage, the police have till Sunday, failed



to arrest anyone.

The Chief Minister, however, remained firm on his stance, saying he would "not allow any kind of anti-national activities inside the campus."

Accusing the "anti-national elements: inside the campus for the recent clashes inside the University, he said he would not allow

anything inside the campus that was against "Rastrabad" (nationalism).

"A lot of anti-national activities are going on inside the campus... but we will not allow this... we will ensure that nationalism thrives both inside and outside Jadavpur (campus)," Adhikari said warning those "who are crying for the JU on social

media" saying "my policy is clear, if you want to live in this State you will have to follow Rashtrawad (nationalism) and sing Vande Mataram."

Reacting sharply to Adhikari's comments, senior CPI(M) leader and former MP Sujjan Chakrabarty said, "a Chief Minister is expected to take responsibility of his words... which means he should speak a minimum of truth... is at least that is visible to naked eyes... here he is not only allowing goons to roam free but blaming the innocent students who were inside the campus during the midnight and were attacked... what were the outsiders doing and what the BJP MLA of a neighbouring constituency was doing near JU before or after the attack."

Reservation a constitutional right, cannot be scrapped: Chirag

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) chief and Union Minister Chirag Paswan on Monday said caste-based reservation cannot be scrapped as it is a constitutional right, even as the Opposition alleged that the ruling party was seeking to amend the Constitution to end quotas.

"These people see politics in everything. After all, aren't the Sangh, the BJP, and our party all part of the NDA? Is reservation something that can be abolished just because someone says so? It is a constitutional right," Paswan told reporters on the sidelines of a national conclave.

Reservation, he said, is not "charity handed out to anyone" but a constitution-



al right that "no power on earth can ever abolish". Those who speak of scrap-

ping it under the garb of "review" or "reform", he added, "likely do not even understand why reservation is necessary."

Referring to the treatment of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, Paswan said people still casually question why they need reservation, even as caste-based discrimination continues in society. He cited the recent controversy over

Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, asking pointedly whether the stage was "purified" after he left it.

He also pointed to instances where Dalit grooms are stopped from taking out wedding processions, and where temple premises are washed with "Gangajal" after visits by prominent leaders, as evidence that untouchability persists.



3 newborns die in Amravati NICU fire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amravati

Three newborn infants died after a devastating fire broke out in the Neonatal Intensive Care Unit (NICU) of the District Women's Hospital on Monday, prompting the state Government to order a high-level inquiry into the tragedy.

Thirty-six other infants were rescued from the smoke-filled facility following the fire, which erupted at around 3.15 am inside a section of the NICU housing premature, low-weight, and critically ill babies, officials said.

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis expressed deep grief over the "heart-breaking" incident and ordered a high-level probe to investigate the cause of the fire and pinpoint administrative failures. "The health administration has been directed to conduct a high-level inquiry," Fadnavis said in a statement, assuring that the strictest action would be



Charred remains of medical equipment in the NICU of a Government hospital where a fire killed at least three newborns in Amravati district

taken against those found responsible.

He directed state health minister Prakashrao Abitkar and health secretary to visit Amravati in eastern Maharashtra immediately to review the situation and directed local authorities to ensure that all injured children receive treatment at Government expense. He announced an ex-gratia

financial assistance of ₹5 lakh to the family of each deceased infant.

According to police and health officials, the fire was triggered by an explosion in a ventilator in the outborn infants' section of the NICU.

The facility consists of three compartments, inborn, outborn, and a step-down care ward for infants preparing for discharge, housing a

total of 39 babies at the time of the incident.

While staff and rescuers managed to evacuate six babies from the affected outborn section, three infants tragically died in the flames.

Amravati Police Commissioner Rakesh Ola said that six rescued infants were shifted to a super-specialty hospital, while four others were transferred to the Divisional Referral Services Hospital, where one child remains in critical condition. The bodies of the three deceased infants have been sent for post-mortem examination, he said.

The tragedy sparked severe outrage among parents and relatives waiting outside the facility, who alleged gross negligence and a complete failure of safety infrastructure.

Eyewitnesses claimed the ward's fire alarms failed to sound and the automatic water sprinkler system did not activate as smoke rapidly filled the ward. Parents

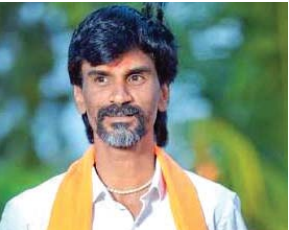
described a chaotic and terrifying scene, where security guards and on-duty nurses braved blinding smoke and heat to pull out babies from their cradles and incubators before fire tenders arrived.

Yogesh Savarkar, a resident of Achalpur whose eight-day-old child was admitted on the first floor, recalled sleeping outside when panic erupted. "My child was on the first floor, and I personally went and brought him down.

Nurses on duty described the horrifying moments as they fought to save the infants amid poor visibility.

"While the ventilator was burning, we removed the babies. I can't describe it; it was terrible. The babies were burning next to it; we rescued them, extracted the incubator, and shifted them," two nurses on duty told reporters, adding they worked frantically until all nine babies in the outborn section were brought outside.

Maratha quota activist Jarange firm on hunger strike from August 29



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jalna

Maratha reservation activist Manoj Jarange on Monday remained firm on a hunger strike from August 29 at Antarwali Sarati in Jalna district.

A delegation comprising Maharashtra ministers Shambhuraj Desai, Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, and Uday Samant met Jarange and appealed to him not to proceed with the agitation.

However, Jarange remained firm on his decision and set August 28 as the deadline for the Government to act on his demands.

Jarange has demanded that the pending process of issuing Kunbi certificates and validity documents to eligible members of the Maratha community be completed by August 28.

Fadnavis and Chidambaram clash Over women's quota

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

A war of words erupted between Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and senior Congress leader P Chidambaram on Monday over the implementation of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, with the former accusing the Opposition party of sabotaging plans to bring the women's quota into force by 2029.

Earlier in the day, Chidambaram slammed Fadnavis for criticising Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for his statements about women's empowerment during his 'Chhatron Ki Gooni' programme in Pune on Saturday, while opposing the Bill that gives 33 per cent seats to women in Parliament and legislative assemblies. The former Union



minister, in a post on X, attributed Fadnavis's remarks to "cognitive failure".

"Because the Constitution (106th Amendment) Bill providing for 33 per cent reservation of seats in the Lok Sabha and the state legislative assemblies was passed in Parliament in 2023. The Congress wholeheartedly supported the Bill in both Houses of Parliament," he wrote. Rejecting Chidambaram's

charge, Fadnavis pointed out that while the Congress voted for the 2023 amendment knowing it was tied to post-census delimitation, the party later opposed fresh legislation in 2026 designed to expedite the process using 2011 census figures.

The BJP leader remarked that he also wished to acquire the art of having selective memory. "You very well know that the 106th Constitution Amendment Act, 2023 — the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam that you read and voted for - contains a clear precondition. Under the provisions for reservation of seats for women, 'shall come into effect only after delimitation exercise has been conducted, which will happen based on the first census taken after the Act's commencement'," Fadnavis said on X.

Kids treated worse than animals: CJP writes to State Govts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) that has put the state of Government schools at the centre of its ongoing campaign wrote to all State Governments on Monday, seeking data on school infrastructure, teacher vacancies and funding over the last five years.

In identical letters addressed to education ministers, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said visuals from Government schools circulating on social media showed

that many children still lacked basic facilities such as safe drinking water, functional toilets, proper classrooms, and even benches.

"It has been 80 years since India gained Independence... No child in this country should be forced to study in

such conditions. They are being treated worse than animals," Dipke wrote.

The letters are the latest step in CJP's campaign regarding the condition of Government schools. The youth-led outfit has been highlighting dilapidated school buildings and inadequate facilities on social media while demanding greater public spending on education.

The campaign has also seen confrontations on the ground. A CJP team, including co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka, was allegedly assaulted during a

recent visit to a Government school in Rajasthan. The CJP accused BJP workers of carrying out the attack, a charge the party disputed, and cross FIRs were subsequently filed over the incident.

In its letters to the states, the CJP has now sought details of the number of Government schools renovated over the past five years and those still requiring repairs or complete renovation.

It has also asked state Governments to disclose the number of sanctioned, filled and vacant teaching posts and provide figures on funds

allocated to Government schools over the past five years against the amount actually spent.

The party also sought estimates of how many additional Government schools are needed to ensure reasonable access to quality education and details of non-teaching duties assigned to Government school teachers.

It has also sought data on how many schools have adequate computers and digital-learning facilities, clean and functional toilets, and proper sports facilities and equipment.



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor visits the Charminar, in Hyderabad, Telangana.

West Bengal moves towards full implementation of NEP 2020

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata



Dipak Barman

West Bengal is working towards full implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and will soon sign a pact with the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) for teacher support, State School Education Minister Dipak Barman said on Monday.

Speaking at a state-level workshop attended by district inspectors of schools and other education depart-

ment officials from across the state at the Biswa Bangla Convention Centre in New Town, Barman said the state was "somewhat behind" in implementing

NEP 2020, and efforts were underway to complete the process expeditiously. He said the state was also preparing to sign an MoU with NCERT to facilitate orientation programmes for teachers and provide technical and academic guidance for implementing the new education framework.

"Through the MoU, NCERT will guide us. They will help us address the difficulties in implementation, from technical issues to taking the framework down to the school level," the minister said.

Mahto launches campaign for JPSC-JSSC reforms in Ramgarh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ramgarh/ Ranchi



Jharkhand student leader Devendra Nath Mahato takes out the 'Bharati Vyavastha Sudhar Yatra' from Nemra village in Ramgarh

Student leader Devendra Nath Mahto-led JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch on Monday launched its statewide campaign for reforms in recruitment examinations from Jharkhand's Ramgarh district amid a protest by locals.

Mahto kicked off the campaign from Lukaiyatand in Nemra, Chief Minister Hemant Soren's native village, after paying tributes to JMM founder and former chief minister Shibhu Soren.

Nemra residents staged a road blockade around 3 km away from the campaign venue to protest the Manch's alleged plans to burn effigies of Hemant Soren.

Mahto, along with Manch members, paid tributes to Shibhu Soren's statue by washing his feet and offering 'akshat' (sacred rice) and garlands as part of a traditional tribal ritual. They also raised slogans of 'Shibhu Soren Amar Rahe'. "Taking blessings of Dishom Guru Shibhu

Soren, we are launching the 'JPSC-JSSC Corruption-Free Recruitment' campaign from today. It aims to demand fair, transparent and corruption-free recruitment systems. The campaign will cover all 24 districts of the state, strengthening our voice," Mahto told reporters.

The campaign will raise demands to check recruitment scams, take

action against the corrupt, crack down on the paper-leak mafia and ensure justice for youths, he said.

He said the campaign would be peaceful and democratic.

"Students across the state are enthusiastic and hopeful about this campaign, believing it will secure justice for them and bring transparency in the recruitment examination system," Mahto claimed.

On FIRs against protesting students, Mahto said, "FIRs cannot silence our voice or suppress our agitation. It will continue till our demands are met."

Regarding the Supreme Court's notice to the State Government, he said, "It is part of the legal process, and the Government will respond accordingly."

He said they want the Government to take a stand for students' concerns in court. "During our campaign, a legal team will also accompany us to help students who want to become interveners in the ongoing case here," he added. Earlier, armed with

traditional weapons and sticks, locals blocked the road leading to the Nemra village.

"We staged a road blockade to prevent Mahto from entering Nemra," villager Birju Soren said.

He said they received information that Mahto would burn effigies of the CM in the village.

When told that Mahto was coming to launch his statewide campaign for reforms in recruitment examinations, Birju Soren said, "Mahto may begin his campaign from the statue of Shibhu Soren located outside the village, but we will not allow him to enter." A representative of Mahto said they did not enter the village.

Mahto was one of the prominent faces of the 26-day student protest that began on July 25 in Ranchi against alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations.

The JMM-led Government cancelled 22 tests and ordered a probe into 23 others conducted by the state public service commission and an out-sourced agency since 2014.

8 Bills passed in Karnataka Assembly without discussion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Eight Bills, including the one allowing portions of park and garden land to be used for public infrastructure and utility projects, were passed by the Karnataka Legislative Assembly on Monday without discussion, amid the Opposition's protest demanding the resignation of Minister B Nagendra.

The Karnataka Government Parks (Preservation) (Amendment) Bill, 2026, passed by the Assembly, amends the 1975 act.

The Cabinet, which met on Friday, approved the proposed amendments to the Act, which governs prominent Bengaluru green spaces, including Cubbon Park and Lalbagh.

Opposition BJP and JD(S) members, who were protesting inside the House demanding sacking of Nagendra — who is facing charges in connection with the alleged embezzlement of crores of rupees at a state-run corporation — shouted slogans criticising the Government over the passage of this Bill.

The Bill explicitly permits the state Government to alienate park land by way of sale, lease, gift, exchange, mortgage, or otherwise, up to an absolute limit of five per cent of the total area.

This applies strictly in favour of Government departments, statutory authorities, Government companies, or local authorities for public utility projects.

It provides for establishing an authoritative evaluation mechanism headed by the Additional Chief Secretary to



BJP MLAs, MLCs and workers stage a protest demanding the resignation of Karnataka Minister B Nagendra over his alleged involvement in the Valmiki Corporation scam in Bengaluru

Government, alongside designated officers and expert domain professionals, ensuring that any proposed land utilisation is thoroughly evaluated before any recommendation is made to the state Government.

The Bill statutorily mandates that the five per cent spatial ceiling is strictly inclusive of any and all lands previously alienated, thereby safeguarding the remaining natural ecosystem.

It further clarifies that standard developments by the Horticulture Department for its own administrative and allied use fall entirely outside this restriction.

It provides a specialised legal pathway for utilising minimal areas within Horticulture Farms for implementing core Horticulture Projects.

"This includes post-processing facilities, cold storage units, production of improved varieties, and agro-based industries directly beneficial to the local

farming community, backed by recorded reasons demonstrating public interest and absolute necessity," it added.

The amendment is significant in the context of the proposed 17-km tunnel road project connecting Hebbal and Central Silk Board. The project requires around six acres of Lalbagh land temporarily and one acre permanently, according to sources.

Adani Enterprises has emerged as the lowest bidder for this project. On Sunday, Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani held a meeting with Chief Minister DK Shivakumar.

The Opposition BJP has attacked the Congress Government over the passage of the Bill, terming it a move aimed at destroying the parks and green spaces across the state for real estate purposes.

"Adani went to Shivakumar's house to take park lands. Shivakumar has colluded with Adani to give away land for real estate.

TN CM announces shelving of Parandur airport project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Monday announced that his Government will shelve the second airport project in Chennai, the Parandur greenfield airport project, citing concerns over the impact on agricultural land, farmers and residential areas. The proposed project is worth over ₹27,000 crores. Opposition, including DMK president and former chief MK Stalin criticised the decision to scrap the project.

Vijay also announced expansion of the fare-free bus travel scheme for women and three free cooking gas cylinders a year to 1.30 crore beneficiaries at an annual cost of about ₹4,000 crore.

Making several announcements in the state assembly, Vijay, fulfilling TVK's key electoral assurances, said that deluxe, express, limited stop and mofussil services will also be free for women and transgenders from October 2 and this move will entail an expenditure of Rs 6,000 crore per annum. Speaking in the State Assembly, Vijay said

Chennai's existing Meenambakkam airport, operated by the Airports Authority of India (AAI), currently has the capacity to handle around 30 million passengers annually.

He said a second airport was necessary to meet the growing requirements of the Chennai metropolitan region, support industrial development and expand cargo transportation.

Vijay said the previous Government had pursued the Parandur project despite its potential impact on farmers. He recalled visiting Eganapuram and neighbouring villages on January 20, 2025, where residents had been protesting against the proposed airport. Vijay said he had met the protestors and listened to their concerns.

Govt denying permission to visit US an insult to Telangana: Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad



Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy addresses a press conference, at Telangana Secretariat

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Monday attacked the BJP and its-led NDA Government at the Centre over denial of permission to him to visit the US, alleging that it was an insult to the four crore people of the State.

Addressing a press conference hours after returning to Hyderabad from his UK visit, he claimed that the Centre was showing discrimination towards Telangana and said the issue will be raised in the Parliament by the Congress party.

On reports that he sought to meet Zohrab Mamdani in the US, Reddy said the New York Mayor was not an anti-social element but an elected representative.

The Centre permitted Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel to visit the US to invite investments into his state, but denied him permission, Reddy said. BJP "doesn't want any state to grow beyond a point", he alleged. Reddy said AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge and party leader Rahul

Gandhi would raise the issue of denying him permission to visit US in parliament.

Reddy returned to Hyderabad on Monday following a three-day visit to the UK. He had initially departed for the UK on August 20 with onward travel plans to the US.

However, the Centre denied permission for the US leg of his tour, following which Reddy decided to cut short his trip and return home from London.



Editor's
TAKE

India-China talks: Clearing the ground for Xi's Delhi visit

Coming just weeks before Xi's visit to New Delhi for the BRICS Summit, the talks aim to stabilise the relationship and lay the groundwork for a significant summit

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval's arrival in Beijing for the 25th round of Special Representatives (SR) talks with Foreign Minister Wang Yi looks, on the calendar, like routine business under a mechanism running since 2003. It is not. This is the first SR round in a full year, and it comes weeks before Xi Jinping is expected in New Delhi for the BRICS Summit on September 12-13 – a visit that would be his first to India in years.

The border talks are, in effect, ground-clearing for a summit both capitals want to succeed. The recent record shows real, if narrow, movement. The October 2024 disengagement at Depsang and Demchok ended a four-year military standoff and revived an SR channel dormant since 2019.

Modi's visit to Tianjin last August, his first to China in seven years, was followed by direct flights resuming after a five-year gap, eased visas, a revived Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, reopened border trade, and a partial easing of Chinese curbs on fertiliser, tunnel-boring machines and rare-earth exports. The Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on border affairs has already met twice this year to prepare the ground for this round.

Yet the irritants are many. The 3,488-km Line of Actual Control remains undemarcated, and disengagement at flashpoints has not been matched by genuine de-escalation of the forces both sides massed after the deadly 2020 Galwan clash. Beijing continues to claim Arunachal Pradesh as "South Tibet," renaming its towns, and recent reports of Chinese troop movements there – dismissed by New Delhi but not forgotten – keep resurfacing.

China's tilt toward Pakistan during last year's conflict following the Pahalgalam terror attack has not helped. Nor has the economics: India's trade deficit with China has crossed \$100 billion, a record, and is still widening this year, even as New Delhi remains dependent on Beijing for as much as 90 per cent of its rare-earth magnets and permanent-magnet imports. This is why 23 years and 25 rounds have produced management, not resolution. For China, the boundary is one lever among many in a wider contest with India; for India, it is a matter of sovereignty that cannot be traded away for economic convenience. That asymmetry of stakes, layered on a trust deficit Galwan made permanent, means both sides now negotiate for stability rather than settlement – a tactical thaw, as most analysts describe it, not a strategic reset.

The way forward lies in accepting that reality rather than resisting it. New Delhi should press the SR and WMCC channels to make de-escalation – not just disengagement – the next concrete milestone, while building the domestic capacity in rare earths and manufacturing that makes engagement with Beijing a choice rather than a compulsion. Xi's possible visit should be judged by whether it locks in verifiable troop reductions, not by the optics of a handshake. Diplomacy with China has always demanded patience without illusions. Nothing in Beijing this week suggests that changes.

When loyalty becomes the only qualification

The Trump administration shows how power can turn institutions into instruments of personal loyalty. Beneath the combative rhetoric and high-profile departures lies a deeper danger: persuasion replacing knowledge, loyalty eclipsing institutional responsibility, and educated people normalising behaviour they once condemned



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

Here is where it is coming to an end, step by step. The façade is crumbling; the putrid structure is becoming visible. First, they leave. There is no grand theoretical explanation, no elaborate political doctrine, no convincing institutional account. They simply depart, citing personal reasons, political disagreements, reassignment or silence. This is how such systems often end, not with a single dramatic collapse, but with departures that gradually reveal what had been concealed by the appearance of control. President Trump's administration offers a laboratory in which loyalty can become more valuable than competence, repetition more useful than evidence, aggression more effective than explanation, and personal allegiance more important than institutional responsibility. The deeper danger is that intelligent people learn to justify the behaviour, reproduce it and eventually mistake their participation in it for political virtue. The political order begins to fracture, and their loyalty does not necessarily protect them.

Pam Bondi, former Attorney General, Tuls Gabbard, the former spy chief, and Karoline Leavitt, the former White House press secretary, are revealing precisely because they are not identical figures. Leavitt transformed the office of White House press secretary from an institution supposed to mediate between government and journalists into something closer to a combat platform. The press secretary became an amplifier. The exchange was no longer about what the administration had done, but about how effectively the administration could defeat the person asking. A press briefing ceases to be an information mechanism when the performance of dominance becomes more important than the transmission of information. The exchange is clipped, posted, shared, praised, attacked and recycled. A hostile question becomes a thirty-second video. The answer need not survive scrutiny if the clip survives the news cycle. The reporter could be recategorised as an enemy, a partisan, a "left-wing hack". Once that transformation occurs, the factual content of the question becomes secondary. The audience is invited to judge allegiance rather than accuracy. This is precisely the political psychology of propaganda. The public no longer asks, "Is the claim true?" It asks, "Whose side is this person on?" Plato's warning about persuasion without knowledge becomes particularly relevant here because propaganda does not require the elimination of facts. It requires only the destruction of a common procedure for deciding which facts deserve belief.



THE QUESTION IS NO LONGER WHY THE LEADER BEHAVED AS HE DID, BUT WHY SO MANY EDUCATED PEOPLE LEARNED TO MAKE HIS BEHAVIOUR APPEAR NORMAL. AND ISN'T IT HAPPENING, IN DIFFERENT FORMS, IN MANY OF OUR COUNTRIES?

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

career incentives and the destruction of independent sources of authority. The Roman imperial system offers another variation. Under emperors such as Tiberius and Domitian, proximity to power could be extraordinarily advantageous and extraordinarily dangerous. Court politics rewarded those who understood the ruler's psychology, but the same intimacy could make a courtier vulnerable when the ruler's suspicion changed direction. Tacitus understood that imperial power corrupts not only those who command but those who adapt themselves to command.

The personalised leader does not create loyal institutions; he creates loyal relationships within institutions. An institution survives a bad minister because its procedures remain stronger than the personality occupying the office. A personalised administration survives by weakening precisely those procedures.

He claims that "the more powerful than the weaker" naturally deserves more, and that laws can become instruments devised by the weak to restrain the strong. That argument has survived because it contains a temptation that democratic societies never permanently eliminate. Power can persuade people that its own success is evidence of its righteousness. If the leader wins, defeats opponents, humiliates journalists and forces institutions to retreat, supporters can interpret every victory as proof that he is right. Failure becomes sabotage by enemies. Criticism becomes persecution. Evidence becomes propaganda. Accountability becomes betrayal. The political system then develops an extraordinary capacity to convert contradiction into confirmation.

He insists that "to do injustice is the greatest of evils, and to suffer injustice is the next greatest evil." Political systems obsessed with humiliation, victory and retaliation teach their servants to fear losing power more than becoming corrupted by it. Once retaining the leader's favour becomes the supreme political good, every compromise with truth can be rationalised as necessary. The official who knows a claim is false can repeat it. The official who knows a policy is failing can defend it. The official who sees an institution being degraded can convince herself that she is protecting democracy by remaining inside the room.

"He who fights with monsters should look to it that he himself does not become a monster." Its political meaning is harsher. Opposition movements can reproduce the habits of the power they oppose. When criticism becomes treason and disagreement becomes existential, the result is not merely bad government but epistemic decay-the loss of a shared basis for deciding what happened.

The question is no longer why the leader behaved as he did, but why so many educated people learned to make his behaviour appear normal. And isn't it happening, in different forms, in many of our countries?

PIC TALK



People take part in a 'Kanwar Yatra' procession on the last Monday of the holy month of 'Shravan', in Ajmer, Rajasthan. PHOTO: PTI



SAKSHI
SETHI

2ND OPINION

A child steps onto a stage, gives a flawlessly rehearsed line, smiles at precisely the correct moment and waits while a teacher adjusts the camera. The performance is replayed because someone blinked. Then again because the background was untidy. Finally, the perfect shot is captured. Within hours, it emerges online with joyful music, polished captions and a message celebrating experiential learning. But halfway between the first take and the last reel, an uncomfortable question arises: Was the activity created for the child to learn or for the school to be seen?

Social media has surely changed how schools communicate. Parents today want glimpses of classroom life. Photographs and films may attractively document success, highlight ingenuity and give families a glimpse

Schools are not content factories

into situations they would otherwise miss. There is nothing intrinsically wrong with a school showing its work. The trouble occurs when presenting the work increasingly becomes the work itself. True education is rarely flashy or photogenic. It often looks quiet and plain. It shows up as a sudden, messy question that stops a class to start a new talk. It is the simple loop of reading, thinking, trying, failing and getting better. This slow work does not make a flashy 30-second video, but a synchronised dance does. And that is where the trap begins. Most schools today face an increasingly competitive environment. Their social-media feeds now serve as quiet digital brochures. A colourful activity, an impressive celebration or a confident child speaking before a camera can communicate vibrancy far more quickly than examination results, teacher training or carefully planned classroom instruction. But what happens when visibility begins influencing educational priorities?

Teachers already hold responsibilities that extend well beyond teaching. Between lesson preparation, grading, meetings and the pressure to capture social-media-worthy classroom pictures and videos, teachers are stretched past their breaking point. A hidden concern is what children learn from this culture. When every activity and achievement requires a photo or public display, children may start viewing participation purely as a performance and success solely as a bid for applause.

Activities which were meant to spark curiosity instead turn into staged photo opportunities. Extroverted children

become the visible face of the school, while introverted ones making massive academic progress remain invisible because real growth doesn't photograph well. This creates a dangerous definition of success. Schools must ask whether the constant recording strips away the authenticity of childhood. A science experiment does not become more educational because it was uploaded. A plantation drive is not more meaningful because children posed beside saplings. Kindness does not need a hashtag to become valuable. Some of the profound educational moments simply cannot and should not be captured. The goal is not to quit social media entirely, which is impractical. Instead, schools must re-establish their core priorities, ensuring that genuine education always comes before documentation.

Schools must evaluate activities by a simple standard: is it worth doing if it isn't posted online? Parents too can support this shift by looking past social-media metrics to demand deeper quality such as critical thinking, teacher support and true student growth. Because schools are not production houses, teachers are not content creators, and children are not marketing assets. Educational success outlives fleeting digital attention; its true value is measured by what remains when the cameras are turned off.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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INDIA MUST BREAK THE COACHING TRAP

India's growing coaching culture is a symptom of a deeper crisis in higher education and employment. The answer is not more coaching centres, but stronger government colleges, better teaching and greater job creation.

The Union and State governments must establish more quality government colleges, equipped with competent faculty and adequate infrastructure. Teachers should be recruited through transparent, rigorous and corruption-free processes. Quality education must become a public responsibility rather than a privilege available mainly to those who can afford expensive coaching.

Colleges should encourage independent learning, critical thinking and strong academic foundations so students can compete successfully in entrance and recruitment examinations without becoming dependent on

coaching institutes. The employment crisis also needs urgent attention. The growing number of graduates and competitive-exam aspirants cannot be accommodated without creating sufficient opportunities in both government and private sectors. Education without employment prospects only deepens frustration.

Coaching centres, if permitted to function, must be strictly regulated by an independent statutory authority. Minimum standards, qualified teachers, transparent operations and reasonable fee structures should be mandatory. Parents and students must be protected from commercial exploitation.

The obsession with coaching has turned education into a costly race. India must restore the primacy of classrooms, teachers and merit. Sustainable way forward.

VANDANA | CHANDIGARH

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Onam must rise above celebration

Onam is more than a harvest festival or an elaborate feast. It celebrates Kerala's rich cultural heritage while carrying a timeless message of equality, compassion and social harmony. The legend of King Mahabali evokes an era remembered for dignity, prosperity and fairness.

At a time when commercialisation increasingly overshadows traditional celebrations, Onam offers an opportunity to return to its deeper values. The festival should bring people together, transcending barriers of caste, creed, religion and social status. Unity and mutual respect must remain central to its spirit.

Celebrations must also become environmentally responsible. Avoiding single-use plastics and creating traditional Pookalam with locally available, natural flowers can help protect the environment without compromising tradition. Most importantly, Onam should be a festival of sharing.

Let this Onam be more than feasting and festivities. Let it strengthen our commitment to unity, harmony, environmental responsibility and compassion. Preserving these values will ensure that Onam remains meaningful and continues to inspire generations to come, while reminding us that true celebration lies in kindness, inclusion and collective responsibility.

JUBEL D'CRUZ | MUMBAI

Confidence must be backed by capability

Apropos "Confidence is India's New Neighbourhood Doctrine" (August 24, 2026). External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's formulation that India must engage China from a position of confidence is coherent, but doctrine and reality are two different things.

India still runs a substantial trade deficit with China and remains dependent on it for rare earths, APIs and electronic components. Despite years of emphasis on Atma Nirbhar Bharat, this dependence has not been meaningfully reduced. Confidence without the industrial and economic strength to support it risks remaining an aspiration rather than a strategy.

On Bangladesh, the contradiction is equally visible. Allowing Sheikh Hasina to deliver a politically charged address from Indian soil while simultaneously emphasising mutual interest and confident neighbourly engagement sends mixed signals to a government in Dhaka that India needs as a partner. Pakistan's evolving security ties with Saudi Arabia and Turkey add pressure on India's strategic environment. Confident words alone cannot address these challenges. Whether this doctrine becomes lasting policy or remains rhetoric will be judged through factories, border agreements and sustained diplomacy.

K CHIDANAND KUMAR | BENGALURU

Teach children the value of money

A tragic incident in Sambhajinagar, Maharashtra, in which a teenage boy and his parents died while trying to prevent him from risking his life at a tourist spot, has raised concerns about parental guidance and financial awareness among children. Reports suggest the boy was distressed because his demand for an expensive mobile phone could not be fulfilled.

Such incidents highlight a larger concern. The old saying, "Amdani athanni aur kharcha rupaiya" - spend within your means - remains relevant. Yet, in an age of showmanship and consumerism, families often spend beyond their means, sometimes relying on loans and creating financial stress. Parents must also be honest with children about their financial limitations instead of creating the impression that every demand can be met. Children should be taught to distinguish between needs and wants and to understand the value of patience, effort and saving.

Similarly, parents should assess a child's interests and abilities before spending heavily on coaching or education. Blind competition can leave young people frustrated and unprepared for their careers. Love children unconditionally, but make them financially responsible and self-reliant. Teaching them the value of money today can help them make wiser choices tomorrow.

SUNIL OKHADE | INDORE

Commercialisation is killing middle-class dreams

The institutions once created to democratise opportunity are increasingly beginning to resemble marketplaces. The question India must now confront is uncomfortable: when education becomes a privilege that only the affluent can comfortably afford, what happens to the promise of merit, mobility and equal opportunity?



VK
BAHUGUNA

The recent agitation at Jantar Mantar, Jharkhand, and in many other states over paper leaks has shaken the conscience of the nation. The spark ignited by the unwarranted UGC guidelines dividing students and the country along caste lines was overtaken by the paper leak controversy and put the country into utter turmoil, which was exploited by anti-national forces, as in previous two agitations. The recent police actions and exposures on paper leaks have proved that senior professors and a chain of people responsible for conducting the exams were found deeply involved in this racket, which clearly proves the cesspool of the Indian education system. Let me discuss how the changes have occurred since people like me from the middle class got admitted and completed a Master's degree and my son got admitted in 2001 in B Tech at IIT Delhi and completed B Tech with a very nominal yearly fee of less than eighteen thousand. Today, it is not possible for a Group A officer to admit his children to private medical colleges as the fees are exorbitantly high.

Let us examine this issue as, across the length and breadth of India, an unspoken tragedy is unfolding inside middle-class homes. The desperate parents are looking at their life savings, calculating property values, and wondering if they can afford to keep their child's dreams alive. The outrage exploding among Indian youth today is not merely about leaked question papers or compromised examinations. Those are just the visible sparks landing on a massive economic despair. Beneath the headlines lies a far deeper, more insidious crisis: the outright commercialisation of higher education. A seat in a classroom — once viewed as a gateway out of poverty — has been transformed into a high-yield investment asset class. Today, education, instead of realising the dreams of parents, is being choked by the heavy ash of commercial greed.

How did a nation that built its identity on accessible public education allow its finest institutions to become playgrounds for financial privilege? Publicly funded institutions were originally established to democratise excellence using taxpayers' money. Today, their fee structures reflect a sharp corporate turn, functioning under the banner of financial self-sustainability.

At premier management institutes like IIM Ahmedabad, Bangalore, and Calcutta, the flagship two-year Post Graduate Programme in Management fee stands at approximately ₹24.5 lakh to ₹27.5 lakh. When personal expenses, books, and living costs are added, the total bill easily pushes towards ₹30 lakh to ₹35 lakh. For a standard four-year B Tech degree across Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), tuition fees sit at ₹1,00,000 per semester. Additional institutional fees, mess overheads, and hostel charges are factored in, a student spends ₹9.5 lakh to ₹13.9 lakh across four years. For families locked out of the hyper-competitive government medical seats, private medical colleges demand anywhere from ₹50 lakh to well over ₹1.5 crore for an undergraduate degree.

Now look at the inequality chasm: costs versus average Indian income. The paradox of India's higher education pricing becomes stark when evaluated against the economic reality of an ordinary citizen. India's average net annual per capita income is approximately ₹2,08,000. The tuition and programme fees of an IIM MBA (₹27.5 lakh) equal more than 13 years of an average Indian's total annual gross income. A four-year B.Tech at an IIT (₹11 lakh) consumes over five years of average annual earnings. A private medical seat costing ₹1 crore requires the equivalent of nearly 48 years of an average citizen's net income. To bridge this massive gap, families are forced into commercial banks where student loans carry interest rates ranging between 8.5 per cent and 13 per cent annually.

A student enters the workforce carrying a crushing debt burden before earning their first salary. Young graduates are forced to abandon careers in basic science, public service, or entrepreneurship simply to chase high-paying corporate roles needed to service monthly EMIs. I am reminded of the then Education Minister, Murli Manohar Joshi, who, in the government led by Atal Behari Vajpayee, questioned the fee hikes by the IIMs and IITs, but in the name of autonomy, he was criticised by these institutions. The question is, when government IIMs and IITs are becoming commercial and profiteering, then why not the private



A STUDENT ENTERS THE WORKFORCE CARRYING A CRUSHING DEBT BURDEN BEFORE EARNING THEIR FIRST SALARY. YOUNG GRADUATES ARE FORCED TO ABANDON CAREERS IN BASIC SCIENCE, PUBLIC SERVICE, OR ENTREPRENEURSHIP SIMPLY TO CHASE HIGH-PAYING CORPORATE ROLES NEEDED TO SERVICE MONTHLY EMIS

The writer is Former Director General of the 'Indian Council of Forestry Research and Education'. He is presently Chairman of the 'Centre for Resource Management and Environment'

ones? Another big fraud is the so-called Non-Resident Indian (NRI) quota. This mechanism of quota in medical and technical institutions functions as a legalised fast track, while meritorious poor students suffer. This system allows rich candidates with significantly lower entrance ranks to purchase seats simply because they can pay three to five times the regular fee.

When money buys entry while merit sits on a waiting list, the social contract between the state and its youth shatters.

Though the Supreme Court of India recently slammed expanded definitions of the NRI quota as a "money-spinning tactic" and a "fraud" on merit, institutional loopholes continue to monetise education. Other countries offer a stark contrast; many developed nations treat higher education as vital public infrastructure rather than a commercial enterprise. For example, in Germany, public universities charge zero tuition fees for undergraduate programmes, and in France, higher education is heavily state-subsidised, with public university tuition set at nominal rates (often under 250 euros per year for standard degrees). In Norway, Finland, and Denmark, public universities operate under state-funded models, ensuring higher education remains a public right free from commercial exploitation. These countries understand a basic principle: an educated youth yields higher tax bases, stronger innovation, and better civic governance over a lifetime.

Learning in India is becoming a profit-driven marketplace, leading to fundamental distortions. First, it results in the denial of access to higher education at an affordable cost. Secondly, meritocracy is subverted, and wealth replaces talent and hard work as the primary gateway to elite professions. Third, families are plunged into multi-generational debt, turning higher education into a debt trap. When medical graduates pay over a crore for an MBBS, the market pressure to recover that capital inflates healthcare costs for the entire country.

I would like to earnestly request the Prime Minister and all political parties to forge a consensus on drastically reforming the education sector. A National Education Fee Task Force should be set up to assess the cost of education first in government and private institutions by taking all parameters into account. A massive scheme should be launched by an Act of Parliament to make higher education accessible and affordable.

The Central and State Governments, operating alongside judicial oversight, must act immediately.

This task force must be legally empowered to audit and cap fees, establish strict, transparent fee ceilings for all professional degrees, ie Medical, Engineering, Management, and Law, across both public and private sectors, strictly according to actual operational costs rather than profit margins or aggressive capital expansion.

The task force must abolish monetised quotas and eliminate commercial seats such as the NRI quota in private and state institutions, ensuring seat allocation remains strictly merit-based. Further, it must ensure subsidised student loan interest rates for lower — and middle-income families. We must realise that a nation that sells its classrooms to the highest bidder sells its own future. It is time to stop treating higher education as a wind-fall commercial enterprise and restore it as a sacred public trust.

Bihar's jobs politics: From promises to reality



GYAN BHADRA

30-40 companies will visit Purnea, reportedly with Rahul Gandhi in attendance, to offer jobs to roughly the same number of youths. Two politicians, two nearly identical figures, one obvious question: whose number is bigger matters far less than how many of these jobs actually show up on the ground. Kishor's plan leans on personal capital rather than public office. He has said he intends to draw on his corporate contacts to link unemployed youth with hiring companies, and has reportedly travelled outside Bihar recently to meet business associates toward that end.

Manoj Bharti, Jan Suraj's state president, has been blunt about what this means in practice: these will be private-sector jobs, not government ones, and most will be located outside Bihar altogether, since — in his own assessment — the state lacks companies capable of absorbing that scale of hiring. That distinction between government and private employment is not incidental; it is central to Kishor's own argument. During the 2025 Bihar assembly campaign, he pointed out that only about 23 lakh people have entered government service across all 75 years of Bihar's history — from peon to chief secretary — a mere 1.97 percent of the state's population. Even raising reservation to 100 percent on the ten lakh government jobs politicians love to cite, he noted, would still leave 98 percent of Biharis outside the government payroll.

That reality is what pushed him toward a private-sector, network-driven route instead — and it's a route with a structural limit built in: an MLA has no authority to hand out private jobs. At best, Kishor can be a matchmaker between companies and candidates, which makes his promise unusually easy to measure, and unusually easy to expose if it falls short.

The metrics that will actually matter go well beyond how many young people submit applications. What counts is how many get interviews, how many receive offer letters, and — critically — how many are still employed six months or a year later. A job that evaporates after a few weeks, or one that pays too little to change a family's fortunes, cannot honestly be called employment generation. Pappu Yadav's Purnea initiative invites the same scrutiny. Company visits and Rahul Gandhi's high-profile presence generate headlines, but neither tells us how many actual vacancies exist or how many candidates will walk out with a job.

Bihar has seen enough job fairs in its metros to know the pattern well: large turnouts, stacks of resumes collected, interviews conducted, photographs taken for the record — and often very little hiring that actually follows once the cameras leave. An offer letter followed by an actual joining date is the only meaningful marker of success; everything before that is process, not outcome. This scrutiny matters more in Bihar than almost anywhere else, because employment has become one of the state's most potent — and most abused — political currencies. Generations of young Biharis have spent years preparing for government exams, only to be undone by leaked papers and recruitment scandals, while the private sector has never grown fast enough to absorb the numbers entering the job market each year.

Given that history, when Yadav says he has created jobs "for decades," the fair follow-up is: how many, doing what, for which companies, at what pay, and for how long? Bharti has essentially issued the same challenge — asking Yadav to place his employment record, government or private, in the public domain for Purnea and Bihar at large. The same standard should bind Kishor. If Bankipur's 10,000-job target is real, the honest move is to publish the whole funnel: applications received, shortlists made, participating companies, interviews held, offers extended, and — the number that matters most — how many actually joined. Yadav's Purnea event deserves identical transparency: the companies involved, vacancy counts, roles, salaries, appointment letters issued, and joining figures.

That level of disclosure is what would finally move Bihar's employment politics past sloganeering — beyond vague talk of recruitment drives, skill missions and industrial investment — toward what young people actually need: appointment letters, dependable pay, and a career rather than a string of temporary gigs. Bihar's population skews remarkably young, and government jobs alone were never going to absorb it; the state needs private capital, manufacturing, services, entrepreneurship and skilling investment working together, including opportunities beyond its own borders.

Both leaders' plans have genuine potential if pursued seriously — Kishor's network-driven bridge-building and Yadav's company-outreach model are different routes to the same destination. For Kishor, delivering on Bankipur could become a defining achievement; falling short would turn it into a cautionary headline. For Yadav, a successful Purnea rollout would finally give substance to years of claims about employment generation. In the end, Bihar's youth are unlikely to be swayed by another round of grand announcements. They will measure both men by the appointment letters that land in their hands. The question worth asking, then, isn't who promised 10,000 jobs — it's who actually delivered them.

The writer is a veteran journalist and social activist



NAVNEET ANAND

sets a trap. She orders the marital bed carried out of the chamber. And the man who outlasted Troy, the Cyclops and ten years at sea finally breaks, because that bed cannot be carried anywhere. He built it around the trunk of a living olive tree, still rooted in the ground, and raised the room around it.

That is how she knows him. Not by the face, which 20 years have changed, and not by the plunder or the fame. He is recognised because one thing of his could not be moved. I watched that scene in a Noida multiplex on a Sunday afternoon, and found I could not swallow.

We file *the Odyssey* under adventure. It is nothing of the kind. It is a migration story, and it happens to be ours. According to the 2011 Census, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar emerged as India's largest sources of inter-state migrants, together accounting for 20.9 million people, or 37 per cent of the country's total inter-state migrant population. Delhi and Mumbai stood out as major migrant destinations.

There is a moment near the end of Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* that the film refuses to hurry. Odysseus is home after twenty years. Penelope will not have him, so she

Through the 1980s and 1990s and into the 2000s, middle and lower middle class families across the Hindi belt reached the same conclusion at roughly the same time: that land was finite, that a government job was a lottery, and that the only asset which could not be partitioned among brothers was a degree. Plots were sold, jewellery pledged, sons put on trains to Bangalore and to the coaching lanes of Mukherjee Nagar.

They were right. Education was the finest investment available to them and it paid, in salaries their fathers could not have imagined and in a confidence their districts had never been allowed. Distance became degrees, degrees became salary, salary became square feet. Nobody was wrong to board that train.

I was one of them. I left Hajipur, a small town in Bihar, for Delhi, chasing something I have still not caught. None of it troubled me while my father was alive. As long as he was, the town stayed mine, because I was somebody's son in a place that knew what that meant. He died in January. It did not only take a father. It cut a cord.

The psychologist Pauline Boss calls this ambiguous loss: grief that never closes, because what you have lost is neither fully gone nor recoverable. The town is exactly where it always was. The lanes, the school, the tea shop at the



turning. I can go back any week I choose. I cannot return. There is no ritual for this, and no leave application that covers it.

What I notice now is what the town had that no city sells. My parents, in their last years, were attended by four people. Eye drops on schedule, tea at the right hour, whatever food they asked for, arriving. In Noida my domestic help fails to turn up one morning and by evening the house is a battlefield.

sucked into the nothingness of materialism, while losing the sense of belonging to somewhere. Simone Weil wrote in 1949 that to be rooted is the most important and least recognised need of the human soul. Her more uncomfortable observation is the one worth sitting with. Uprootedness, she said, is contagious. The uprooted go on to uproot others. Which brings me to the part I find hardest to write.

My children will leave too and they will go

where the work is, exactly as I did, and I have no standing to object, because I am the one who taught them that mobility and ambition are the same word. I do not know how many years I will live near them, or whether the arithmetic of care my parents took for granted will exist by the time it is my turn. Two generations have been built on the assumption that families can rearrange themselves at will and the bonds will hold anyway. Nobody has done the accounting on what that costs at the far end.

Education is a ladder. It must not become a blinker. Those of us no longer hostage to an employer's geography, still free to steer our wings in any direction, might ask what we are using that freedom for. Freedom exercised only to accumulate is not freedom. It is a longer leash.

On Calypso's island, Odysseus is offered immortality and eternal youth if he will only stay. He turns it down for a mortal wife and a rocky, unimportant island. Most of us have made the opposite trade, in instalments, without ever being asked to sign.

And in the first book of the poem, long before Odysseus himself appears, his son Telemachus leaves home to go looking for a father he cannot remember. We have raised a generation of Telemachuses. The question is whether we have left them anything to sail towards. Anything that, when the time comes, cannot be moved.

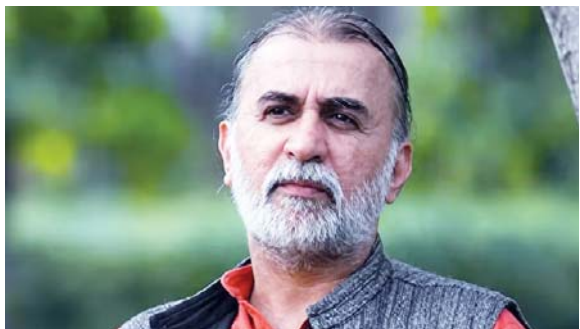
The writer is a commentator and strategic communications expert

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Order Order

Supreme Court to pass order on Tarun Tejpal's exemption plea



The Supreme Court on Monday said it will pass orders on journalist Tarun Tejpal's plea for exemption from surrendering after he was convicted of rape and sentenced to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment by the Bombay high court. A single-judge bench of Justice Alok Aradhe reserved its decision after Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Goa government, said Tejpal's plea was not maintainable as the journalist had not filed a separate application for exemption from surrendering.

He said the plea was not maintainable also for the reason that Tejpal had not furnished a certificate that he had already surrendered as per the Supreme Court Rules, 2013.

At the outset, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Tejpal, submitted that the Supreme Court Rules did not apply to the case as the high court had already granted him four weeks to surrender.

Mehta referred to earlier top court decisions and said that where the appeal has been filed, it shall expressly state whether the convict has surrendered or not.

He said in the case where the convict has not surrendered, the appeal should not be accepted unless accompanied by an exemption application from surrendering.

Mehta said, "The existence of the appeal is dependent on either filing a certificate that he has surrendered or, alternatively, he will have to pray for exemption from surrendering. These are only two options. Look at the seriousness of the matter."

Sibal urged the bench to list the matter on August 31 before the regular bench as Tejpal has time till the first week of September to surrender.

"I don't know why my friend (Mehta) insists that I must go to jail when I'm protected... We are not seeking any extension. I'm already protected. Please list the matter on August 31," Sibal urged the bench.

The bench said that it would pass orders in the matter and reserved its decision.

On Monday, Tejpal's plea was listed in chamber matters, where cases are taken up for preliminary or procedural directions and then placed before a regular bench for hearing. (PTI)

TMCP foundation day: Calcutta High Court to hear rival pleas



The Calcutta High Court will on Tuesday hear two separate petitions by the student wings of two rival TMC groups seeking permission to hold programmes on the Trinamool Chatra Parishad (TPCP) foundation day on August 28. The lawyers for the two rival groups mentioned their respective petitions before the court, seeking an urgent hearing.

Justice Sougata Bhattacharyya said the two petitions will be taken up for hearing on Tuesday. The Mamata Banerjee faction's lawyer Arko Nag mentioned the matter before the court, seeking an urgent hearing of its petition for permission to hold the programme at Mayo Road in central Kolkata on August 28.

He stated that the authorities have rejected their application for permission to hold the foundation day programme.

The lawyer for the other TMCP group also mentioned its petition, seeking permission to hold the programme at the same venue at the same time. (PTI)

to the top court last month, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) had alleged that the state was not cooperating in providing the records as directed by the court.

"I (state) would need a week to place the facts on record," Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state, told the bench on Monday.

He said that pursuant to the apex court's August 3 order, the chief secretary and principal secretary (Home) of Arunachal Pradesh were present in court.

"We will be able to satisfy the court that they (directions) are complied with in letter and spirit," Mehta said, adding that the state has



SC seeks response from States, UTs on footpaths

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The existence of footpaths is an integral part of human life, the Supreme Court said on Monday while directing all States and Union Territories to respond on the implementation of its directions for properly demarcated, encroachment-free space for pedestrians.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe impleaded all the states and Union Territories as parties in the suo motu case on ensuring properly demarcated footpaths, wherever there is a road.

"The first step is proper demarcation of space for

pedestrians. There should be confidence of safety in walking. Wherever there is a road, people should walk in the demarcated space," the bench told Additional Solicitor General KM Nataraj, appearing for the Centre.

The ASG brought to the notice of the bench that since roads are a State subject, the Ministry of Road, Transport and Highways (MoRTH) and the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) have issued advisories to all the states and Union Territories, besides the National Highways Authority of India for creation of proper demarcated space for pedestrians, in compliance of the directions of the court.



The bench asked the states and UTs to reply to these advisories issued by the ministries, saying, "the existence of footpaths is an integral part of human life".

On August 3, the bench directed the Centre to ensure that every road had a properly demarcated

space for pedestrians.

It had asked the Centre to instruct the authorities concerned to make sure that the space meant for walking is not encroached upon and is properly separated from motor vehicle lanes.

The apex court had emphasised that pedestrians should

have confidence that the space is meant for them and they can walk freely without any threat of moving vehicles.

On June 19, in a significant verdict, the top court had held that the right to walk on a demarcated footpath is a fundamental right.

It held that this right shall have priority over motorised vehicles on demarcated paths, and it forms part of the right to movement guaranteed under Article 19 (1) (d) and other fundamental rights, including Article 21 (right to life and liberty).

The top court said that a citizen's fundamental right to walk on a demarcated footpath is primary and shall have priority over movement by motorised vehicles," it had ruled.

by motorised vehicles.

The declaration by the top court came in an unfortunate motor accident compensation case where a father lost his five-year-old son while taking him to school.

"The right to walk is a fundamental right under Part III of the Constitution. It is integral to the right to movement guaranteed under Article 19(1)(d), read with Article 19(1)(a), Article 19(1)(b), Article 19(1)(c) and Article 21 of the Constitution of India. The fundamental right to walk will take within its sweep the right to demarcated footpaths. These rights are primary and shall have priority over movement by motorised vehicles," it had ruled.

Delhi HC cautions against personality rights use to snuff out caricature, parody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has cautioned against the invocation of personality rights to extinguish caricature, lampooning, or parody which may not be commercially exploitative.

The court made the observation while granting protection to Physics Wallah founder Alakh Pandey against the use of his name, image, and other attributes for impersonation and monetisation by third parties.

The educator alleged that several internet platforms and users were monetising his name, image, etc, through social media posts, sticker packs, videos, websites, and such like means. Some of this content was vulgar and sexually explicit, he contended.

In the interim order passed on August 5, Justice



Anup J Bhambhani opined that he would grant protection to Pandey for three sets of violations: content that is sexually vulgar, content that monetises his personality without any licence, and impersonation.

"In the opinion of this court, the concept of personality rights as has been claimed in the present matter may be overbroad and therefore susceptible to misappli-

cation," the court said.

The court said it wants to ensure that personality rights are not deployed to prevent dissemination of information in relation to wrongdoing, or to extinguish an entire genre of expression, including caricature, lampooning, or parody which may not amount to commercial exploitation of an individual's personality or publicity rights.

Inquiry needed into affairs of Virender Dev Dixit's ashrams: Delhi HC after CBI says he is dead

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday said an inquiry was needed into the affairs of the ashrams of self-styled spiritual preacher Virender Dev Dixit, as society has every reason to know about the activities going on there, after it was informed by the CBI that he is dead.

The court was hearing a matter related to allegations that several women and girls are held in illegal confinement at the Adhyatmik Vishwa Vidhyalaya ashram in Rohini in north-west Delhi.

A bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya



and Justice Tejas Karia directed the station house officer of Delhi's Vijay Vihar police station to register a missing person case and initiate a probe after it was informed by ashram women that an inmate was missing while her belongings were still lying on the premises.

During the course of proceedings, the court was also informed by the counsel for

the CBI that Dixit, who had been absconding for a long time, is dead now.

"Courts cannot interfere with their activities provided they are not disturbing the public order. That is the only test. But nobody can be left unaccountable. The peers of the ashram cannot be left unaccountable. Somebody should be there and, if nobody comes forward, the State will take it over," the bench said.

The court was informed that the missing woman's parents were severely ill with no one else to look after them in their advanced age. They wished to meet their daughter, whom they spoke

to over a video call, but she had refused to visit them.

The bench said, "We are of the opinion that the affairs of the ashrams and the manner in which they are being run need to undergo an inquiry."

"Since respondent 4 (woman inmate) is said to be missing though her luggage and belongings are lying in the Rohini Ashram, we direct the SHO of Vijay Vihar police station to register a case of missing person and conduct an inquiry into the whereabouts of respondent 4."

The court directed the SHO to complete the inquiry and apprise it of the outcome on August 31, the next date of hearing.

Jharkhand HC refuses stay on notification cancelling appointments of FROs, seeks Government response

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Jharkhand High Court on Monday refused to grant a stay order on a Government notification cancelling appointments of Forest Range Officers.

The court ordered the State Government to file a response in the matter and fixed September 24 as the next date of hearing.

The JMM-led Government had on August 18 cancelled 22 examinations, including that of FROs and



ordered a probe into 23 other tests, conducted since 2014, amid a weeks-long students' agitation

over alleged irregularities in recruitment exams.

On August 22, the high court stayed the notifica-

tions cancelling the appointments of Child Development Project Officers (CDPOs) and those recruited through the JSSC-CGL examination.

The court on August 21 had stayed the notifications cancelling the 11th and 13th Jharkhand PSC exams, besides putting a clamp on the order scrapping the appointments of food safety officers.

The high court also made it clear that on September 15, it will hear the matter at 12.15 pm, earlier than the scheduled 2.15 pm.

or SIT probe into the matter.

During Monday's hearing, advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner NGOs, asked whether the materials collected and examined by the CBI during the preliminary inquiry so far were not sufficient to register a regular case.

The bench said the issue had to be examined by the CBI.

The top court also agreed to hear a separate plea related to the issue and asked Mehta to take instructions and file a counter affidavit, if necessary.

The bench noted that the chief secretary and the principal secretary (Home) of Arunachal Pradesh had also filed an affidavit. It allowed the

petitioner to file a reply to the affidavit within two weeks.

At the flag end of the hearing, Bhushan requested the bench to direct the CBI to file a fresh status report by the next date of hearing. "The CBI shall also submit a fresh status report," the bench said. While hearing the matter on August 3, the top court had sought responses from the chief secretary and principal secretary (Home) of Arunachal Pradesh after the CBI claimed "non-cooperation" by the state.

In its April 6 order, the top court had directed the Arunachal Pradesh Government and all its concerned departments, authorities and instrumentalities to

fully cooperate with the CBI.

It had observed that the state and its instrumentalities cannot confer benefits according to the "whims of any political or administrative functionary".

It had said the matter was a fit case for an "independent investigation".

"Accordingly, we deem it appropriate that CBI shall register a preliminary enquiry forthwith and shall conduct a time-bound investigation into the award and execution of the public works contracts and work orders which form the subject matter of this writ petition and the affidavits filed in these proceedings," it had said.



Gujarat HC rejects bail plea of AAP MLA Chaitar Vasava in assault case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court on Monday rejected the bail plea of Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) MLA Chaitar Vasava in an assault and extortion case in which he was sentenced to seven years' imprisonment along with eight others by a sessions court in Narmada district.

Vasava has not yet been disqualified as a member of the State Assembly.

A single bench of Justice Vimal K Vyas rejected Vasava's plea for suspension of sentence and observed that being a member of the legislative assembly, he ought to have guided the aggrieved persons to seek lawful remedies rather than resort to intimidation and coercion Government employees, as materials on record

prima facie reflect.

"(The MLA) resorted to arranging and paying compensation to the individuals who had encroached upon the forest lands and undertaken unauthorised cultivation. Such conduct of the applicant, who is an MLA, raises the question of propriety in the context of the

public office he holds," the court noted in its order.

It also said that even after being on bail in another offence subject to a condition against misuse of the liberty so granted, he openly breached the condition and continued to involve himself in further offences for the benefit of his supporters.

SC issues notice on plea over forest rights near PEKB coal block



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday sought responses from the Union Government, the Chhattisgarh Government and the Rajasthan Rajya Vidyut Utpadan Nigam Ltd (RRVUNL) on a plea seeking enforcement of community forest rights of residents of a village near the Parsa East and Kete Basen (PEKB) coal block.

Community forest rights in Chhattisgarh give local tribal groups and forest dwellers legal power to protect, manage and use their traditional forest lands.

The top court issued notices to the Centre, the State Government, RRVUNL and the District Level Forest Rights Committee (DLC) of Surguja on the plea of the 'Hasdeo Aranya Bachao Sangharsh Samiti' (HABSS) and six others challenging the verdict of the Chhattisgarh High Court of April 21.

The High Court had dismissed an appeal filed by the Samiti and others challenging,

among other things, the cancellation of community forest rights claimed by villagers of Ghatbarra and subsequent approvals for Phase-II mining in the PEBK coal block.

In its direction on Monday, an apex court bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana said that the ongoing mining activities in the PEBK coal block in the State on behalf of the RRVUNL will remain unaffected due to the issuance of the notice on the plea.

Taking note of the submissions of senior advocate CU Singh, appearing for the 'Samiti', the CJI said that he was issuing notice to ascertain whether any community forest right existed in the instant case. If the answer is yes, then what remedial measures can be taken to explore enforcement of that right, the CJI said while making clear that the examination of this aspect does not impact the ongoing mining activities undertaken by RRVUNL in its captive coal block.

Enquiry into award of contracts in Arunachal Pradesh: SC seeks fresh status report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday asked the CBI to submit a fresh status report on its preliminary enquiry into allegations of preferential allotment of contracts in Arunachal Pradesh to firms allegedly owned by or linked to family members of Chief Minister Pema Khandu.

The Arunachal Pradesh Government told a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that it had complied with the apex court's direction to provide the CBI with the necessary records and documents.

In a status report submitted

to the top court last month, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) had alleged that the state was not cooperating in providing the records as directed by the court.

"I (state) would need a week to place the facts on record," Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state, told the bench on Monday.

He said that pursuant to the apex court's August 3 order, the chief secretary and principal secretary (Home) of Arunachal Pradesh were present in court.

"We will be able to satisfy the court that they (directions) are complied with in letter and spirit," Mehta said, adding that the state has

given all the documents to the probe agency.

The bench said it would give the state two weeks to place its stand on record.

When the bench was told that various documents have been handed over to the agency, it asked the CBI to confirm whether they have received them.

On April 6, the apex court had directed the CBI to register a preliminary enquiry within two weeks into allegations of preferential allotment of contracts in the State.

The top court had passed the order on a plea filed by NGOs Save Mon Region Federation and Voluntary Arunachal Sena seeking a CBI



Digital arrest: When fear wears a police uniform

Why citizens must understand the law before they surrender to a cybercriminal’s authority



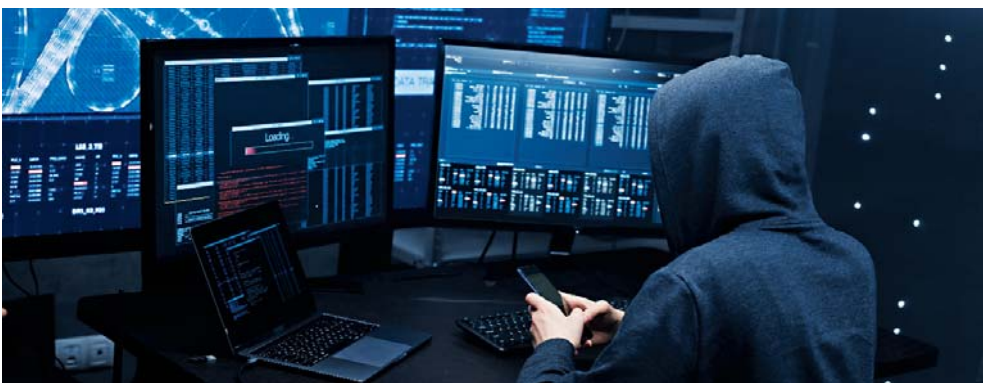
Dr KUMAR ASHISH, IPS

A phone rings. The caller introduces himself as a police officer, a CBI official, an Enforcement Directorate officer or sometimes even a judge. He informs you that your Aadhaar, mobile number, bank account or a parcel in your name has been linked to a serious criminal case. Within minutes, the conversation changes from an enquiry into an apparent crisis. You are told that you are under investigation, that an arrest warrant has been issued and that you must remain on a video call. You are instructed not to speak to anyone. Finally comes the demand for money-sometimes described as a "verification deposit", "security amount", "bail money" or "temporary transfer for investigation". This is a new kind of crime in which the criminal does not enter your house, break your lock or snatch your wallet. Instead, he enters your mind-- This is the Digital-Arrest Scam.

The very first fact every citizen must remember is fundamental: there is no legal procedure in India called "Digital Arrest". A video call cannot substitute for a lawful arrest. The Rajasthan High Court, while taking suo motu cognisance of the growing menace in January 2025, specifically observed that digital arrest has no legal standing in India.

The psychology behind the fraud

What makes this crime particularly dangerous is that it exploits something valuable-the public's trust in Law Enforcement. The fraudster does not merely impersonate an officer. He creates an entire theatre of authority. Fake identity cards, fabricated notices, police uniforms, official logos, simulated offices and even additional callers posing as senior officers are used to make the deception convincing. The victim is then isolated and kept continuously connected to the fraudsters. The isolation is deliberate. A frightened person who is not allowed to consult family, friends or a lawyer is much easier to manipulate. The criminal's greatest weapon, therefore, is not technology-it is "fear".



What does the law actually say about arrest?

The Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS), which governs criminal procedure, lays down a legal framework for arrest- Section 35 specifies circumstances in which a police officer may arrest without a warrant. Section 36 prescribes important requirements relating to the arresting officer and the arrest process. Section 38 recognises the arrested person's right to meet an advocate of his choice during interrogation, subject to the statutory framework. The BNSS also requires important safeguards concerning information about the grounds of arrest and communication to a relative or other nominated person.

Section 57 requires a person arrested to be taken before the Magistrate or officer in charge as prescribed, while Section 58 provides that an arrested person cannot ordinarily be detained for more than 24 hours without the requisite judicial authority, subject to the statutory exceptions. Section 62 makes it explicit that arrest must be made strictly in accordance with the Sanhita.

These provisions illustrate an important principle: arrest is an exercise of legal power surrounded by procedural safeguards. It is not

a threat that an unknown caller can manufacture over WhatsApp.

Here, we must understand that the BNSS does provide for electronic service of summons in specified circumstances. That, however, should not be confused with a so-called digital arrest. A genuine electronic summons is part of a formal legal process; it is not an instruction to transfer money to a private bank account.

Which laws can apply to the fraudsters?

There is no single offence in

the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita called "digital arrest". The expression describes the modus operandi. The actual offences have to be determined from the conduct proved during investigation. For example, BNS Section 318 deals with cheating. It covers deception that dishonestly or fraudulently induces a person to deliver property or to do something that causes, or is likely to cause, harm. The statutory illustration itself recognises cheating through false representation of official status. BNS Section 319 deals with cheating by personation and can be relevant where criminals impersonate officials or other persons to deceive victims.

Where fear or threats are used to obtain money, Section 308, relating to extortion, may also become relevant depending upon the facts. More complex cases may involve offences relating to forgery, forged electronic or documentary material, conspiracy, organised crime or provisions of the Information Technology Act, 2000. The precise sections, however, must always be determined by the investigating agency on the evidence available in the particular case.

The digital trail is often the evidence trail

A victim may instinctively delete the offending messages or block the caller. From an investigative perspective, that can be a mistake- The Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023 expressly recognises electronic and digital records. Section 61 provides that an electronic or digital record cannot be denied admissibility merely because it is electronic or digital, subject to

Section 63. Sections 62 and 63 prescribe the framework concerning electronic records and their admissibility. Therefore, a victim should preserve, wherever available:

- phone numbers and caller IDs;
- WhatsApp or other chat messages;
- screenshots;
- emails;
- forged notices or identity cards;
- bank account numbers;
- UPI IDs and transaction references;
- URLs and social-media profiles;
- call details and other relevant digital material.

Hence, do not delete evidences out of embarrassment or fear.

The police response: follow the money, technology and network

Modern cybercrime investigation cannot stop with identifying the person who made the call. The caller may be only one component of a much larger network. Behind a digital-arrest operation may be persons procuring SIM cards, opening or controlling mule bank accounts, arranging forged documents, providing technical infrastructure and moving the proceeds through multiple accounts. This is why effective investigation requires simultaneous examination of the communication trail, digital trail and money trail.

The Government has established the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) to strengthen coordination against cybercrime. I4C has also provided technical support to State and Union Territory police and facilitated action against digital infrastructure, SIM cards and mule accounts associated with such frauds. For the victim, however, one principle is especially important- report the crime as the earliest possible.

Report immediately.

The national cybercrime helpline 1930 and the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal provide mechanisms for reporting cybercrime. The Government has specifically advised citizens receiving digital-arrest-type calls to report them immediately. In financial cyber fraud, every minute can matter. The faster the complaint reaches the financial and law-enforcement ecosystem, the greater the opportunity for tracing the transaction and attempting to prevent further movement of the money.

What should you do if you receive such a call?

The following five principles should become part of every family's digital safety habit:

- First, pause.**
Do not make a financial decision while frightened.
- Second, disconnect.**
There is no need to remain continuously connected to an unknown caller merely because he claims to be an officer.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is Deputy Inspector General of Police, Koshi Range, Saharsa, Bihar

India opened the reactor, not the fuel

SHANTI hands the reactor to the market and keeps the used fuel with the State. The draft rules should say what that promise costs and when it begins



NISHANT SAHDEV | **DEBARATI DAS**

India is planning the biggest expansion of nuclear power in its history. The target is 100 gigawatts of nuclear capacity by 2047. Today, the country has about 8.8 GW. Reaching the target would mean increasing the fleet more than elevenfold in little over two decades.

To make that possible, Parliament passed the SHANTI Bill, in December 2025. It replaced the Atomic Energy Act of 1962 and the Civil Liability for Nuclear Damage Act of 2010. For the first time, private companies can participate in building, owning and operating nuclear power plants in India.

Much of the debate has focused on the beginning of a plant's life: how much insurance an operator must carry, what happens after an accident, and whether foreign reactor designs can enter the Indian market. Those are important questions. But the more revealing feature of SHANTI is what it does not open.

The part the government kept for itself

SHANTI opens the reactor to private capital. It keeps key parts of the fuel cycle with the state.

Activities including uranium and thorium mining, uranium enrichment, reprocessing of spent fuel, management of high-level radioactive waste and heavy-water production remain within the government's exclusive domain.

Put the two sides together and the architecture becomes clear. A private company can build a reactor, own it, operate it for decades and sell the electricity. But it does not control the entire nuclear fuel cycle. The state remains responsible for critical activities at the front and back ends.

That is not necessarily an issue. In fact, it is arguably the right choice.

Enrichment and reprocessing are among the most sensitive parts of the nuclear fuel cycle because of their connection to weapons proliferation. India, which is outside the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, has particularly strong reasons to keep these capabilities under sovereign control.

But keeping the back end with the state creates a responsibility that



deserves far more attention than it has received.

A promise without a price tag

Once the government takes responsibility for spent fuel, the private nuclear business acquires a peculiar shape.

The operator earns revenue during the productive life of the reactor. The state inherits obligations that can extend far beyond it.

Spent nuclear fuel does not become harmless when it leaves a reactor. It must be cooled, stored, secured, transported and managed. If India eventually chooses geological disposal for high-level waste, the state will also have to develop and maintain a permanent disposal system.

That creates a long-term public liability.

The draft SHANTI Rules recognise the problem. They propose a dedicated Spent Fuel Management Fund to finance the subsequent management of spent fuel handed over to the Central Government. They also propose a Nuclear Liability Fund and separate financial security for decommissioning.

That is the right architecture. But architecture is not enough. The rules need to answer a more basic question:

How much money should a reactor contribute today for an obligation that may mature decades from now?

Four questions the rules should answer

First, how is the contribution calculated?

A spent-fuel charge could be based on electricity generated, the quantity of spent fuel produced or another formula. These approaches produce very different results.

A charge linked to electricity generation has one major advantage: collection begins when the reactor begins earning revenue. The financial obligation therefore grows alongside the activity creating the waste. **Second, who decides whether the contribution remains adequate?**

The draft framework provides for periodic review of nuclear-liability limits. The spent-fuel obligation deserves the same discipline.

Waste costs are unusually exposed to inflation, interest rates, technological changes and delays. A number calculated when a reactor begins operating may look entirely different when the reactor eventually shuts down.

A fund designed for a century-long problem cannot be treated as a number fixed on the day a plant receives its licence.

Third, is the money genuinely ring-fenced?

A fund is meaningful only if the money cannot quietly become part of the government's general fiscal pool.

The rules should require clear segregation, transparent reporting and independent audit. The Comptroller and Auditor General should be able to show Parliament how much has been collected, where it is held, how it is invested and how much has been spent.

Investors demand this kind of visibility from companies. The state should demand no less from itself

when it is accepting a liability that can last generations.

Fourth, and most importantly, when exactly does responsibility pass from the operator to the government?

This is where the draft rules need greater precision.

The handover problem

The draft requires financial security against nuclear damage to remain in place until all spent fuel has been removed from the spent-fuel storage pool.

That may be a workable point for one part of the liability framework. But removing fuel from a cooling pool does not make the long-term waste problem disappear.

It simply moves the fuel into the next stage of its journey.

The fuel may require dry storage, transport, further processing or eventual disposal. Each stage creates costs, risks and institutional responsibilities.

So the rules should distinguish between removing fuel from a reactor site and transferring long-term responsibility for that fuel.

India needs a legally defined handover point: a moment at which ownership, custody and long-term financial responsibility clearly pass to the government.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

Nishant Sahdev is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems. Debarati Das is a BSc Microbiology student at Adamas University and was a summer research intern under Sahdev

The invisible backbone: Data links in the age of unmanned warfare

Bharati Exicom's role and contribution across the unmanned industry, spanning airborne platforms, ground nodes and marine nodes on one secure network



ASHISH PADTE

Unmanned Systems: The New Centre of Gravity in Modern Warfare

Unmanned equipment has moved from the margins of military planning to the very centre of it. Across every recent conflict, unmanned aerial vehicles, ground robots and uncrewed surface vessels have emerged as among the most powerful and lethal instruments on the battlefield, and among the most cost-effective. A system costing a few lakh rupees can find, fix and destroy an asset worth hundreds of crores.

The importance is felt across all three domains. In the air, unmanned platforms now deliver persistent surveillance, precision strike and loitering-munition mass, providing airpower without the airframe cost. On the ground, unmanned ground vehicles carry sensors and lethal payloads into spaces too dangerous for troops, from high-altitude posts to urban clearances. At sea, uncrewed surface and sub-surface vessels are redefining littoral security and maritime strike. The common thread: lethal effect, delivered cheaply, at scale.

Why Drones Fail: The Data Link Is the Weakest Link

When unmanned missions have failed in recent conflicts, the post-mortem has pointed, again and again, to the same component: the data link.

A conventional communication link is vulnerable because it is easy to detect, easy to intercept and easy to kill. The moment the link dies, the most sophisticated platform in the world becomes an expensive projectile with no eyes and no ears.

Both sides of this contest are learning the technology every single day. The counter-UAS operator refines detection; the unmanned operator refines evasion. In such an environment, a data-link radio designed for yesterday's threat is already obsolete.

The radio must be adaptable and built for the future: hardware that is futuristic by design, able to adapt and upgrade its features in the field, so that critical transmissions remain secure, robust

find the platform by the heat it radiates.

- RF detection and interception: electronic-support sensors that find, fingerprint and intercept the radio link between the platform and its operator, then jam or hijack it.
- GPS jamming and spoofing: denying or falsifying satellite navigation so the platform loses its way, loiters blind, or is captured intact.

■ Thermal and heat-signature detection: electro-optical and infrared sensors that



and sovereign for the life of the platform.

A platform is only as survivable as its link. In unmanned warfare, the data link is not an accessory; it is the mission.

What Makes a Data Link Futuristic?

Four attributes separate a future-ready tactical data link from a commodity radio:

- **A true Software Defined Radio:** a multi-mission, multi-mode and multi-role radio that connects all end points on a single network, with capability delivered in software and upgraded over the platform's life.
- **An in-country waveform:** a nationally developed and controlled waveform that keeps the network secure and closes off every class of vulnerability that comes with foreign-controlled protocol stacks.
- **Multi-mission, multi-domain readiness:** one radio family connecting air, land and sea nodes on a single network, without compromising the security or the credibility of the link on any of them.
- **High data rates:** the throughput to move real-time high-speed video, critical mission data and real-time navigation information simultaneously, because a modern unmanned mission is a data-heavy mission.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is CEO, Exicom Technologies India. He brings over 20 years of experience in wireless technology and played a key role in building high-performing teams, driving cross-functional collaboration, and maintaining a strong customer-focused approach

te Shri G. S. Narang, member of Ordnance Factories Officers CGHS (OFOCGHS), Ayudh Vihar, Plot No. 3, Sector-13, Dwarka, New Delhi 110028, passed away in January 2022. I was the member of Flat No. A-46. I have no claims/objections, if any, regarding the transfer of the deceased member's assets/interest in the said flat to any civil/legal representative may be submitted to the OFOCGHS office within 30 days of publication of this notice. In the absence of any claim/objection, the Managing Committee shall proceed with the transfer formalities as per the records and applicable rules.

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Godrej Group to invest ₹20,000 crore in Haryana

Godrej Industries Group on Monday said it plans to invest about ₹20,000 crore in Haryana with the potential to create around 40,000 jobs.

The group has signed a memorandum of understanding with the Haryana Government in the presence of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, outlining its future investment plan in the state, Godrej Industries Group (GIG) said in a statement.

The proposed investments will build on the group's existing footprint in the state. GIG has invested approximately ₹12,000 crore in Haryana to date and employs around 9,000 people across its businesses, it added.

The group's real estate firm Godrej Properties Ltd (GPL) will be a key driver of the investment plans. Having invested approximately ₹11,000 crore in Haryana to date, GPL plans to invest a further ₹16,000 crore by FY28, it added.

The company currently has 18 projects across Gurugram, Sonipat, Faridabad, Panipat and Kurukshetra, with its future projects expected to create more than 11,000 jobs. Godrej Ventures, the real estate private equity business, has invested around Rs 1,000 crore in Haryana and plans to invest a further Rs 3,500 crore in Grade A+ office infrastructure in Gurugram, the statement said.

Non-audit taxpayers asked to file ITR by August 31

The income tax department on Monday nudged taxpayers with business or professional income who are not subject to audit to file ITRs for AY 2026-27 before August 31. Till August 20, over 2 crore ITR 3 and 4 were filed on the e-filing portal, taking the total Income Tax returns filed for AY27 to over 6.5 crore. This also includes over 5.9 crore ITR-1 and ITR-2, which were filed by the due date of July 31.

"31st August 2026 is the due date for filing ITRs for AY 2026-27 for taxpayers with business or professional income who are not subject to audit. Be the tax hero who files on time," the I-T department said in a post on X. If a taxpayer falls in the non-audit category, he/she can file the applicable ITR (ITR-3, ITR-4, ITR-5 or ITR-7).

ITR-3 is filed by individuals and Hindu Undivided Families (HUFs) with income from a proprietary business or profession.

Stock markets end lower amid simmering geopolitical tensions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Monday as persistent geopolitical tensions and elevated crude oil prices hampered risk appetite.

Investors remained cautious ahead of fresh US sanctions on Iran, experts said. Despite a positive beginning, the 30-share BSE Sensex failed to carry forward the momentum and declined 171.72 points, or 0.22 per cent, to settle at 77,369.11. During the day, it dropped 339.17 points, or 0.43 per cent, to 77,201.66. The 50-share NSE Nifty slipped 32.95 points, or 0.14 per cent, to end at 24,219.05.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Adani Ports, Bharat Electronics, Bajaj Finance, Bajaj Finserv, Trent, Axis Bank, State Bank of India, and Tata Consultancy Services were among the laggards. Tata Steel, HCL Tech, Infosys, and Hindustan Unilever were among the major winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 1.68 per cent to \$92.80 per barrel.

"Indian equity markets ended lower on Monday, tracking weakness across Asian markets as renewed concerns over the Middle East and selling in banking and financial stocks weighed on investor senti-

ment," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

"Markets remained cautious ahead of fresh US sanctions, with Washington promising an 'economic D-Day' against Iran and its trading partners, while Tehran threatened to halt Gulf oil exports in response, keeping investors wary of further escalation," he added.

The BSE MidCap Select index dipped 0.11 per cent, while SmallCap Select index was flat and ended marginally higher by 0.06 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, Insurance declined 0.86 per cent, PSU Bank (0.82 per cent), Housing Finance (0.76 per cent), Financial Services (0.39 per cent) and Bankex(0.35 per cent). Metal climbed 1.38 per cent, Telecommunication jumped 1.05 per cent, Commodities (0.55 per cent), Realty (0.43 per cent) and Oil & Gas (0.34 per cent).

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | AUGUST 25, 2026

Goyal urges Japanese firms to buy steel from India

RAJESH RAI ■ Tokyo

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Monday urged Japanese firms to source steel from India, saying Indian companies manufacture high-quality products.

He said India imposed only a 12 per cent safeguard duty on low-grade steel compared to higher duties imposed by countries including the US (50 per cent), UK and European Union.

Answering questions on the safeguard duty during a roundtable meeting with Japanese businesses here, Goyal said India has taken a balanced approach by imposing the safeguard duty only on lower grades of steel, and higher grades can be imported freely.

"Those steel products that are manufactured in India, why do you want to import (buy) from Japan?" Goyal said, adding India has extended protection to its domestic industry from the impact of excess capacity in certain countries.

Indian industry has flagged concerns over

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal participating in a fireside chat on the India-Japan Next Generation Economic Partnership in Tokyo, Japan

excess capacity of steel in countries like China.

He said countries across the world are experiencing surplus steel capacity and are consequently taking safeguard measures to protect their domestic industries.

In December 2025, India announced safeguard duty on imports of certain steel products for three years, with the aim to curb dumping from countries like China and protect domestic manufacturers from a supply glut.

The duty, first imposed as a temporary 12 per cent levy for 200 days in April 2025, is in force until April 2028.

The 12 per cent duty was levied in the first year (April 21, 2025 to April 20, 2026), which was reduced to 11.5 per cent in the second year (April 21, 2026 to April 20, 2027), and further it will be lowered to 11 per cent in the third year (April 21, 2027 to April 20, 2028).

"India even today is a net importer of steel. So we have enough scope to expand our capacity, in fact double our capacity and people are investing money. When they are investing money they want protection, so that tomorrow they do not face dumping," he said.

Goyal said he has been

urging Japanese industry over the last seven years to source from India at least those steel products that are competitively priced and meet Japanese quality standards.

"Even if they are cheaper or of the same quality as Japanese steel...somehow they do not buy from India," he said.

Goyal questioned how India could be expected to protect foreign companies from trade measures when they do not support Indian domestic producers by sourcing from the country.

"It's a matter of concern for me, that's not a fair trade," he said suggesting the Japanese firms to approach the Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) on the anti-dumping and safeguard duties related issues.

He also said the safeguard duty is in line with World Trade Organization (WTO) rules.

Goyal is leading a 200-member business delegation here to discuss ways to boost trade and investment ties between the two countries.

UPI marks 10 years with 13,000-fold transaction surge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Unified Payments Interface (UPI), which was launched on August 25, 2016, has completed a decade of transforming India's digital payments landscape, emerging as the backbone of the country's digital payments ecosystem and a global benchmark for real-time payments.

Annual UPI transaction volume rose from 1.78 crore in 2016-17 to more than 24,162 crore in 2025-26, an almost 13,000-fold increase, the finance ministry said in a statement.

During the same period, transaction value jumped

from ₹0.07 lakh crore to around ₹314 lakh crore, representing a more than 4,000-fold rise, it said.

Developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) under the regulatory oversight of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), UPI has recorded an unprecedented expansion in both transaction volume and value over the past 10 years, it said.

The year 2026 marked a significant milestone in the growth trajectory of UPI, it said, adding that monthly transaction volumes crossed 2,300 crore for the first time in May 2026, reaching 2,320 crore transactions, signalling a new scale of adoption.

Rupee falls 3 paise to close at 95.74 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The rupee pared initial gains and settled for the day lower by 3 paise at 95.74 (provisional) against the US dollar on Monday, on a stronger American currency and weak domestic markets.

Forex traders said the USD/INR pair traded in a narrow range as rising Brent crude prices, persistent importer demand, and cautious sentiment over new US sanctions targeting Iran weighed on investor sentiment.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.65, then touched an intraday high of 95.64 and a low of 95.75 and finally settled for the day at 95.74 (provisional) against the greenback, lower by 3 paise from its previous close. On Friday, the rupee settled higher by just 3 paise at 95.71 against the US dollar.

"We expect the rupee to trade

with a slight negative bias on uncertainty between the US and Iran. Elevated crude oil prices may also weigh on the rupee. However, overall weakness in the US dollar on declining odds of a rate hike may

support the rupee at lower levels. USD/INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 95.50 to 96," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 98.98, higher by 0.18 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading lower by 1.62 per cent at \$92.86 per barrel in futures trade. On the domestic market front, Sensex fell 171.72 points to settle at 77,369.11, while the Nifty declined 32.95 points to 24,219.05.

Foreign institutional investors offloaded equities worth ₹542.71 crore on a net basis on Friday, according to exchange data.

India's forex reserves jumped \$9.905 billion to \$716.907 billion during the week ended August 14, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) said on Friday.

Amazon, Flipkart revamp seller fees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

E-commerce majors Amazon and Flipkart have revised fee and penalty structures for sellers on their platforms in the weeks leading up to the festive shopping season, a move that sellers say adds to the financial burden on small and medium enterprises already operating on thin margins.

According to a notice issued by Amazon India on its seller forum, the company has, with effect from August 17, 2026, changed the manner in which it calculates order cancellation fees for sellers using its Easy Ship and Self Ship services.

Under Easy Ship, sellers store their own products, pack them when they receive an order and then hand it over to the Easy Ship Pickup executive, who then ships the product and ensures timely delivery.

In Self Ship, the seller packs and delivers the product themselves, using their own courier or deliv-

ery service, with no Amazon logistics involved.

The fee, which was earlier based on category-specific referral charges, is now computed as a percentage of the order value.

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया

Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: 893/8, MAIN MARKET MEHRAULI, NEW DELHI PO MEHRAULI, NEW DELHI-110030

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the general public that the following 11 lockers were shifted (Cabinet of erst-while Barakhamba Branch received at Mehrauli Branch in M/o February 2018).

The keys of these 11 lockers are missing at Central Bank Of India, Mehrauli Branch Located at 893/8, Main Market Mehrauli, New Delhi PO Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030. These lockers have been inactive for a long time.

Sl. No.	Locker No	Size
1.	271	Small
2.	277	Small
3.	281	Small
4.	284	Large
5.	288	Small
6.	294	Small
7.	306	Small
8.	315	Small
9.	326	Small
10.	337	Small
11.	345	Small

The branch will break the above said lockers on or after one month from the date of publication and auction the items (if any) in it and the amount received will be appropriated towards the outstanding balance of the bank dues. If anyone has any claim in respect of these lockers and has any objection, then all the documents related to the locker can be lodged with the branch/claim in the branch. After this and without documents no claim in this regard will be admissible and the bank will not bear any responsibility.

PLACE: NEW DELHI
DATE: 24.08.2026

By Order of the Branch Manager,
Central Bank of India, Mehrauli, New Delhi

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया

Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: 893/8, MAIN MARKET MEHRAULI, NEW DELHI PO MEHRAULI, NEW DELHI-110030

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR BREAK OPEN LOCKERS

DATE: 25.08.2026

Be it known to the Locker hirers mentioned hereunder and public at large that the following locker holders of this Branch have failed to make payment of the respective overdue locker rent mentioned against their name, despite several reminders given by the bank from time to time on this account. Under these circumstances the Bank is constrained to break open such lockers and hence it is hereby informed that after 15 days from the publication of this public notice, the break opening proceeding will be initiated by the Bank as per Banking rules and regulations in case the respective locker holder(s) fails to make the payment of overdue rent of lockers plus applicable penalty by latest by the 15th day of the publication of this notice. The details of the locker to be broken open are as under:

Sl. No.	Locker A/C. No.	Name	Locker ID	Amount Rent Due (Without GST & Penalty)	Rent Paid Upto	Address
1.	4503928993	Bhagwan Datt Sharma	141	₹ 16,300.00	30/06/2018	H No 341 Ward No-4 Mehrauli , New Delhi - 110030
2.	4503111972	Sharda Gupta	65	₹ 13,978.00	30/06/2019	J 705 Ward No 6 Mehrauli New Delhi-110030
3.	4504180945	Ghansham Mohan	135	₹ 15,100.00	30/06/2019	6/817 A Ward No.6, Mehrauli New Delhi -110030
4.	4501115492	Amit Sondhi Surinder Sondhi	7	₹ 13,348.00	30/06/2020	1073/1 A2 Near Old Po Mehrauli New Delhi -110030
5.	4501168738	Shri Ram Ahuja	148	₹ 13,742.00	30/06/2026	7/956 Main Bazar Mehrauli New Delhi - 110030
6.	4500626100	Har Prashad Sharma	5	₹ 12,643.00	30/06/2021	2/1 Rajpur Khurd Extension, Mehrauli New Delhi -110030
7.	4501147649	Singari Devi	46	₹ 11,729.00	30/06/2021	Qutab Pump House Qutab Minar New Delhi -110030
8.	4504176621	Angoori Devi	124	₹ 12,700.00	30/06/2021	844/6 Main Bazar Mehrauli New Delhi-110030

*The above said Lockers will be broken open due to non-operation of the locker since long time , overdue rent & other issues despite several reminders given by the Bank from time to time. Hence it is hereby informed to all the concerned that they should contact the Locker department of the Branch immediately else after 30 days from the publication of this public notice Bank shall/may go for breaking opening of the Lockers to may further proceed to recover the overdue rent , break opening charges, Costs met out towards publication of this notice and other applicable charges by disposing of the contents of the locker by the laid down procedure without any claim against the Bank and at the risk and responsibility of the locker hirers.

By Order of the Branch Manager,
PLACE: NEW DELHI DATE: 24.08.2026
Central Bank of India, Mehrauli Branch, New Delhi

PROSPECT

HUDCO delivers record financial performance



Housing and Urban Development Corporation Limited (HUDCO), a Navratna NBFC-IFC, held its 56th Annual General Meeting (AGM) through video conferencing, where Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman and Managing Director, highlighted the Company's strongest-ever operational and financial performance despite global economic and geopolitical uncertainties.

Addressing shareholders, Kulshrestha emphasised that urbanisation will be a key driver of India's long-term growth and that HUDCO remains well-positioned to support sustainable, resilient, and inclusive urban development across the country. Further, he observed that as one of the fastest-growing major economies, well-planned cities- major metros as well as Tier-II and Tier-III towns- will be critical drivers of investment, employment and productivity.

Kulshrestha highlighted the growing role of the Urban Invest Window (UIWIN), which serves as a one-stop solution providing end-to-end support to ULBs for infrastructure development. Launched in November 2025 under the guidance of the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, it reflects the philosophy, 'When cities win, everyone wins.' Since its launch, UIWIN has partnered with several States, including Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Bihar, and Odisha.

HUDCO is also strengthening its institutional foundations by leveraging its Navratna and NBFC-IFC status, expanding its participation in PPP projects across multiple sectors, reviewing key policies, advancing asset monetisation and maintaining strong asset quality through proactive risk management.

(PNS)

UNICEF YuWaah hosts dialogue on youth development priorities

Youth Central, the annual flagship event by UNICEF — YuWaah, convened over 100 stakeholders from the Government, private sector, foundations, civil society, and young people for a dynamic dialogue on key youth development issues, exploring key priorities such as — youth centrality, economic opportunities for women, AI and entrepreneurship, internships, disability inclusion, and service-based learning.

Present at the event were Nitesh Kumar Mishra (Additional Secretary Youth Affairs, Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports), Nadi Albino (Acting CEO, Generation Unlimited), Rashmi Verma (Chief Inclusion and Social Impact Officer, SAP), Jesper Moller (Deputy Representative, Programmes, UNICEF

India), Kumar Manish (UNFPA) and Pooja Mahaldar (UNICEF YuWaah Youth Representative).

At the event, UNICEF YuWaah and SAP India unveiled 'The Road to Yutopia: Youth Centrality at Workplaces Framework', a practical guide to help businesses build workplaces that are youth-friendly, inclusive, and future-ready. Designed for organisations employing youth, it offers an actionable roadmap for embedding perspectives and insights from early talent or young professionals across workplace systems, from recruitment and culture to governance and innovation.

The framework builds on Yutopia, a Public, Private, Youth alliance jointly led by UNICEF YuWaah and SAP India, which envisages a future where young people are not only participants or employees, but partners, co-creators, and leaders.

Government to sell up to 6% stake in Hindustan Copper

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government will sell up to 6 per cent stake in Hindustan Copper Ltd (HCL) through an offer for sale (OFS) at a floor price of ₹514 a share. The floor price is at a 10.38 per cent discount over Monday's closing share price of Hindustan Copper on the BSE.

In a post on X, Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) secretary Arunish Chawla said the Government of India



offers to divest 3 per cent equity in Hindustan Copper Limited (HCL) through an Offer for Sale (OFS), with an option to divest an additional 3 per cent (green shoe) in case of oversubscription.

The OFS will open at a floor price of ₹514 per share. Shares of Hind Copper settled at ₹573.55, up 0.17 per cent, on the BSE on Monday.

According to Chawla, 10 per cent of the offer is reserved for retail investors, with an additional 25,000 shares set aside for eligible employees.

So far in the current fiscal, the Government has mopped up ₹52,716 crore through PSU disinvestment.

Three-day CBSE cluster athletics sports meet concludes, girls top performance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

CBSE's three-day Cluster Athletic Meet 2026-27, organised by Kamal Model Senior Secondary School, Mohan Garden, concluded on Monday at the East Vinod Nagar Sports Complex, with girls displaying remarkable performance.

The meet, held under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Khelega India Khilega India," elicited participation of 3,000 athletes from 313 schools.

School chairman Ved Tandon said all the children performed well in the competition. Among the girls, Meera Bobal, Amira Khosla, and Riya Bisht excelled in the long jump. Vivek, Rahul Raj, and Rohit Tomar were the best performers among the boys. The Under-19 girls and boys 1,500m race and the Under-17 girls and boys 1,500m race generated significant excitement among participants and spectators, he said.

The under-14 students of Vasant Valley School, Vasant Kunj, secured first place with 50 points and also performed well in the under-17 competition. Vasant Valley School, Vasant Kunj, won the under-14 girls' championship, with Mahira, a student of the same school, winning the best athlete trophy.

NTPC launches three-month vigilance awareness campaign



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NTPC Limited launched its three-month Vigilance Awareness Campaign 2026 at Scope Complex, New Delhi. Rashmita Jha, IRS, Chief Vigilance Officer (CVO), formally inaugurated the campaign, which will be conducted from 17th August to 16th November 2026 as a prelude to the Vigilance Awareness Week 2026. On the occasion, the CVO also unveiled the revamped Corporate Vigilance Intranet page.

The campaign being conducted under the theme "Probity for Prosperity" will focus on five key areas identified by the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC):

disposal of pending complaints, disposal of pending cases, capacity-building programmes, digital initiatives and contract management.

Addressing the gathering, the CVO urged vigilance officials to enhance the reach, quality and impact of preventive vigilance and outreach programmes during the campaign. She also announced the expansion of the "VAW Volunteer" initiative, with a special focus on engaging women from Self-Help Groups (SHGs) this year.

G Raja Shekhar, Head of Vigilance urged Vigilance Executives to lead by example through integrity and ethical conduct and to become true flag-bearers of the campaign at their respective projects.

Pijush Hazarika attends agriculture business workshop in Guwahati

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Agriculture Minister Pijush Hazarika on Monday attended the State-level workshop on "Strengthening Business Opportunities for Agriculture and Allied Products in Assam", organised by the Agriculture Department at the Srimanta Sankardev Kalakshetra in Guwahati.

The workshop focused on strengthening the business potential of Assam's agriculture and allied sectors and making agriculture more profitable

and market-oriented for farmers.

Addressing around 250 progressive farmers from different parts of the State, Minister Hazarika said that India is an agriculture-based economy and development of the agriculture sector is crucial for the country's economic growth. "Around 150 crore people in our country need food. Therefore, we have a huge domestic market for our agricultural produce. We must take advantage of this opportunity and strive towards self-reliance in agriculture," he said.

FM to leave for 8-day official trip to Canada, US, focus on deepening ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman will embark on an official visit to Canada and the US from August 25 to September 2 to hold talks on bilateral economic and financial cooperation, investment opportunities and global economic priorities, besides participating in the G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors (FMCBG) meeting.



During the first leg of her visit to Toronto, Sitharaman will participate in the inaugural Economic and Financial Dialogue with Canada's Finance and National Revenue Minister Francois-Philippe Champagne, the finance ministry said in a statement.

The dialogue is expected to cover macroeconomic developments, financial sector cooperation, bilateral investment opportunities and shared international priorities, while strengthening the economic and financial pillar of the renewed India-Canada partnership, it said.

In recent months, the two sides have discussed cooperation in areas such as energy, critical minerals, technology, innovation and resilient supply chains, along with ongoing efforts towards a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

Sitharaman will also participate in an investment roundtable with leading business representatives from sectors including energy, artificial intelligence and critical minerals to facilitate greater business-to-business linkages and identify investment opportuni-

ties, including in GIFT City-IFSC. She will also engage with senior Canadian business leaders at another roundtable, with senior managing directors and chief executive officers of Indian public sector banks participating in the discussions to explore greater financial-sector collaboration and investment linkages.

Sitharaman will hold one-to-one meetings with Canadian company CEOs and senior executives on India's growth prospects, investment opportunities and avenues for expanding Canadian business presence in India. Besides, she will also interact with the Indian diaspora in Toronto. The US leg of the visit will cover Chicago, Asheville and New York from August 28 to September 2.

In Chicago, Sitharaman will participate in an investor roundtable and meet with CEOs and senior representatives of private-sector companies to discuss India's investment opportunities, economic outlook, and ways to strengthen business partnerships. She will also visit the Polsky Centre for Entrepreneurship and Innovation at the University of Chicago to exchange views

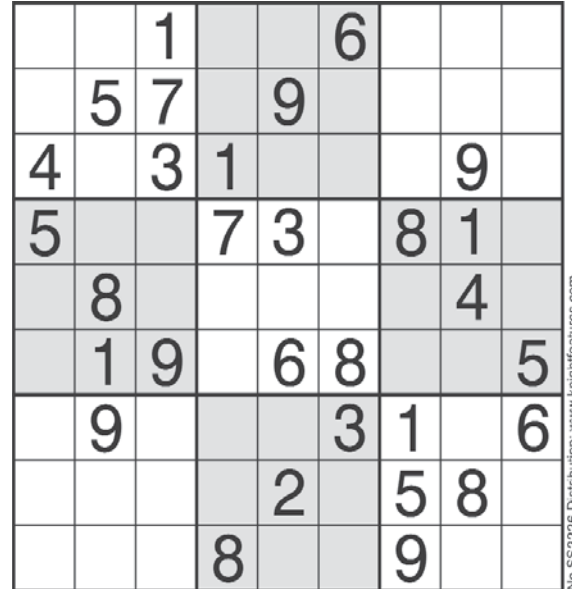
on entrepreneurship, innovation, technology commercialisation and linkages with India's startup ecosystem, the finance ministry said.

The Finance Minister will then travel to Asheville, North Carolina, where she will lead the Indian delegation at the G20 FMCBG meeting under the US presidency of the grouping on August 31 and September 1, it said. The meeting will bring together finance ministers, central bank governors and senior economic officials of G20 members to deliberate on key global economic and financial issues.

India's participation in the G20 Finance Track will provide an opportunity to advance its perspectives on global economic growth and stability, international financial cooperation and challenges confronting emerging and advanced economies, the statement said.

In New York, Sitharaman will participate in an investor roundtable and hold one-to-one meetings with senior executives and CEOs from the financial sector to discuss India's economic and financial landscape and ways to strengthen financial and institutional linkages, it said.

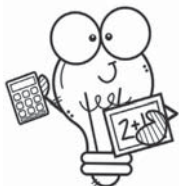
DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

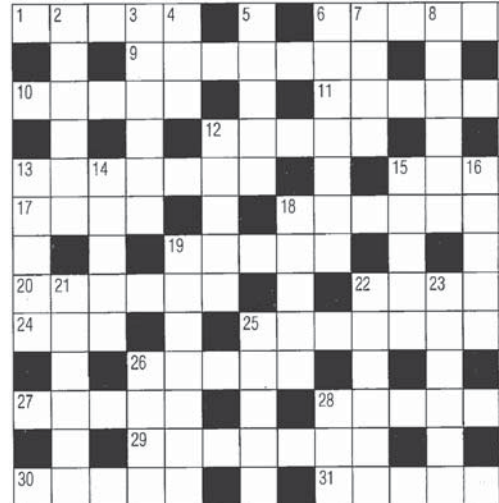
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



SOLUTION (24.8.26)

2	7	5	6	4	8	9	3	1
1	8	6	9	5	3	2	4	7
4	3	9	1	2	7	6	5	8
9	6	2	3	7	1	5	8	4
7	1	4	5	8	9	3	2	6
3	5	8	4	6	2	7	1	9
5	4	1	7	3	6	8	9	2
8	9	7	2	1	5	4	6	3
6	2	3	8	9	4	1	7	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | AUGUST 25, 2026



ACROSS

- 1 Fishy starting price for a rodent race runner! (5)
- 6 She's in the pool (5)
- 9 Jacket, not a twinset (7)
- 10 To Ann, a changed man! (5)
- 11 One-fifth of a ton? (5)
- 12 Port can make you lithe! (5)
- 13 Does it provide but little transportation? (7)
- 15 On his own, Mr Sloan (3)
- 17 Winged wader, once worshipped (4)
- 18 Dignified way to get an appointment (6)
- 19 Lower the cover at the leisure centre (5)

DOWN

- 2 A writer's point (3,3)
- 3 A Spaniard is a handsome fellow (6)
- 4 Actually more than a stone (3)
- 5 They're instrumental in making players puff (5)
- 6 The flier crashed into the back of the helter-skelter! (7)
- 7 Is the number of years for one! (4)
- 8 Is it like a trout swimming around Beach Head? (6)
- 12 A middling meal? (5)
- 13 Watches, as objects (5)
- 14 Another name for Elgin, maybe (5)
- 15 Whole-hearted boat-building is

- 20 What a cloud burst may do when some children go to church (6)
- 22 Fair twins? (2-2)
- 24 Thus a learner can be "King" (3)
- 25 Also in the scheme as a unit (7)
- 26 In her job, many may be on the dole (5)
- 27 Be out till morning, perhaps (5)
- 28 Mystic rites or essays (5)
- 29 Forbear to check out the RAF activity (7)
- 30 Fred gets out of line, but isn't given a roasting! (5)
- 31 Where the Aussies have a Scottish accent? (5)

- forbidden! (5)
- 16 Devilish contributor to pandemonium (5)
- 18 Heave up out of wells, possibly (5)
- 19 Picked up something good for the Editor (7)
- 21 Big wave in possible contact with a coaster (6)
- 22 Enters in the style of Laurence (6)
- 23 The only national theatre near Portsmouth (6)
- 25 Her mother's beautiful, too (5)
- 26 Just a body of water (4)
- 28 A gratuity for taking the rubbish (3)

Pulse of positivity summit focuses on health, wellness



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

The Pulse of Positivity — Health & Wellness Summit Uttarakhand was successfully organised at Fairfield by Marriott, Dehradun, bringing together policy-makers, leading doctors, healthcare professionals, wellness experts, academicians and industry representatives for meaningful conversations around mental health, preventive healthcare, lifestyle choices and strengthening public health awareness.

The Summit was graced by Ritu Khanduri Bhushan, Speaker, Uttarakhand Legislative Assembly, as the chief guest, while Acharya Pratishtha, Director, Mokshayatan Yog Sansthan & President, and Bharat Yoga, joined as the guest of honour. Puneet Anand, AVP & Vertical Head — Corporate Affairs, Corporate Communication & Social, Hyundai Motor India Limited, was also part of the inaugural dais.

The programme commenced with the ceremonial lamp lighting, followed by a welcome address by Vishal Kumar Tyagi, Project Director, Pulse of Positivity, and the felicitation of dignitaries.

Addressing the gathering during the inaugural session, Ritu Khanduri Bhushan emphasised that building a healthy society requires healthy habits to begin early in life. She highlighted the important role of parents and elders in instilling discipline, encouraging healthy eating habits and making children more conscious of their overall health and lifestyle.

Acharya Pratishtha Ji and Puneet Anand Ji also addressed the gathering during the inaugural session, setting the tone for a day of conversations focused on building a healthier tomorrow through awareness, prevention and collective responsibility.

Chief Minister of Uttarakhand, Shri Pushkar Singh Dhami, extended his best wishes for the success of the Pulse of Positivity - Health & Wellness Summit Uttarakhand 2026 and appreciated the initiative towards promoting health and well-being. Shri Madan Kaushik, Cabinet Minister, Government of Uttarakhand, also conveyed his greetings and shared a special video message for the Summit, highlighting the importance of greater awareness around health and wellness.

NBCC to kick-start ₹500 crore projects in Delhi-NCR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

NBCC and HUDCO, two Navratna CPSEs under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, have further strengthened their strategic partnership with the commencement of two major development projects in the Delhi-NCR region. *Bhoomi Pujan* ceremonies for both projects were held recently, marking the beginning of project execution.

The ceremony was attended by Sanjay Kulshreshtha, CMD, HUDCO, and KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, along with Suman Kumar, Director (Commercial), NBCC, M Nagaraj, Director (Corporate Planning), HUDCO, Daljeet Singh Khatri, Director (Finance), HUDCO, and senior officials of both organisations.

The larger of the two projects is the Integrated Office Complex at Sector-62, Noida, Uttar Pradesh, with a project cost of approximately ₹485.20 crore. The project will have a maximum 2B+G+7 configuration with a total built-up area of approximately 82,617 sqm and is planned to achieve a

4-star GRIHA rating, underscoring its focus on sustainable and energy-efficient development.



The second project is the Commercial Development at Kaushambi, Ghaziabad, carries a project cost of approximately ₹34.64 crore. With a B+G+7 configuration, the project covering approximately 6,400 sqm of built-up area is planned to achieve a 3-Star GRIHA rating, reflecting the commitment towards sustainable development.

The two projects are a significant step forward in the strategic collaboration between HUDCO and NBCC. The partnership builds on the MoUs signed between the two organisations earlier, under which NBCC was entrusted with development projects.

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BRIEFLY

Akshay Bhatia finishes tied 12th at BMW Championship



Akshay Bhatia closed the week in style with an eagle-birdie finish, carding a two-under 68 to sign off tied 12th at the 2026 BMW Championship and retain his 15th position in the FedExCup standings.

He was only one of the three Indian-origin players to make the Tour Championships, for which only the Top-30 make it.

Bhatia, who began the week 15th in the standings, produced a strong final round to finish comfortably inside the top 30 and qualify for next week's season-ending TOUR Championship. His eagle-birdie finish provided a fitting close to another strong week in the FedExCup Playoffs.

Overall Bhatia had three birdies and an eagle against three bogeys.

Aaron Rai also signed off with a two-under 68, making four birdies against two bogeys to finish tied 16th. Despite the solid result, Rai slipped two places in the FedExCup standings and will enter the TOUR Championship 39th. (PTI)

Sharma finishes T-46 at Nexo title as Jamieson claims home victory



Indian golfer Shubhankar Sharma finished tied 46th with an even-par 72 at the 2026 Nexo Championship here.

Sharma's final round featured three birdies and three bogeys as he completed the tournament at four-over 292 at Trump International Golf Links. His four rounds were 73-72-75-72. Fellow Indian Yuvraj Sandhu missed the cut earlier in the week. Scotland's Scott Jamieson claimed his second DP World Tour title with a superb final-round 67, finishing at 11-under par and two shots clear of England's Matthew Jordan.

The 42-year-old made it consecutive Scottish victories at Trump International Golf Links in Aberdeenshire, following Grant Forrest's success at the venue last year.

Jamieson began the final round three shots behind overnight leader Shaun Norris but quickly erased the deficit with three birdies on the front nine.

Norris was subsequently handed a two-stroke penalty for breaching Rule 8.1, which relates to actions that improve conditions affecting a stroke, allowing Jamieson to take the outright lead around the turn.

The Scot strengthened his position with two more birdies at the start of the back nine. After dropping a shot at the 13th, he immediately responded with a birdie on the 14th to restore his advantage. Jordan's bogey at the 17th further extended Jamieson's lead to three shots, and a closing par secured an emotional victory on home soil. (PTI)

'Players must defend rapid attacks better after two games without win'

JEROME PUGMIRE
■ Paris

Paris Saint-Germain coach Luis Enrique urged his players to be more "attentive" to rapid attacks after failing to win two games in a row. PSG salvaged a 2-2 draw at Rennes on Sunday thanks to two late goals from substitute Ferran Torres on his club debut. That draw followed a 1-0 defeat to Lens in the Trophée des Champions, the French Super Cup. "(Transitional play) was one of our strengths over the past three seasons, being attentive to that," PSG coach Luis Enrique said after the Rennes game. "There are



certain positions where you need to be sure your position is covered by another player. If you're a little bit distracted, you can have problems."

Both Rennes goals were scored on quick breaks and PSG's transitional play was also exposed when Lens scored the week before.

Hockey WC: India women bow out after draw with Australia

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen (The Netherlands)

Tears flowed freely in the Indian camp after the women's hockey team's hopes of making the World Cup semi-finals ended in heartbreak, following a goalless draw against Australia here on Sunday. As final hooter sounded, veteran goalkeeper Savita Punia and Bichoo Devi, sitting in dugout, broke down. Ishika Chaudhary, playing her maiden World Cup, sat behind them, staring blankly as the enormity of the missed opportunity sank in.

For a team that had dared to dream and looked capable of turning that dream into India's

first medal in women Hockey WC, the campaign ended with tears and heartbreak.

India finished level on points with Australia but were eliminated from semifinal contention on goal difference.

The disappointment was visible on the faces of the players as they walked off the field, many of them red-eyed and struggling to hold back tears before boarding the team bus. For a side featuring 11 players at their first World Cup, the exit was particularly difficult to digest.

Head coach Sjoerd Marijne, who spoke to the media after the match, too could not hide his disappointment, while scientific advisor and head of



athlete performance Wayne Lombard and senior players tried to lift the spirits of the younger members of the squad. One player, sitting on

the stairs and speaking to her mother over the phone, summed up the mood in the camp. "This was best opportunity. We came so close, and

now I don't know when I'll get this chance again," she said.

Savita, playing in her third World Cup, was equally heartbroken. "This was the best opportunity," the player with 318 caps said quietly.

Experienced midfielder Neha Goyal was inconsolable. When reminded of next mission of winning gold at the Asian Games, she could only nod silently. India have never won a medal at the women's World Cup, with their best finish being fourth in the inaugural edition in France in 1974.

Their fifth-sixth place match on August 27 will now give them a chance to have best ever finish after that.

But statistics were not

enough to console the players.

When one player was told that a fifth-place finish would still be India's second best result at the World Cup, she replied: "A medal is a medal, isn't it?" Captain Salima Tete admitted that players were devastated after coming close.

"We're not happy because we came so close. We worked so hard for it. We played well, but couldn't finish," she said.

"We're together in defeat as well as victory. We've learned from this that we shouldn't waste any opportunity. We're playing for fifth place and we'll make a comeback. We haven't given up our fighting spirit, and we won't in this last match either," she said. (PTI)

Nerves cost us against Australia, but I am proud of the team: Sjoerd Marijne

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen (Netherlands)

India women's hockey team coach Sjoerd Marijne admitted nerves got the better of his side in its goalless draw against Australia, adding that reaching the fifth-sixth place playoff at the World Cup is still a significant achievement.

India succumbed to the pressure of a must-win match and were knocked out of semifinal contention after being held to a goalless draw by Australia on Sunday.

"It looked like there were nerves. We didn't play the game we wanted to play. It was not fluent, there was no



rhythm in passing and receiving and there were a lot of unforced errors," Marijne said. "It's not that we can't do it, but I don't know why we couldn't do it. We know we can do much better than this. Everyone is very disappointed."

India will now play the fifth-sixth place classification match, a position Marijne

believes the team can take pride in reaching after making significant progress in recent months. "But if you had said five or six months ago that we were going to play the fifth-sixth position match, nobody would believe us. I also told the girls that we really need to learn from this," he said.

The Dutchman said India's inability to convert their opportunities proved costly in the game. "This was our first setback. We didn't lose and holding Australia to a draw is also a positive, although we needed to win this. In these kinds of matches you have to be there and avail the chances you get," he said. (PTI)

Era of sustained dominance is over: Men's singles enters genuinely open era

AMIT KUMAR DAS
■ New Delhi

Men's singles has entered an unusually open phase, with a deepening pool of contenders making sustained dominance increasingly difficult to imagine, according to several leading players, including new World Badminton champion Alex Lanier of France and world No. 7 Victor Lai.

The evidence is not just in the names at the top of the rankings but in the uncertainty surrounding almost every major tournament. The gap between the established elite and the chasing pack has narrowed considerably, while the physical demands of the modern men's game have made consistency across an entire season increasingly difficult.

"It's a tough question, but I definitely feel that this is a different period," said Lanier when asked whether it is possible to achieve the kind of domination that the old guards such as Lee Chong Wei, Lin Dan or Viktor Axelsen once achieved. "There are more tournaments nowadays, and there are also more good players. We can lose from the first round, and the intensity in the opening round is already very high."

At the World Championships here, that depth has been particularly evident, with India's Ayush Shetty, ranked world No. 22, stunning defending champion and world No. 1 Shi in the opening round or Denmark's World No 26 Rasmus Gemke beating All England champion Lin Chun-Yi and Indonesia's World No 3



Jonatan Christie.

Lanier, who became the first Frenchman to win the men's singles title at the World Championships, said the depth of the field had made it much harder to string together victories week after week. "It is becoming increasingly difficult in men's singles to win one tournament and then win another one the fol-

lower generation, Victor Lai, who said the competitive gap had virtually disappeared beyond the very top.

"Anyone in the top 30 can beat anyone. I've been saying that since I first made it to the top 30. There are no easy matches, and as you saw yesterday, Gemke made it to the quarters, and his ranking is 20-something, so it just proves that anyone in top 30 can beat anyone. It's just how you perform on the day," said Lai, who claimed his second successive World Championships bronze.

Lai, who broke into top 20 in January and rose to World No 7, said the absence of a single defining figure had become one of the defining features of the current men's singles landscape.

"Most people agree that there's no dominant force in

men's singles right now. It's a lot of different players, and anyone can win on any given day. There's no dominant force like Lin Dan, Lee Chong Wei back in the day, so it's really nice that we're all competing for the top spot," he said.

Asked whether one of the current generation could establish that kind of dominance over the next five years, he was skeptical.

"Honestly, I don't think it's possible for one person to be so dominant. We have so many young guys like Alex and I, and Ayush from India, Alwi from Indonesia -- these are just a few, and there's a lot of guys coming up now who maybe we haven't heard of yet, but we will hear soon. I doubt there's going to be one dominant force in the future." (PTI)

No relaxation in Asian Games selection criteria despite pressure: Sports ministry

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Sports Ministry has ruled out the possibility of athletes, who do not meet the Asian Games selection criteria announced a year ago, finding a place in India's Japan-bound contingent despite the "pressure being created" by their supporters. The Sports Ministry has approved a 492-strong contingent of athletes for the September 19 to October 4 Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan. Athletics forms the biggest chunk of 73 names in the list.

A few more additions could be made and approval for them is being awaited from the Olympic Council of Asia. However, the ministry made

it clear that those additions will not be at the expense of flouting the selection criteria that was announced in September last year.

"A lot of pressure was there (on us). Some parents came and said that my child has not been selected. We told them if your child merits selection (fulfils the selection criteria), there is no way that he or she will not be selected," a sports ministry source said.

"Let's take an example. If somebody has to run 10 seconds to be a contender for medal in the 100m event, should we send an athlete who runs 15 seconds? We have set the criteria that if an athlete is in the top six in Asia, we will select him or her, otherwise not. We have followed



that."

In its selection criteria unveiled in 2025, the ministry had made it clear that only those with "realistic chance of winning a medal" would be considered for multi-sport events, including the Asian

Games, through selection trials that would be video-graphed and overseen by independent observers.

In addition, it had also stated that only the top six in continental rankings would be eligible. Because of this cut-

off, the Indian football team was among the earliest to be ruled out of the Asiad due to its plummeting rankings. Sports Minister Manuskh Mandaviya had also asserted a few weeks ago that events like the Asian Games must not be seen as exposure trips by athletes and only the best should be heading to Japan in pursuit of medals.

Finalising the Indian contingent for multi-sport events has never been an easy task. Omitted athletes have even taken the legal route to challenge their non-inclusion.

Recently, equestrian Anush Agarwalla had approached the Delhi High Court against his non-selection but his appeal was eventually dismissed by the Supreme Court.

Norris says his car isn't good enough for F1 title shot but McLaren could fix that

JAMES ELLINGWORTH
■ Zandvoort (Netherlands)

Lando Norris says he doesn't yet have a car capable of vying for the Formula 1 title despite back-to-back Grand Prix wins but he could "win every race" remaining this season if McLaren manages to solve its vulnerability.

The F1 defending champion boosted his title chances with victory at the Dutch GP on Sunday after a daring pass on standings leader Kimi Antonelli in the process.

"I know I've just won two races in a row and had two poles in a row, but at the minute I don't have the car I need to fight for a championship," Norris said after the race. He added that the right



changes to target McLaren's troubles in slow-speed corners could set him up to chase down Mercedes driver Antonelli.

"We're very, very strong in high-speed (corners), and that's the place we've

improved the car the most... No one matches us in high speed, and that's a good thing," Norris said.

However, Norris added that "Mercedes' advantage that they have to us in slow speed is also crazy."

Norris urged McLaren not to get "complacent" and to focus on improving how the car handles in low-speed corners to unlock its full potential.

"If we can improve on these slow speeds, I'm confident that I can win every race this season. If we don't, then it's much more difficult to believe so," he said.

Meanwhile, Antonelli suggested Mercedes is "clearly not the fastest car anymore on the grid." Spending the right money at the right time Exactly how McLaren can go about making Norris' wish come true is unclear.

F1's "cost cap" limits how much teams can spend in key design areas. An earlier upgrade has more time to

take effect but, as the season goes on, teams understand more about their cars and have more chances to copy ideas from rivals.

That means it's a question of how much money to leave in reserve and when to spend it. Mercedes started the year with the fastest car, winning the first six Grand Prix races. Team principal Toto Wolff suggested Sunday that the team didn't have the freedom to spend on major changes and so "the ride has been a bit tougher than at the beginning of the year."

McLaren team principal Andrea Stella has his doubts. He said he was "pretty sure" that Mercedes has some performance-boosting ideas in reserve. (AP)

Pratitee takes sole lead; Mayank stays ahead in Asian Junior Girls Classical Chess title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Top seed Woman Fide Master (WFM) Pratitee Bordoloi emerged as the sole leader in the Asian Junior Girls Classical Chess Championship, scoring a crucial win over Woman Candidate Master (WCM) Aadya Gowda in the seventh round here on Monday.

The victory took Pratitee's tally to six out of a maximum seven points and put her half a point ahead of her nearest challengers.

WCM Shohradova Leyla of Turkmenistan, who was sharing the lead going into the round, was held to a draw by Shivamshika G and



slipped to 5.5 points.

Fide Master (FM) M Prishita Gupta strengthened her title challenge with a victory over WFM Nivedita V C to also reach 5.5 points, joining Leyla in chasing group. WFM Mariya Kholavko of Kazakhstan and WCM Dakshita Kumawat

drew their encounter and moved to five points.

In the Open Championship, top seed Grandmaster-elect Mayank Chakraborty maintained his sole lead after the completion of seven rounds.

Mayank was held to a draw by International Master Vignesh Advait Vemula, but the result was enough to take his tally to six out of seven and keep him half a point ahead of the chasing pack. IM Artem Pigin of Russia was surprisingly held to a draw by Daksh Goyal, while FM Sharnarhi Viresh scored an important victory over FM Amanmuhmet Hommadov of Turkmenistan to move to 5.5 points.

Jurel’s hundred gives India command over SL in 2nd Test

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Colombo

An unflappable Dhruv Jurel allayed concerns surrounding his form with a remarkably composed unbeaten 115 before bowlers struck early blows to give India command of the second Test against Sri Lanka on a rain-hit second day here on Monday.

Jurel’s second Test hundred powered India to a hefty 503 for nine declared in their first innings, and Sri Lanka were reduced to 8 for two at close after pacer Prasadh Krishna and Manav Suthar gave marching orders to Lahiru Udara and Prabath Jayasuriya respectively.

Kamil Mishara was batting on five when the stumps

were drawn at 5.51 pm of an extended session. The hosts are trailing by 495 runs. But the main storyline of the day was given by Jurel, fresh from his 51 in the first innings of the opening Test last week.

If the fifty at Galle broke a barren run of eight innings, Jurel underscored his growing confidence and touch with a near flawless knock at the SSC ground.

India gained immensely from his innings, and the right-hander was also involved in two vital stands - a 112 for the seventh wicket with Rishabh Pant that lifted India from 307 for six to 419.

For the subsequent wicket, Jurel and Manav Suthar added 39 runs that helped the

tourists to further break away from their opponents and close in on the 500-run mark.

However, Jurel’s consistency was the key ingredient in both those partnerships. The 25-year-old’s 177-ball innings was a prime example of risk-free runs accumulation and situational awareness.

At the beginning of the day, Jurel gave full support to Pant, who came out to bat after the early dismissal of debutant Saransh Jain.

At that time, the focus was on Pant because he had to retire on 3 after copping a blow on his forearm by Lahiru Kumara on Sunday.

Jurel understood the circumstances, and gave more strike to Pant, who played a



typical innings of 63, full of chutzpah.

Pant fought gallantly against Lankan pacers during his near two-hour stay at the crease, batting with confidence and little discomfort.

The eventual runs against

his name might have looked good, but Pant had to dig deep to reach that mark.

Pacers Fernando and Kumara targeted his body with a bouncer barrage, and the former even managed to ping on his shoulder once.

However, Pant was equal to the task, either moving away from the line or nudging the ball around.

There was an explosive moment too, when the left-hander got inside the line to hook Kumara over fine leg for a six. Pant, who made a 66 in the second innings at Galle, reached his fifty in 81 balls with a pulled four off off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha.

The wicketkeeper batter celebrated the moment with a thundering maximum off left-arm spinner Jayasuriya.

On the other hand, Jurel reached his fifty in 97 balls, pulling Jayasuriya for a four.

But the partnership of contrast ended immediately upon the resumption after

lunch, as Pant lofted Nuwantha straight to Udara on the edge of the circle.

It left the burden right on the shoulders of Jurel, a 12-Test-old batter. But he showed the knowhow of a veteran batter to tame a delicate situation - for him and the team.

The inclusion of Sarfaraz Khan as an injury replacement for Sai Sudharsan might have also contained a little clue for Jurel to buckle up and score runs, and aced that challenge in flying colours.

True to his strengths, Jurel stayed on the back foot, negating spinners and pacers alike, and there was hardly a moment when he looked out of place while playing a shot.

The only moment of uncertainty came when Jayasuriya appealed vociferously for a leg-before decision when the batter was in 80s, but it was promptly turned down.

The skies opened up nearly 30 minutes before the scheduled tea break, leaving Jurel stranded on 95. After rain break of nearly two hours, Jurel duly completed his hundred with a scamped single off Fernando, and he consumed 171 balls. Off came the helmet and Jurel proudly flashed a tattoo on his biceps to his teammates at the dressing room. The tattoo read ‘Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan’ — the iconic lines spoken by former PM late Lal Bahadur Shastri . (PTI)

Jaiswal, Fernando fined 25% of match fee for heated exchange



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India opener Yashasvi Jaiswal and Sri Lanka seamer Asitha Fernando were on Monday fined 25 per cent of their match fee for an on-field altercation on day one of the second Test in Colombo.

The duo was also handed a demerit point each.

The players were involved in a confrontation after Fernando dismissed Jaiswal in the 17th over of India’s first innings. Jaiswal walked towards Fernando and the two exchanged words, following which Fernando moved his head towards Jaiswal. In response, Jaiswal leant in, resulting in their heads making contact.

“Both players admitted the offences and accepted the sanctions proposed by Andy Pycroft of the Emirates ICC Elite Panel of Match Referees, so there was no need for formal hearings,” ICC said in a statement.

“Both players were found to have breached Article 2.12 of the ICC Code of Conduct for Players and Player Support Personnel,

which relates to “inappropriate physical contact with a Player, Player Support Personnel, Umpire, Match Referee or any other person (including a spectator) during an International Match.”

“In addition to this, one demerit point each has been added to the disciplinary records of Fernando and Jaiswal, both of whom did not have any previous offences in the preceding 24-month period,” the statement added.

Before start of play on day two, Jaiswal had defended his actions saying “If you don’t know what he said then please don’t make your judgment if anyone cross the line we need to let them know this India will fight and reply”.

On-field umpires Ahsan Raza and Sharfuddoula Ibne Shahid, third umpire Rod Tucker and fourth umpire Prageeth Rambukwella levelled the charge. Level 1 breaches carry a minimum penalty of an official reprimand, a maximum penalty of 50 per cent of a player’s match fee, and one or two demerit points.

Batting with Pant is terrific experience, I seek his advice: Jurel

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Colombo

Dhruv Jurel’s Instagram bio is simple yet catchy. It reads Mamba Mentality - a term coined by basketball legend Kobe Bryant to describe his efforts to become the best version of himself.

Jurel’s unbeaten 115 on the second day of the second Test against Sri Lanka here on Monday was a testimony of his devotion to that motto.

At one end, Rishabh Pant, with whom he built a 112-run stand, was playing in his archetypal way for 63, but Jurel concentrated on his strengths to accumulate runs. Jurel explained his batting methods while batting alongside a sparkling shot-maker like Pant.

“We all know Pant is such



India’s Dhruv Jurel celebrates his century on day two of the second Test cricket match between India and Sri Lanka, in Colombo, Sri Lanka on Monday

parents. But does he get tempted to copy the dominating ways of Pant?

“As you can see, Test cricket has different ways of playing, and it makes the game beautiful. When you play with Pant, it’s a very terrific experience. I can’t play like him, the way he has been playing since childhood. “My game plan is to see which bowler should I take down, which spell should I play, and I always ask Pant because he is a wicketkeeper, I am a wicketkeeper, and we play in the middle order, so it’s a very good experience. The wicketkeeper batter also offered a fitness update on Pant, who did not do the stumper’s duty towards the end of the day. “Right now, he got a hit

on his right shoulder, and we are closely monitoring him. Today I did wicketkeeping, because his shoulder was a little bad. Hopefully, I think he will be fit tomorrow,” he said. After batting solidly for 99 runs, Jurel’s 100th run was a scamper and dive for a single.

The 25-year-old saw the lighter side of it. “So actually, till 99, I was getting runs, and on 99, he (Asitha Fernando) started bowling good lengths, and Sri Lanka started fielding well too.

“So when I played that shot (a straight punch off Fernando), it was going over the head of the bowler, and I thought, there is some gap from the fielder, but as I saw he (fielder) coming close I was like - Oh! What have I

done,” he smiled.

After reaching the hundred, Jurel made a salute and displayed a tattoo — Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan — on his biceps. “My grandfather was a farmer, and my father was a soldier. So, those are my roots, and I don’t want to forget them. So, that salute should go to my father and grandfather,” he said, and added that touring this country with India A helped his preparations.

But Jurel did not forget to thank Mohammad Siraj for blocking 29 balls, giving him a chance to complete his century. “Siraj, whenever I speak to him, I think he celebrates more. It’s good thing about him was that his defending was solid. It was good,” Jurel said. (PTI)

PM Modi to address country’s youth ahead of National Sports Day

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will address the youth of the country, including sportspersons, across more than 1500 locations on Thursday to mark the occasion of the National Sports Day which falls on August 29.

Modi’s virtual address will be part of the nationwide programme ‘Khelo India Samvaad - Khel Ki Baat, PM Ke Saath’, a major initiative of the sports ministry to be held two days ahead of the National Sports Day.

Hockey legend Dhyan Chand’s birth anniversary, which falls on August 29, is celebrated as the National Sports Day in the country.

“Key excerpts from the

Hon’ble Prime Minister’s Independence Day message on Sports and Youth Power will also be showcased. This will be followed by the virtual address of the Hon’ble Prime Minister to the youth across the country,” Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya said during a media briefing.

“Through this initiative, youth, athletes and educational institutions are being brought together at 1,500+ locations across the country.

“IITs, IIMs, NITs, AIIMS, premier medical colleges and universities, along with other leading educational institutions, are participating in this nationwide campaign.” He said the programme is a major effort to create a direct dialogue between sports-loving youth



and India’s policymakers, providing young people with an opportunity to share their ideas, experiences and suggestions.

The programme will begin with a welcome by MY Bharat volunteers, followed by a special video presentation

capital, the celebration will be held in four-five locations, including one at the IIT, Delhi, where Mandaviya will grace the occasion. “I will be present at the IIT Delhi for the celebrations (on August 27),” the minister said.

Leading former and current Indian athletes and international medal winners, including Indian Olympic Association President PT Usha will also interact with the youth of the country.

Other prominent sportspersons who will interact with the youth include Manika Batra, Deepa Karmakar, Saina Nehwal, Gagan Narang, Sreejesh, Mary Kom, Baichung Bhutia, Pullyela Gopichand, Anju Bobby George, Karnam Malleswari, Mirabai Chanu,

and some cricketers.

“They (the youth) will share their journeys, challenges, failures, successes and sporting experiences with young participants,” Mandaviya said. “The objective of the event is to inspire young people with the belief that a champion’s journey does not begin in a grand stadium, but with a small field and a first attempt.” Members of Parliament, Members of Legislative Assemblies, Union Ministers, Ministers of State and State Sports Ministers will participate in the programme.

“These elected representatives and dignitaries will engage with youth and seek their ideas and suggestions on the four key themes,” he said.

England drop Carse for second Test against Pakistan as late-night incident investigated

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

England pacer Brydon Carse was dropped on Monday for the second cricket test against Pakistan following the latest off-field incident to affect the national team.

Images on social media showed Carse in police handcuffs outside a nightclub in Derby on Saturday night, following a game with his club side Durham.

The England and Wales Cricket Board said in a statement that Carse will be replaced in the squad by Sonny Baker for the second test, which starts on Thursday.



“Following a referral from the ECB, the Cricket Regulator have confirmed that they will investigate events on Saturday night in Derby,” the ECB said in a statement on its website Monday. “Brydon Carse will no longer be available for selection for the Second men’s Rotherhay test match while this investigation is ongoing

and the full facts are obtained.”

The Cricket Regulator independently investigates matters where there is an allegation of a breach of the ECB’s regulations. Outcomes include no further action being taken, a caution or a charge for breaching regulations.

The incident came just days after the midnight curfew imposed on the England men’s cricket team was scrapped under newly appointed captain Joe Root.

That restriction had been put in place by England managing director Rob Key after controversial late-night incidents on the winter tours of New Zealand and Australia.

Ibrahim Zadran to lead Afghanistan against India in T20I series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kabul

Ibrahim Zadran was on Monday named Afghanistan captain for their upcoming three-match T20I series against India, with the opener taking charge in his first assignment as the team’s full-time T20I skipper.

The series will be played at the Feroz Shah Kotla in New Delhi from September 13 to 17 and is Afghanistan’s “home series”.

Afghanistan have also welcomed back veteran fast bowler Naveen-ul-Haq, who returns to the national setup after recovering from a stress fracture in his right shoulder.

The injury had ruled him out of Afghanistan’s T20I

series against the West Indies and the T20 World Cup 2026.

Naveen’s comeback bolsters a pace attack that also features Fazal Haq Farooqi, Abdullah Ahmadzai and all-rounder Azmatullah Omarzai.

Afghanistan have opted for a full-strength squad, with experienced all-rounder Gulbadin Naib also returning to add depth to the middle order and provide another bowling option.

Rashid Khan will lead an experienced spin-bowling group that also includes Noor Ahmad and Nangyal Kharoti, while senior all-rounder Mohammad Nabi adds further experience and balance.



Uncapped wicketkeeper-batter Noor Rahman has been included as the second wicketkeeper alongside Rahmanullah Gurbaz following his performances in domestic cricket, the Shpageeza Cricket League and at A-team level.

ACB CEO Naseeb Khan said the board had focused on

selecting a well-balanced and fully prepared squad for the series.

“The Afghanistan Cricket Board has always made every effort to select a well-balanced and fully prepared squad for all relevant competitions.

“We have followed the same approach for the

upcoming series against India, and I hope the Afghanistan team will deliver an outstanding performance in these matches,” he said.

The Afghanistan team will travel to India soon for training and final preparations ahead of the series.

Afghanistan squad: Ibrahim Zadran (C), Rahmanullah Gurbaz (WK), Noor Rahman (WK), Sediqqullah Atal, Darwish Rasooli, Azmatullah Omarzai, Gulbadin Naib, Mohammad Nabi, Rashid Khan, Nangyal Kharoti, Noor Ahmad, Muejeb Ur Rahman, Fazal Haq Farooqi, Abdullah Ahmadzai and Naveen-ul-Haq. Reserves: Ijaz Ahmadzai, Shahidullah Kamal and Fareed Ahmad Malik.

Hockey WC: India’s slim hopes of reaching semifinals end with loss to Argentina

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ Amstelveen

India’s men’s hockey team failed to overcome the pressure of conceding an early goal and saw its hopes of reaching the World Cup semifinals end with a 3-5 loss to Argentina here on Monday.

After losing to the Netherlands in their previous match, India were almost out of the race for the last four from Pool E. However, Argentina’s victory over England had technically kept

their qualification hopes alive.

India needed to win by at least three goals to advance, but conceded twice in the opening six minutes and struggled to recover. Poor passing, frequent loss of possession and a leaky defence compounded their problems.

India did manage to score twice within a span of two minutes late in the match, but by then it was too little, too late. The Netherlands have already qualified for the semifinals from the pool, with the second semifinalist to be



decided by the final pool match between England and the Netherlands.

Argentina, which defeated India 8-0 and 4-2 in the FIH Pro League in Rourkela earlier this year, continued its dominance. Joaquin Toscani (1st minute), Nicolas Della Torre (6th), Tomas Domene (33rd, 45th) and Lucas Toscani (53rd) scored for Argentina, while Sukhjeet Singh struck twice (10th, 58th) and Hardik Singh converted a penalty stroke in the 59th minute for India.

With this defeat, India

remained fourth in the pool without a point from three matches and will now play for seventh or eighth place.

India needed to win by at least three goals to keep their semifinal hopes alive, but Argentina put them under pressure from the start, scoring in the 39th second. Toscani received the ball on the right and fired it into the net, giving Indian goalkeeper Mohit HS no chance. In the third minute, a mistake by Jarmanpreet Singh during the circle gifted Argentina their first penalty

corner. Mohit brilliantly kept out Tomas Domene’s flick before the Indian defenders cleared the danger.

Argentina doubled their lead in the sixth minute. The ball deflected off an Argentine striker’s stick and struck Yashdeep, earning them another penalty corner, which Nicolas converted to put his side firmly in control.

India responded with greater urgency after conceding twice and pulled one back four minutes later through Sukhjeet. Abhishek set him up

from outside the left side of the circle, and Sukhjeet fired a powerful diagonal shot into the net. Argentina came close to scoring again in the 15th minute when Ibarra Ignacio took the ball and passed it to Ruiz Tomas, who then passed it to Toscani, but this time Mohit blocked the attempt.

The score was 2-1 after the first 15 minutes. Neither team scored in the second quarter. Although India created some chances, their own mistakes prevented them from finishing. (PTI)